

GIOVANNI VERGA

EROS

A novel

TRANSLATED FROM THE ITALIAN

E R O S

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Translated from the Italian

FROM THE 1884 TREVES EDITION

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TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Giovanni Verga's *Eros* first appeared in 1874–75, during the years he spent among the salons of Florence and Milan, before the great Sicilian novels that made his name. It is one of the so-called *romanzi mondani*—society novels of passion, idleness, and fashionable ruin—through which he learned his craft and, already, began to judge the world that had received him.

The story follows the Marchese Alberto Alberti from a childhood of elegant neglect through a life spent being loved more easily than he can love. Adele, his cousin; Velleda, her brilliant friend; the Contessa Armandi, older and more experienced: each in turn seems to promise a destiny, and each is used up by a temperament that analyzes feeling until feeling dies. The title is ironic. What the book finally represents is not love, but the failure to love—and, in the last pages, the quiet victory of death.

This English version is translated from the fifth edition (Milan, Fratelli Treves, 1884), a public-domain text as established on Wikisource. It does not include the introductions, chronologies, or critical notes of later copyrighted Italian editions. Names and titles have generally been left in Italian (*Marchese*, *Contessa*, *Belmonte*); place-names familiar in English appear as Florence, Milan, Turin, Leghorn.

The translation aims at a literary English of the same century as the original: not a gloss, and not a modernization.

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CHAPTER I

Toward four o'clock on one of the last nights of Carnival, the Marchesa Alberti, seated before the mirror and somewhat pale, was looking at herself with tired, absent eyes while her maid dressed her hair for the night.

"What noise is that?" she asked after a long silence.

"The Marchese's carriage."

"So soon!" she murmured, stifling a yawn. The maid was about to close the door of the little sitting-room that led into the Marchese's apartments, when a man in masquerade dress entered abruptly, with an unsteady step and a haughty brow.

"Is Cecilia asleep?" he asked without stopping.

"I left her just now, Signor Marchese," replied the maid, poorly concealing her surprise.

"Ask her if she can grant me five minutes."

He remained motionless, his brow furrowed, his gaze fixed before him. The maid, returning, lifted the heavy velvet portière; the Marchese took a few steps toward the door, glanced by chance at a large mirror that stood facing him: he seemed to hesitate an instant, then shrugged his shoulders, knitted his brows, and entered with his cigar in his mouth.

The Marchesa was reading, turned toward the wall: hearing his step she closed the book, and asked without moving her head:

"Is it you?"

“Yes.”

She raised her eyes toward the clock hanging on the wall.

“It is half-past four,” replied the husband to that mute and significant interrogation, chewing the cigar between his teeth.

Cecilia stifled two or three little coughs, and said to him:

“Give me that little bottle there on the table, I pray you.” He threw the cigar into the fireplace, and did not move.

Then the Marchesa turned toward him, with a sudden movement that modeled the bedclothes upon the most elegant figure of a woman; she passed a hand whiter than the cambric that fell along her arm over her thick chestnut hair, and fixed upon her husband’s face her great dark eyes, wide open.

He stood upright, motionless, serious—too serious for the clothes he wore—and still had a light coating of powder on his hair and face; he must have been young, aged before his time, pale, blond, elegant, somewhat bald.

“You have something to say to me?” asked the Marchesa after a brief silence.

“Yes.”

“Sit down, then.”

He cast a glance over the chairs and the sofa, encumbered with gowns and feminine implements, and answered dry as dry: “Thank you.”

“I beg your pardon for my maid,” said the wife, blushing imperceptibly.

Alberti barely inclined his head.

“Pardon me rather this importunate visit. I wished to speak with you... this evening.”

Cecilia cast him a rapid, penetrating glance, and asked:

“Have you lost?”

"I have not played."

"You are fighting...?"

"Yes."

She grew pale.

"Reassure yourself," added the Marchese. "I am not fighting with Conte Armandi."

She sat up in the bed, red in the face, her hair loose, and her corset undone: "Why do you tell me that, sir?"

"Because my friend Armandi is a famous swordsman, and you might have been anxious for me."

The woman remained looking at him with extraordinary firmness.

"Why do you fight?"

The husband smiled—a grotesque smile on that impassive face—and answered quietly:

"For you."

The Marchesa passed her handkerchief over her lips.

"Galli had a rather loose tongue and claimed to have seen you at La Scala, in a domino, in the box of my friend Armandi."

"Were you at supper?"

"Yes."

"Ah, you fight for a poor jest at dessert!" she said, smiling bitterly.

The Marchese looked at her fixedly. Then with the most indifferent air in the world he took a domino that was on the nearest chair, threw it upon the sofa, and sat down facing her. "Forgive me," he added; "I could not allow my wife to be calumniated."

She bowed, too deeply and ironically perhaps, and therefore all the blood rushed to her face:

"Everyone knows that Galli is jealous of you because you stole Adalgisa from him!"

“You know that too?” replied the Marchese, crossing one leg over the other.

“Pardon me, women’s weaknesses!” she said, a little pale, and trying to smile.

“And men’s, if you like,” added the husband with gallantry.

There was a moment of silence: she toyed with the opening of her corset; he swung the crossed leg: they avoided looking at each other.

“Now, since I confess that I am concerned not to lose my life, and I shall do my utmost to put a hole in my adversary’s, tomorrow at twelve I shall have crossed the frontier.”

She raised her eyes to him, and listened in silence.

“I wish to spare you all the little inconveniences of my absence, and I should like therefore to settle by common accord the administration of your dowry...”

Cecilia did not answer.

“I shall leave you a power of attorney so that you may collect for yourself whatever sum you think fit...”

“Will you be away long?” the Marchesa interrupted abruptly.

“I do not know myself.... and if you wish to suggest the figure....”

“Do as you think best.”

“But I... frankly... should divide it in equal parts, as between good friends.”

She, paler than the sheet that covered her, inclined her head.

The Marchese rose, lit a cigar at the candle, and at the moment of leaving added with the same air of unconcern:

“It would remain for us to come to an understanding about Alberto’s education, in case my absence should be indefinitely prolonged; but the best, it seems to me, is to conform to the prescription of the law. You will occupy yourself with him until he is

seven; afterward I shall take charge of him.” And he was already turning his back.

“How do you wish your son to be educated until he is seven?” asked the Marchesa in an unsteady voice.

The husband stopped short, and seemed to reflect an instant. “Well!.. as you like...” he added then. “If I gave you any suggestion I should do you an injustice. And now forgive me the inconvenience, and good night.”

Cecilia remained motionless, mute, pale, her eyes fixed; but at the moment when he was about to pass the door, she exclaimed, with a sudden and stifled accent, as if all the blood had rushed impetuously to her heart: “Sir!...” He turned. “Sir!...”—and the words failed her. “Speak to me frankly, in God’s name!...”

He saw the tears that glistened in his wife’s eyes, without batting an eyelid. Instinctively she drew back, frightened by the cold and incisive gaze of that man who seemed to seek out her horrible anguish even in the most hidden folds of her heart, to contemplate them with that pale and glacial face.

“You seem to have told me enough. I fight with Galli because he has insulted the Marchesa Alberti, and Armandi will be my second. I leave for abroad, I leave you half of your income, my name, and our Alberto until he is seven. But my cigar is poisoning your room. Good night.”

He did not turn, and she said not a word.

Passing through the anteroom he heard a bell ringing in the Marchesa’s rooms.

CHAPTER II

The young Marchese Alberti was educated far from his own people, in the Spartan manner, at the Cicognini College. His father had died outside Italy, having scarcely known him. The Marchesa, always young and elegant, the most beautiful Tuscan woman there was in Milan, went to visit him once a year, when there were the races in Florence, embraced him, caressed him, brought him sweets, and got back into her carriage smiling. — She was seized with a pleurisy on leaving La Scala, and died before her friends had had time to send for her son from Prato. The poor little orphan was then twelve years old, and religiously preserved the few letters that his papa had written him, and the boxes of sweets that his mamma had given him. Once he had hung his head, all ashamed, when his friend Gemmati had said to him: “And why does your papa never come to see you?” — Another time he had blushed because certain strangers who were visiting the college had shown that they knew him as the son of the Marchesa Alberti, and then he had blushed at having blushed. His mother never spoke to him of his father. — Of all these things he remembered later.

The first unrests of the heart cast into his mind the fatal germ of self-examination.

At sixteen Alberto was a tall, delicate youth, with blond hair, an aristocratic profile, a little cold and hard, his father’s marble pallor, and the great blue eyes, the fascinating and most mobile smile of his mother—a heart that opened wide as a double door, a vivid imagination, affectionate but restless, wandering, we might say nervous, a

mind more acute than penetrating, analytical from restlessness and from weakness of character—a mind that slipped through your fingers at every instant—said his professor of philosophy—apt to make him seek the decomposition of unity, or to give him the worst troubles of life when the heart should mix itself in the business. He had taken early the habit of thinking, like all solitaries. Later he had a friend, Gemmati, for whom he had a lover's tendernesses and jealousies, even to sulking with him when he learned that he smiled at the barber's daughter who lived opposite. — Long afterward, and in very different circumstances, while he sat beside the fire, his eyes fixed on the flame, and his lips contracted over his extinguished cigar, the memory of that ridiculous jealousy of his childhood flashed through his mind with the strange caprice of reminiscences. — He threw away the cigar, and rose paler and more frowning than before.

He had done his studies quietly at college until that age; he had passed through languages, through numbers, through the analysis of word and thought; at sixteen he had become a dreamer, fantastic, hypochondriac, and he felt that he loved for the first time, because all the poets spoke of love. Then, triumphant in mystery, he showed in secret to his friend Gemmati the first faded flowers that his little cousin had given him, or that he had stolen from her; "Do you love Adele?" Gemmati asked him, who was himself a little related to the girl. "Yes!" answered Alberto, turning red. "How so, if you almost never see her?" "When I think of her I feel as if I were going mad;"—and it was true; for he lent her all the amplifications of his fancy, but when he stood beside her, once a year, he remained dumfounded next to that beloved who proposed that they play at shuttlecock.

At twenty he left the college more a child than when he had entered it; that is to say with no exact notion of life, with many fancies in his head, and certain wild and preconceived judgments, in which he persisted with the obstinacy of a man who pretends to know the world from books. The director of the college let all these ugly

truths transpire from a fine letter that he wrote to Signor Bartolomeo Forlani, Adele's papa, Alberto's maternal uncle, adding that the nephew had not succeeded in passing the last year's examinations, despite his fine mind. The uncle, who was his guardian into the bargain, and was just returning from settling accounts with his nephew's steward, replied thanking as best he knew how and could the Signor Director for the excellent success of the young man—a letter that put the good director's back up; as if one meant to make a fool of him, and it was nothing of the kind! — He wrote also to his nephew, inviting him to come to Belmonte, the name of his villa on the Pistoiese mountain, and went all festive to inform his daughter of the approaching arrival of her little cousin, whom the Signor Director wrote had become a fine young man, and stuffed full of talent. The girl, who no longer played at shuttlecock, blushed; her papa did not notice; he added that, according to the latest leases, the cousin's farms yielded thirty-two thousand lire net, and went off rubbing his hands.

At Belmonte they awaited this fine young man, of whom the Signor Director spoke so well, and who had thirty-two thousand lire of income.

CHAPTER III

As Alberto had his friend Gemmati, Adele also had her school friend, the Contessina Manfredini, who had come to stay with her for a few weeks. The two friends walked on the terrace overlooking the road that led to the villa, holding each other embraced, laughing and twittering like merry little birds. The sun was setting behind the Apennines; the mountains were outlined with a vague violet transparency against the warm tints of the west; the air was embalmed with a thousand summer fragrances; a thin mist rose from the bottom of the valley where the torrent could be heard murmuring; the oxen that had been there to drink climbed the slope slowly, browsing the grass here and there, and making their bells sound from time to time.

The two girls, silent for some time, stood leaning against the balustrade of the terrace, and looked on idly.

“Is your cousin coming this evening?”

“Yes.”

And after a brief pause:

“Is your cousin blond?”

“Yes.”

“Tall?”

“Yes.”

“Is he handsome?”

Adele smiled, and bowed her head.

Her friend turned toward her, looked her in the face, and said slowly:

“Do you love him?”

“Oh!...” exclaimed Adele, drawing back abruptly, and turning to fire.

Words have the value that he who hears them gives them. All the virginity that was in the girl’s heart seemed to start at that question. The other, who was two or three years older than she, embraced her tightly, face against face, rocking together with her on the railing, with a movement of inimitable grace, and whispered softly in her ear: “Do you love him?”

She turned suddenly, red as flame, and stamped a kiss upon her cheek.

“And does he love you?”

Adele answered without raising her head: “I do not know.”

“Come now!”

“He has never told me.”

“Certain things there is no need to say.”

“Then how does one know?”

The other looked at her, laughing: “He must love you very much, because you are truly pretty!”

“How beautiful you are!” exclaimed Adele, throwing her arms around her neck.

A carriage was approaching rapidly; the handsome youth inside raised, half timid and half smiling, his great blue eyes toward the terrace, made a somewhat embarrassed salute, cast a festive glance, and blushed slightly.

“How tall he has grown!” exclaimed Adele under her breath, clutching, without knowing why, at her friend’s dress.

“He is a fine young man,” said the other.

“He had a cigar in his mouth, did you see?”

“He is not elegant, but he has a distinguished air. He is a Marchese, is he not?”

“Yes, he will be here in a moment.”

Velleda raised her head with a movement imperceptibly haughty, coquettish, and graceful at the same time, and began to whip the lowest twigs with a switch she had in her hand.

“If I were as beautiful as you!” exclaimed Adele ingenuously, perhaps struck by that rapid flash of vanity, or perhaps answering the thoughts that crowded into her mind.

Her friend was indeed a magnificent blonde, an aristocratic and delicate beauty, modeled like a Venus, and graceful as a fashion-plate, with thick, soft ashen hair, great blue eyes, and dewy lips; beneath her gray gloves she hid nails of steel, tinted with rose; her little boot seemed animated by impatient tremors, and with that high heel, with that elegant curve, it had an air of gentle arrogance, as if it felt that it made blessed the grass it trod: her smile was fascinating, her gaze deep and a little haughty, her accent caressing, her dress had artful simplicities, and her blonde-lace modest coquetties—this was what that girl was who whipped the twigs with a willow switch, and who was called Velleda, in the same way that she was blond, that she was capricious, that she was elegant, and that a fine hothouse flower has a fine foreign name. She seemed to overwhelm the virginal grace of her friend with the mere proud carriage of her head, or with a single one of her fascinating smiles. Adele was thin, delicate, a little pale, so white that she seemed diaphanous, and that the smallest veins showed through with a vague bluish shading; she had great turquoise eyes, thick black braids, white hands a little too tapering; the wind, enamored, modeled her clothes upon her slim and gentle little body like a statue of Hebe; her movements had a certain caressing and feline elasticity; beside all this an almost savage timidity, a

thoughtless smile, and sudden blushes. A connoisseur would have guessed in the modest and almost childish grace of the girl the approaching blossoming of a beauty such as to rival that of the proud blonde; but Alberto was not a connoisseur, and when his little cousin ran to meet him stretching out her hands and greeting him with her most graceful blush, the blond hair, the silk dress, and the queenly glance of the other flung themselves, I would say, at his head, in a flash. Poor Adele! if she could have heard the buzzing of all those restless hornets that were awakening in Alberto's mind, while she believed she was making a proper introduction, saying: "My cousin! Signorina Velleda!"

Signorina Velleda made a fine dancing-school curtsy, and Alberto remembered it writing that same day to his friend Gemmati: "If you had seen with what grace, as she bowed, she swept her dress back!"

Velleda went on ahead, still toying with her little switch as with a riding-whip, a little like a capricious child, a little like a graceful coquette. At the turning of an avenue she disappeared.

Adele, who was chatting with her cousin all joyful, blushed suddenly, and Alberto noticed it.

"What is it?" he asked her.

"Papa knows nothing of your arrival.... I am trying to see him."

Papa could see them perfectly well from his window, and was rubbing his hands.

At the recollection of his uncle the young man grew dark in the face, and thought of the examinations that had come to nothing. But the uncle, who was the best uncle in the world, embraced his nephew tenderly as if the latter had no black balls on his conscience; indeed at table there appeared a certain flask of old Chianti, of that for great occasions, and if they had let him, the uncle would have made his nephew burst with indigestion, to prove his tenderness. Adele was talkative and taciturn at the wrong moments, Signorina Manfredini

easy and full of spirit, Alberto a little embarrassed, a little absent, and from time to time he had certain assaults of gaiety that rose to his face, glistened in his eyes, and resolved themselves into bizarre effusions of affection for Uncle Bartolomeo.

“The beautiful moon!” exclaimed Adele, appearing at the window. “Shall we not go into the garden?”

Velleda, interrogated in that way, began to laugh.

“You go too,” said the uncle to Alberto, who made no show of moving.

“And you, uncle?”

“What do you want me to come and do there? I have my newspaper to digest. Go along.”

CHAPTER IV

The two girls burst into the garden, merry and noisy; the moon seemed to flood them with a pale radiance, drew bluish reflections from Adele's hair, gave something vaporous to Velleda's, glistened on the silk, played with the shadows, cut itself among the bushes, drew the paths sharply in white; the sky was clear, slightly blue; the gay voices and the merry peals of laughter had crystalline sonorities.

"I am tired!" said Adele, letting herself drop onto a seat, and she gathered her little dress, turning toward Alberto with a tacit invitation; he who was chatting thoughtlessly fell suddenly silent.

"I have forgotten my little shawl," said Velleda with singular liveliness.

"I will go and get it," answered Alberto, eager.

The girl could not conceal a little malicious smile.

"Thank you, do not trouble yourself," she answered, and ran off.

Adele had drawn aside to make room for her cousin beside her; but he began to walk back and forth, casting from time to time greedy and embarrassed glances at the seat.

"Will you sit down?" she said.

"No.... thank you, do not put yourself out."

"What!"

She began to pluck the leaves of the rosebush. Alberto now crossed one leg, now the other, looked at the trees, the path, the tips of his boots, and did not know what to do with his hands.

“Will you permit me to smoke?” he said after a long silence, and as if he had made a great discovery.

“Do, by all means.”

He, triumphant, lit a cigar, and set to puffing the smoke with emphasis.

“Does the smoke bother you?” he asked her.

“No,” answered Adele, coughing and rubbing her eyes.

And they were silent again.

“A beautiful evening!” exclaimed Alberto at last, with his nose in the air.

“Beautiful indeed.”

“It is a trifle cold!”

“A trifle.”

“It is a long time since we have seen each other, you know!”

“Two years.”

“That is true.”

She was looking at him very seriously.

“You have learned to smoke!” she said to him at last with a smile, and as if she were confiding a secret she had been hiding for some time.

“What would you have, vices are easily learned,” answered Alberto with gravity.

“But the cigar becomes you!”

He looked into her great turquoise eyes that glistened in the moonlight, quickly lowered his own, and blew his nose. Adele was reducing to the tiniest pieces the leaves she had plucked from the rosebush.

“But your garden is very beautiful,” said Alberto at last.

The young girl looked around, as if she were seeing those trees and those paths for the first time, and answered:

“Yes, very beautiful.”

“A delight!”

“A true delight. That fountain there I had made.”

“Really!”

“Yes, is it not pretty?”

“So pretty!”

“It is all of marble, you know!”

“Oh!”

“Papa did not want it because of the expense....”

“It must have cost a good deal!”

“I should think so! But Papa is so fond of me!”

“Oh!” (in another tone).

“And of you too, you know, he is fond of you!”

The dialogue that was walking on stilts threatened to stumble on that little pebble.

“He said he would keep you here until November,” added Adele, seeing that her cousin remained silent.

“But...”

“Does it displease you?”

“No.... no!...”

“Will you not be bored?”

He turned, looked at her, then began to shake the ash from his cigar with his little finger. Adele remained somewhat pensive, the poor child, and added, a little trembling: “You will be glad to stay!”

“Just imagine!”

“Velleda will stay until November too! What a feast!”

The cousin felt himself damnably ridiculous for not knowing how to put forth the paltriest compliment.

“Do you like my Velleda?” Adele resumed.

“I?....”

“Is she not beautiful?”

“Oh yes!”

“She too said that you are a handsome young man.”

At those words it seemed to Alberto that the moon irradiated Adelina with a halo.

“You too have grown beautiful!” he said with the courage of gratitude.

“Really?”

“Really.”

She smiled, bowed her head, crossed her pale little hands on her knees, and the moonbeam seemed to turn vermilion upon her cheeks!

The nightingale was singing; a breath of breeze passed that made the leaves rustle lightly; they felt themselves one beside the other. All at once the girl burst out laughing.

“Today I wanted to address you formally, you see!”

“Why?”

“Because you have grown so tall: I felt shy of you.... that was it!”

“Oh!”

She turned toward him, with a sudden movement of expansion and abandonment—pure feelings and virgin souls have such innocent boldnesses—and he drew aside modestly.

“But if you had been formal with me I should never have forgiven you!”

“Why?”

“Because.... because... I do not know why.”

They both fell silent, and they felt that that silence dominated them. Alberto was wholly intent on smoking, and Adele on pricking her hands on the rosebush. One heard the rustle of her dress at every movement of hers.

“The last time you left for college it was raining, do you remember?”

“Yes, you wrote to ask me how I had arrived.”

“You remember that too?”

“I still have the letter.”

“Really?”—she blushed and turned her head.—“And Velleda who does not come back!”

“I think I see her down there.”

“Velleda!”

“Oh, you are still there!” cried Velleda from afar.

“We were talking of you, you know!” exclaimed Adele, running to meet her, and throwing her arms around her neck she whispered something in her ear.

“Naughty!” murmured Velleda, bowing her head and turning red.

“Silly goose!” muttered Signor Bartolomeo when he learned of it.

At eleven all the lights of the villa were, or seemed, extinguished. Alberto, who stood at the window, like one who needs to take into his heart all the serene beauty of a summer night, thought he discerned a thread of light that filtered between the slats of the shutter of a window on the ground floor, facing his own. He leaned out to see better; but the light suddenly grew brighter, as from the vanishing of an interposed shadow, and went out almost at once.

CHAPTER V

The next day, as soon as Alberto opened the window and leaned his elbows on the sill, with his fine meerschaum pipe in his mouth, he heard himself called by name.

He turned his eyes under the pergola, and saw a fresh little face and two beautiful eyes that smiled at him; his little cousin was gathering flowers from a shrub somewhat taller than she, and was rising on tiptoe to bend the reluctant twigs; the sleeves of her dress fell along her arms a little too delicate, but white as alabaster; the gayest ray of sun gilded those arms and that gentle face.

“Good day, cousin!”

“Good day, little cousin!”

“It is nine o’clock, you know!”

“I know.”

“And are you not ashamed?”

“And what are you doing there, so early?”

“You see, I am making nosegays.”

“For whom?”

“For Papa.”

“And then?”

“For Velleda.”

“And then?”

“And then... for whoever deserves them.”

He lifted his nose in the air, sent forth a great puff of smoke, and said: "It is a beautiful day."

"Yes," answered the girl, dry as dry.

Adele went to and fro among the trees, stooping at every instant over the flower-beds with a childish and graceful vivacity that was all her own. Alberto watched her in silence. From time to time she too looked at him without letting him perceive it, with a certain little spiteful air.

"Have you slept well?" she asked at last.

"Very well, thank you."

"And do you wish to sleep still?"

"No.... why?"

"Come and help me, then!"

"I am coming at once, little cousin."

Seeing him come she set herself with a great show of business to sorting the flowers, and the young man felt evaporate in an instant the great audacity with which he had almost asked her for a nosegay.

"Papa has gone up there, to la Sassosa, for the vintage."

"Oh, really?"

"This year we shall have a famous vintage!"

"Yes?"

"The steward said so!"

"He would know."

"And Papa is pleased.—Do you like this flower?" Adele resumed then, leaping from one subject to another.

"Pretty! what is it called?"

"I do not remember; it is a foreign name."

"It must be a rare flower!"

She was about to answer, but she saw that her cousin was looking more at the hand than at the rare flower, and she blushed.

“What a beautiful flower-bed!” he said, so as not to be perceived.

“Do you know what there was here before? the little square where we used to play at shuttlecock! Do you remember?”

“How it has changed!”

“You too have changed,” she answered without raising her eyes.

He answered after an instant: “And you too.”

And they both smiled.

“Let us go and wake Velleda, the lazy thing!” said Adele, all red in the face.

The ground-floor windows were not very high from the soil, but the poor girl rose in vain upon the tips of her little feet: “You knock,” she said to Alberto. He gave two timid little taps.

“Who is it?” they heard answered by a voice which still had something sleepy and voluptuous in it.

“It is my flowers, come to bid you good morning, sleepyhead!”

The slats of the shutter opened a little; the sun’s rays slipped in with a certain avidity, and drew themselves in luminous stripes upon a beautiful white figure, upon the rosy arm that leaned on the sill, upon the gold-colored hair, lightly waving, that fell softly upon the dressing-gown. Velleda brought her face close to the shutter, and her beautiful eyes were seen to glisten; but catching sight of Alberto she drew back abruptly, and shut it altogether, saying:

“I am coming at once.”

“Will you not have it?” asked Adele, a little vexed, of Alberto, who remained with his eyes fixed on the closed shutter, without perceiving the nosegay that his cousin was giving him.

“Then I deserve one too?” he said, smiling.

“Presumptuous!”

Passing under her cousin's window, Adele raised her eyes, and stood looking at it.

"Do you see how beautiful that jasmine is that climbs up to your sill?"

"Why do you sit up so late in the evening?" she resumed after a brief pause.

"How do you know?"

She blushed.

"...They told me so," she answered.

That blush made vanish in a flash from Alberto's mind the graceful apparition he had caught behind the shutter, and which still glistened in his thought, as a ray of sun still radiates, even after it is closed, in the pupil it has dazzled. He raised his eyes to that window facing his own, where the evening before he had thought he saw a light, hesitated an instant, but did not open his mouth. He seemed to feel her arm tremble, and vague fugitive blushes pass, with an alabaster transparency, over the beautiful face she held bent, and over her delicate neck.

They had sat down under the pergola. She spoke to him with that sweet speech of the Tuscan girl which resembles the twittering of a little bird; she smiled, blushed, toyed with the puffs of her dress and with the leaves of the pergola; she was all festive, and turned at every moment to see Velleda appear, who never came. The shadows of the foliage seemed to caress her, alternating the light upon her face; the little breeze, from time to time, made the hem of her dress trail lightly over his feet. He breathed deeply, almost with voluptuousness, and smiled; she breathed likewise and smiled. "Why?" she asked him, still smiling.

"I feel my lungs expanding."

"It is the mountain air."

"How well it does one!"

“Is it not true?” and they were silent.

“Do you like the country?” she resumed a little later.

“Yes.”

“Will you be glad to stay?”

“Most glad.”

“I like it so much!” she exclaimed, clapping her hands, all smiles.

“Do you like to sit looking at the moon from the window?” asked her cousin all at once and abruptly, as if answering an insistent thought.

“Yes....”

“I too!” and he grew pensive.

“Does it not seem to you that one would love the moon?” he resumed then, with certain eyes that glistened singularly; “and that that sweet light should rain upon your face like dew, and refresh your blood, and caress your hair, and that the stars should sparkle like enamored eyes, and that the night breeze should kiss, murmuring, the leaves and the flowers, and that the blades of grass should stir in graceful embracements, and that your glances should seek up there, in that pale light, the glances of the woman.... that is, you, of the man....”

He got entangled, stammered, the emphasis boiled away, and he was silent, blushing; she did not answer; at first she had opened her eyes wide at that outburst; then she had bowed her head, her face on fire; she had drawn a little aside, and had felt her heart heavy with I know not what sighs.

“Shall we go and find Velleda?” she said after a few moments, lifting upon him her beautiful embarrassed eyes.

He followed her. “Oh, the pretty little flower!” exclaimed the girl; her cousin picked it up and gave it to her.

“Thank you!” she said, “but my nosegay is beautiful too, is it not?” and she began to laugh. At that moment they had arrived under her window. “Is that your window?” asked Alberto, with a slight tremor in his voice.

“...Yes...” answered Adele. “Here is Velleda, at last!”

And she threw herself into her arms, covering her with kisses; she took her by the hand, and began to run with her.

“Why do you run so?” Velleda asked her.

“I feel I have wings,” she said, “and I should like to fly!”

CHAPTER VI

That evening Uncle Bartolomeo returned late from the Sassosa; there was no talk of walks in the garden, and the lights were put out early at the Villa Forlani. Alberto stood for several hours in vain at the window, hoping to see again that certain light behind that certain shutter; but the shutter remained modestly closed, as the long lashes of a maiden are lowered when one speaks to her of love. It seemed to him that that thread of light would have irradiated his heart with all the aureoles that dwell in a sweet confession, that that closed window was thinking of him, and that behind those shutters Adelina must start, as he did, at the rustling of those leaves which the little breeze stirred softly, or that she must be blushing, feeling her face caressed by that same perfume of jasmine which caressed his face as well. — Sweet dreams of twenty years, which the storms of life set fluttering now and then over a man's heart, even when the smile of skepticism has wrinkled his lips.

Uncle Forlani had proposed an excursion to the Sassosa; the impatient horses were shaking their bells, and the young girls kept them waiting. At last Adele appeared, a little pale, and with a dewy smile. The moment she saw Alberto she turned crimson.

"Good-day, cousin!" She smiled at him sweetly, and held out her hand, warm and feverish.

"Always the last!" said Velleda, laughing, as she came running down, drawing on her gloves. "My hat would not hear of staying in place! What is the matter? How pale you are!"

"I slept ill," answered Adele, flushing again.

Alberto felt his heart leap in his breast.

Uncle Bartolomeo came up in time, as if he had had an intuition of delicate situations.

"Come, children, the sun is already high."

"How beautiful you are today!" said Velleda to Adele when they were alone.

A week passed in this manner. Velleda more than once surprised her friend with her eyes full of tears: "What is the matter?" she would ask.

"Nothing; my heart is too full."

Uncle Bartolomeo, as a man who knows how to manage things, had prepared a pleasant surprise for his nephew. The following Sunday Gemmati also arrived from Pistoia, and in the evening there was a great gathering at the Villa Forlani. Neighbors came, the notary Zucchi with his Signora, and three or four others. The evening passed rapidly in such pleasant company. Alberto, beside his friend, was merrier than usual, and even noisy; Gemmati was a handsome young fellow, a little coarsely cut, but jovial, witty, and likable; Velleda, who knew how to be bored with grace, like a well-bred young lady, pounded on the piano whatever they wished; Adele showed the album to Signora Zucchi, and turned the pages for Velleda; Alberto helped her now and then, to have the pretext of standing near her, of touching her dress or her hand in turning the leaves; then he sulked at her because she was gay and thoughtless, did not try to look him in the eyes, talked with the first comer, and avoided having their hands meet; he went and sat down on a sofa, his face overcast, launching fiery glances at her from time to time. Adele, who saw all this maneuvering as girls see it, out of the corner of her eye, enjoyed it thoroughly.

Signora Zucchi, who laid claim to the elegance of a provincial lady of fashion, gave herself a great deal of trouble to appear at her ease, and was always in motion, now boring Signor Forlani, who was playing chess with the notary, now interrupting Velleda while she played, now playing the child with Adele, or the coquette with Gemmati; at last she sat down upon the sofa where the young Marchese was, making a thousand little graces to attract the attention of the handsome blond, who sat tucked into the other end of the sofa, with a certain face that might have made one believe he was angry with Signora Zucchi.

One of the neighbors had brought a great piece of news: the Contessa was expected at the Villa Armandi — the beautiful Contessa Emilia — it was said.

“The beautiful Contessa cannot be so very young any longer!” said the elegant Signora Zucchi.

“All Florence talks of her, and more than one has done mad things....”

“Much obliged!....” answered Signora Zucchi, settling herself virtuously upon the sofa. “If that is all!....”

Signor Forlani coughed; Velleda struck a crashing chord that was not marked upon the music, and Adele opened her eyes very wide. The notary too muttered prudently: “Hum! hum! not all the madmen are in the hospital!....”

Velleda had left off playing; Gemmati was talking with her in an undertone; she listened, smiling now and then at the edge of her lips. Then Gemmati had drawn near Adele and had set himself to talking with her. Alberto felt I know not what vexation, nor did he himself know against whom, but he watched his cousin askance, who did not occupy herself with him as he would have wished; at last he rose and went to place himself beside Signorina Manfredini. She lifted her

eyes from the photographs, fixed him with a queen's assurance, so that he was the first to lower his eyes.

"Your friend is a pleasant young man," she said to him.

"Very pleasant."

She went back to turning the leaves of the album; the young man sought Gemmati with his eyes, and saw him by the fireplace, talking with Adele, who was laughing like a little mad thing; he flushed, and made an abrupt movement to go away; but instead of taking the door that was behind his back he found it shorter to go round by the garden to reach his room, and so had to pass so near his cousin as almost to give her a shove with his elbow.

"Are you going?" she asked him in surprise.

He answered with an accent out of Othello: "Yes!"

"Why?"

"I am sleepy," he answered brusquely.

"What a handsome young man!" exclaimed Signora Zucchi, not so low as not to be heard by Adele, and observing her with gossiping curiosity; the girl, too naïve to be distrustful, flushed with joy, continuing to stare at the door through which he had gone.

"Is he Signora Cecilia's son?" asked the notary.

"Yes," answered Signor Bartolomeo; "he has thirty-two thousand lire a year in fine farms."

"And yet the late Marchese!..."

"And the late Marchesa too, unfortunately!..."

"But let us not speak of the dead. That boy has been fortunate at least in having an uncle like me... I do not say it to boast, but he would not even have enough to pay for the pride of the title."

"And yet he does not seem at all cheerful!" observed Signora Zucchi.

"What have you done to him?" whispered Velleda in Adele's ear.

"I?... nothing, I swear to you!" answered the girl, blushing.

With a very heavy heart she went to look for the cousin who was fleeing her, and found him on the terrace, his elbows resting on the balustrade.

"What has happened?" she asked him timidly, placing herself beside him like a shadow.

"But nothing has happened!"

She had not the courage to insist, and was silent.

There was a branch of acacia in flower beside them; she plucked two or three little blossoms and offered them to him with a gentle gesture. He, at feeling himself touched by her hand, started.

"Do you know the meaning of the acacia?" he asked her with a certain disturbance in his voice.

Adele turned the color of live coals, and signed no with her head.

"Truly?"

"Truly!"

"So much the better!" he added, smiling.

The girl ran into the house and flew to Velleda's ear.

"What is the meaning of the acacia?" Adele asked in an undertone, redder than Signora Zucchi's dress.

"So we have already come to this!" exclaimed Velleda, laughing.

"Tell me what it means."

"It means a rupture...."

The young girl would hear no more, and returned to the terrace, trembling. Her cousin held in his hand a spray of flowering vanilla. "See," he said to her, "I am not as unkind as you!" — and he gave her the flower. She put it in her bosom, and with a graceful and modest daring snatched the acacia blossoms from his buttonhole, flung them from the terrace, and fled. Alberto saw her, through the panes, walking on her friend's arm; the two girls were talking in an

undertone, and smiled now and then. All at once Adele turned toward the balcony and kissed the flower he had given her. It seemed to the young man that those panes irradiated with light.

He felt himself drawn toward her by the strongest enchantment he had ever known; but she seemed to avoid him, she looked at him with a certain embarrassment; when he approached her she made instinctive abrupt movements, as if to flee, and remained hesitant, like a frightened bird that beats its wings. All this made her so beautiful that Alberto was fascinated by it; in that moment all the attractions of life, of youth, and of love were for him in that pale little face and under that modest gray dress that trembled like leaves stirred by the breeze. Velleda was close by, blond, elegant, graceful, with all the rustle of her silk, with the Chinese perfume of her embroidered handkerchief — he was aware of it.

“Adele, I wish to speak with you,” he said to her in a trembling voice. The girl, a little reassured at seeing him so moved, answered ingenuously:

“Let us go into the garden.”

“No.... tonight, when everyone is asleep.... when you hear three knocks at your window.... it will be I....”

She, surprised, was about to ask him the reason of all those mysteries which she did not understand, when Alberto interrupted her quickly:

“Hush! they are watching us!”

And he walked on with the wary ease of a conspirator in a melodrama.

Velleda had stopped to adjust a ribbon, and Uncle Bartolomeo at that instant was wholly intent on making his guests observe that the evening was most beautiful.

Alberto seized Gemmati by the hand, at the moment when he was about to withdraw to his room, and led him with him into the garden.

“Tonight I shall speak to her!” he said in his ear, in a stifled voice.

Gemmati stopped to look at him in surprise, and answered him gently:

“Why this madness? Do you not see her always? Can you not speak to her when you wish?”

“No!... it is not the same thing.... You do not understand me.... you cannot understand me.... you do not love her as I love her.... Have you seen her? How beautiful she is! is it not true?”

“Yes, she is a little angel.”

“Velleda too is beautiful, perhaps more beautiful.... in a different way.... everyone says so.... and sometimes, seeing them one beside the other, even I.... But why does Adelina seem to me more beautiful?”

“Because you love her.”

“And why must I love her and not Velleda, who is at least as beautiful as she?”

“Why, because she loves you.”

CHAPTER VII

One o'clock had struck some time since when Alberto opened his window, now delightful as it preceded the first rendezvous, now full of voluptuous agitation and of inexplicable anxiety. Adele's window was closed: what a singular physiognomy that dark window had, and how it looked at him! He hesitated a few instants, like every Caesar about to cross a Rubicon, then jumped down upon the grass with the heart of a thief who is forcing a door for the first time; the silence was profound, and the young man had made not the slightest noise in falling upon the tips of his toes; the leaves of the arbor rustled scarcely at all; he stopped, uneasy, looking about him, his ear strained, as if the least sounds came from his uncle blowing his nose or taking snuff; then he advanced with a wolf's tread to beneath his cousin's window. It was a question now of striking those three famous knocks, promised when three hours still remained before they were to be struck, when his heart, under her eyes, beat more loudly, and the chatter that reigned in the drawing-room made one suppose they would be innocent. All the poetry of romantic meetings, of silken ladders, and of mysterious signals, vanished before the fear of hearing Uncle Forlani cough. He felt that he was afraid, and then that confession which he was forced to make to himself infused him with courage. When he knocked those three lightly, it seemed to him that he had awakened all the echoes of the mountain and all the uncles in the world.

How many palpitations in that minute while the window delayed in opening! how many palpitations when he heard it unclose little by little with a circumspection that confessed the sin aloud! A luminous streak designed itself upon the grass of the flower-bed, and Adele's pretty little nightcap showed itself timidly; she was trembling a little; the moon, which had risen late, lit the wall opposite and cast back a livid, gentle glimmer upon her candid face, which smiled with ineffable embarrassment, and looked here and there, without daring to raise her eyes to him. Certainly they had said enough to one another; but the cousin, hard pressed by that eloquent silence, began:

“How good you are, Adele!”

She opened her great eyes wide, and asked with graceful ingenuousness:

“Why?”

“Because you have consented....”

“Did you not ask it of me?...”

“Yes.... but at this hour you would be asleep.... and instead I....” Adele made a certain little smile and answered:

“No, I was not sleepy.... I have not been sleepy for several nights.”

“Since when?...”

“You are very curious, cousin!” she said to him after an instant's hesitation.

The cousin, without opening his mouth, looked her for the first time in the eyes with the love of a man; she lowered hers and laughed no more.

“Are you quite sure that they are all asleep?” she asked him a little later, answering without knowing it to that look.

“Yes; for more than an hour not a single light has been seen.”

She withdrew her hand abruptly. A silence followed that gave her courage and made her smile: "Well," she asked him, "here I am; what have you to say to me?"

"I wanted... I wished to ask your pardon."

"For what?"

"I have been unkind..."

She shook her head slowly: "No."

Alberto would have preferred reproaches, so as to have room to beat about the bush; he no longer knew what to say, and remained embarrassed.

"Do you hear the nightingale?"

"No, it is the solitary sparrow."

"What a delicious night!"

She did not answer.

"What are you thinking of?"

"Of nothing."

"Do you not feel happy?"

"... Yes!"

"What time is it?" the girl asked after a few instants, as if she were waking.

"It must be half-past one..."

"It is late, you know!"

"Do you wish to go?"

"Yes" — and she did not move.

"Why did you say that you had been unkind?" she asked him, smiling very softly.

"Because... it is useless now that I should tell you... you have forgiven me!" And he set a great sigh for a full stop.

She began to look at the moon, saying so many things to it with her eyes.

Then, quickly, as if starting:

“Good-bye! good-bye! It is late, good night!”

“Adele!...” exclaimed Alberto as she was about to close the window. “Adele!” — She appeared again, but all trembling, as if she had heard quite another accent in his voice. He hesitated. — Then the girl fixed her shining eyes upon his face — the young man felt all the modest daring, all the avid reticences that were in that virgin look, and said: “I love you! that is what I wanted to tell you!”

Adele turned white hearing that word which she had awaited for an hour.

“Forgive me!” Alberto resumed, troubled by her silence. “Has it displeased you that I said it? Forgive me, Adele! But speak, tell me at least a single word, for the love of God!”

“Why do you speak so formally to me?...” murmured the girl in a thread of a voice.

“Ah! how good you are, Adele! You are as good as you are beautiful! See, to speak to you now without that formality seems a delight to me! You knew nothing! You never noticed anything! I have loved you a long time, you know! Ever since I was at the boarding-school; but since I have been near you I love you as... I should not know how to tell you myself... See, in this moment... it seems to me that my heart is about to leap from my breast... I should like...”

The girl let fall into his hands the spray of vanilla that she had put in her bosom. Alberto seized those little hands and kissed them with ardor.

“How beautiful you are!” he exclaimed, looking at her with enamored eyes. “How I love you!”

Indeed she was beautiful as an angel in that moment; love irradiated like a kind of aureole from the blush that covered her, from

her uncertain and modest smile, from her lowered eyes. There was so much light in those eyes that when she fixed them upon Alberto's face it seemed to him that two stars dazzled him.

He spoke to her in agitation, with that first rush of the love that had wandered until that day among the nebulae of imagination; he told her of what he felt in his heart, of what he had thought, of what he had dreamed, of what he had done, of the years spent at the boarding-school, of the timid joys, of the bitterness stifled, of the mother he had lost, as she had lost hers, of that first evening when he had sat down beside her, of what he had seen in the trembling light of the stars, irradiation of unknown worlds, of that vague sentiment of a We scattered throughout all creation, of those ethereal aspirations toward a word without human voice, which had concentrated themselves in her, and which flooded his heart, all at once, at the mere contact of her dress. He felt himself immensely happy; it was the first time that he spoke of love, and that a girl stood listening to him. — She listened avidly, indeed; rather she drank the young man's virgin and enthusiastic love in the sparkling of his eyes, and in the passionate vibrations of his voice. Her poor little hands trembled like leaves in his. — "Do you love me?" he said to her with one of those accents that penetrate to the bottom of the heart. She signed yes with her head two or three times, without daring to look at him.

"And you will love no one but me?"

The young girl fixed him with the limpid and frank look of the virgin, and answered with naïve wonder:

"Could you love another?"

"No... no!..."

"Well then?"

He remained thoughtful an instant.

"And will you love me always so?"

“Always, and I will teach your children to love you so!” answered the girl with sublime candor.

Alberto was silent, his face darkened, and he avoided looking at her; he had felt as it were a stab; the frank revelation of the chaste maternal instinct that revealed itself in the serene eyes and the naïve smile of the virgin, overthrew the artificial poetry of his heart, made him fall from the stars among which he was poised, and made him think. — “What is the matter?” Adele asked him, seeing him overcast.

“The matter is that I wish to be loved by you, and not by my children!” he answered, giving vent as he could to his ill humor. “The matter is that I love you, and not... The matter is that I love you, because I love you.. without thinking of anything else... Love me so, Adele! Let us love each other for the sake of loving each other... because otherwise... you know...”

“What?”

“We might doubt ourselves... our intentions... we might doubt our love...”

Just when Alberto was about to unfold all his theory of a pure, poetic love without children, a sneeze was heard at the window above, which was Uncle Bartolomeo’s. Adele fled like a frightened fawn; Alberto made himself very small, and slipped away like a cat along the wall. It took a good half-hour before he could decide to climb back in through the window, after having assured himself that not a living soul was heard to breathe, and that his uncle’s window was truly closed. Yet he was tormented all night by the doubt, combined with the sneeze he had heard, that that certain shutter had not always been half open, as he had seen it on going in — and not a cursed breath of wind had blown all the evening. The next day he would have wished himself a hundred miles away rather than appear in the presence of his terrible uncle.

Toward eight o'clock he was about to steal off quietly, on the pretext of going hunting, when the servant came to look for him, just on his uncle's behalf.

"I am coming at once," answered the nephew, who would more willingly have gone to the devil.

CHAPTER VIII

At the sight of his uncle's patriarchal face and broad jovial smile, the young man felt better, and tried to smile himself. His uncle had a mountain of papers on the little table, and his spectacles on his nose.

"Were you about to go hunting?" he asked amicably.

"Yes, my dear uncle," stammered the young man with tenderness.

"Forgive me, but I have a serious discourse to make you." Alberto felt himself growing small again. His uncle's spectacles dazzled his sight.

"But I shall be done in a trice," Signor Bartolomeo resumed. "I have put everything in order this month past; you will have only to cast your eyes over the accounts, and I hope you will be content with your uncle."

Alberto breathed freely, and answered that he was most content.

"You shall see what order, what scrupulous exactness! If I had always administered, by this time you would be.... Enough! one does not speak ill of the dead. These are the tax papers... the expenses... the balances... the account of the guardianship... Listen to me."

"But, my uncle!... how can you think!..."

"No! no! my boy.... These are delicate affairs.... I am mixed up in them.... It is a matter of guardianship!..."

Alberto, who understood nothing whatsoever, and who had besides in his body the remorse of that little business of last night, entirely lost his head merely at casting his eyes over those long strings of

figures, and let himself be dragged by the hair through a labyrinth of debit and credit, receipts, payments, allowances, legal acts, miscellaneous expenses, etc., approving with his head, or giving vent to protests of confidence and gratitude. After a couple of hours of that torture he came to know that Uncle Bartolomeo, out of the thirty-two thousand lire of income, had made, during his guardianship, an economy of 5,876 lire and 97 centesimi — over and above all the expenses and the board paid regularly to the Cicognini College — of which 5,876 lire and 97 centesimi he had sent his nephew 2,000 lire while he was still at Prato, and without so much as a line of receipt, and the remaining 3,876.97 lire he was delivering at that moment. Needless to say, without wishing to hear so much as a word of indemnity — the idea! — as if they were not of the same blood at all! Alberto reminded him vividly of his poor Cecilia! indeed he would not even have the 3 centesimi of surplus returned.

The nephew, for all his inexperience, felt vaguely that his thanks came with difficulty, and that he remembered the sneeze of the night.

“Now, once and for all, it is well to put ourselves in order by way of a notary with a good quittance.”

Alberto did not breathe a word, and signed everything that his uncle and Signor Zucchi put under his hand.

CHAPTER IX

Gemmati had gone to Pistoia for a couple of days. Alberto had accompanied him a stretch of the way; then he had returned on foot, by the shortcuts that climbed the slope, flanked by flowering hedges. The path came out upon the carriage-road, a few steps from the villa's gate, to bury itself again, after another hundred paces or so, among the thick trees that continued to climb with the little hill. The two girls were about to set foot upon it when he arrived from the other side upon the high road; they turned at the sound of his steps, and uttered a prolonged oh!

"Did I frighten you?"

"Afraid of what?" said Velleda.

"Yes, you did frighten us," answered Adele, laughing.

"Shall I accompany you?"

"Where shall we go?"

"Why.... wherever you like," answered Velleda to her friend's question.

"If we went back to the house?"

Signorina Manfredini made no observation, turned about, and began to walk toward the gate, leaning on her parasol, with that haughty indifference which had earned her the nickname of the Princess.

"You know, it was nothing!" Adele said to her cousin, without daring to look at him.

Velleda preceded them without affectation along the great avenue of the garden, turning now and then to ask a question, or stopping to gather with the same interest a flower or a blade of grass. The two cousins followed her one beside the other, chatting between themselves, but without walking arm in arm. Adelina was a little pale, she had certain fleeting blushes, certain bursts of gaiety, like a fullness of life that had concentrated itself in the heart: she walked slowly, as if she were tired, with a certain caressing softness, answered him in a voice full of a sweet sonority, and smiled at him without raising her eyes, with a veiled smile.

Entering the drawing-room Velleda freed her magnificent blond hair, taking off her broad straw hat, and tumbled into it all that heap of grasses and flowers she held in her lap.

“What do you want to do with them?” Adele asked her.

“The most beautiful bouquet — you shall see!”

As soon as they were left alone the cousin took the young girl’s hand, and said to her: “How beautiful you are!” She smiled at him without raising her eyes.

The sun made the window-panes sparkle, and flooded the girl’s face with golden motes. She worked in silence, her head bent over her embroidery, and her hands, which labored with a feverish impatience, told the beloved young man all those things that her lips kept silent. — They had been speaking to one another for half an hour without opening their mouths — he with the glances that the girl felt rest upon her hair like a kiss — she with that silence, with the sudden blushes that passed over her delicate nape, and with the slight trembling of her hands.

“Adele!” — Alberto murmured at last in a voice scarcely intelligible — she started — “are you angry with me?” — she sought two or three times the hole in the canvas where the needle should go, and stammered:

“Why?”

“Because you say nothing to me...”

“I am listening to you,” answered the girl ingenuously.

“Do you love me?”

Adele lowered her head until it almost touched the work she had in her hands, and the blood ran like a flame through all her veins.

“Give me something of yours!...”

“I have nothing!...”

The cousin took the little scissors; she perceived it, grew slightly pale, left off working, and waited, her head bent, trembling. He took one of those little curls that fluttered upon her neck, and cut it.

“Oh!” exclaimed the poor girl, whose hands trembled strongly.

“Did I hurt you?”

“... No... I have pricked my finger...”

Several days passed of tumultuous joys, hidden in two hands that met by chance, and of sighs overflowing with happiness, of provocative blushes and modest audacities, of monstrous dissimulations, that would have opened even a blind man’s eyes, and of most skillful subterfuges, which no one made a show of guessing — seeking one another with their eyes, speaking with their hands, caressing one another with the sound of the voice, breathing love and the beloved with the air, with the perfume of the flowers, with the ray of the sun, and with the song of the birds. — Velleda, as if she alone saw clearly, showed herself as little as possible. Gemmati was at Pistoia; Uncle Bartolomeo rubbed his hands looking at the fine weather that favored the abundant vintage. It was a paradise. — To the young lover it seemed that he lived in a delicious ecstasy that was not without voluptuousness, a subtle voluptuousness, almost ethereal, that stole exquisitely through his most hidden fibres, and multiplied a hundredfold the pleasure of certain sensations. His heart abandoned itself softly to it; he desired nothing more, he would not have dared to

seek further; all the joyous phantoms that had peopled his youthful dreams, woman, love, happiness, were gathered in her, in her smile, in her voice, in the warmth of that little dress that creased a little too much upon the breast and the delicate shoulders; when Velleda's proud train rustled upon the carpet near him, or her elegant tresses caressed his glances with their beautiful blond, he looked with pleasure, as if that other beauty, instead of being a subtraction from Adele's attractions, formed a part of them, belonged also to the woman he loved... or to his love.

For the rest he saw Velleda seldom, apart from the dinner hour, and the evening — not always, however. A few days later he met her in the garden for the first time quite alone, with the wide sleeve fluttering upon her arm, her face colored with the rosy reflections of her parasol, her glance wandering, her gait gracefully indolent. She stopped short, held out her right hand, and said to him with a security of phrase and intonation that seemed to weigh like a vigorous hand upon his shoulder:

“And Adele?”

“I have not seen her yet.”

She smiled as she knew how to smile sometimes, and said: “Oooh!...” Alberto blushed for fear of turning red.

“We shall find her perhaps on the terrace, where Signor Forlani is having some little statues from Lucca set up,” she added. “Will you accompany me?”

And they went along the avenue, one beside the other. The light flounces of her dress whispered over her little boots of shiny leather.

“Do you like the country?” Alberto began after a few steps.

“So much!”

“Do you take long walks?”

“Yes.”

“One hardly ever sees you in the morning!”

She turned to look at him, with a shade of surprise, and inclined her head slightly, a little ironically.

“Before, there were two of us running about the garden,” she added at once as if to cancel the effect of her greeting. “But now Adele is always tired.”

“And do you not grow bored going alone?” Alberto hastened to answer.

“Why should I grow bored?”

“It is true enough that sometimes one prefers to be in the company of one’s own thoughts...”

“What thoughts?” Velleda interrupted abruptly, fixing her eyes on his face.

They remained an instant looking at one another in that manner. Uncle Bartolomeo, who was close by, cried out, as if he had guessed the ticklish situation:

“Eh, children! who wants to see the fine carriage! Run to the terrace.”

Indeed a superb coach passed, glittering with varnish, with gilded coats of arms, with galooned liveries, with bells, adorned with ribbons and flowers at the horses’ headstalls and the postilion’s buttonholes; the spokes of the wheels shone in the sun like rapid birds’ wings; a thin veil of dust wrapped the elegant carriage, padded with silk like an elegant little box, and the beautiful lady who sat half reclined in it, resting her feet on the seat opposite, in an indolent pose, in the midst of a cloud of muslin fresh and light as tulle; the blue veil of her little hat fluttered over all that graceful assemblage.

“The beautiful lady!” exclaimed Adelina ingenuously, who had come running.

“It is the Contessa Armandi,” said Velleda.

Alberto had followed her with a long look.

They turned back for dinner, and the uncle went ahead, quicker than the others, saying that he was hungry. Now and then Alberto remained thoughtful, and did not answer at once, answered at random to the questions and the talk of the two girls, who both seemed festive; at table he spoke two or three times of the Contessa Armandi, and after dinner he went to smoke in the garden.

He felt swelling in his breast the germs of all the forms of love, like a luxuriance of life, like acrid flowers of youth: it was a strange mixture of Adele's blue eyes, of her modest smile, and of the lures of Velleda's blond hair, and of her elegant coquetry — farther on, among the blue and purple clouds of the future, there undulated vaguely the phantom of another love, nebulous as the muslin that stretched from one end to the other of the Contessa Armandi, like a veil dress shaken out in a milliner's basket. — All these phantoms whirled confusedly in his head, ran through his veins with blood kindled by fever. — That boy who was beginning to feel Woman grew gigantic, and had need of weeping.

CHAPTER X

In that time an invitation was brought to the villa for the ball of the Contessa Armandi.

They went on a magnificent autumn evening. The flowering hedges exhaled vigorous perfumes; the horses' bells had I know not what of the festive; the postilions' whips cracked gaily; the last bell of the Ave Maria died in the distance, with the last ray of sun that colored with opaline tints a rent of sky.

The garden of the Villa Armandi was illuminated, the staircase adorned with flowers, all the windows shone like the lenses of a magic lantern. — Alberto looked avidly — through an iris of hangings, of colors, of gildings and of mirrors; one saw a coming and going of people in festivity; in the rooms sweet perfumes were fragrant, superb gems sparkled and velvety eyes, there was a sound of music, of graceful phrases, and of rustling satin — and in the midst of all this there was a woman more beautiful, more elegant than all the others, who was called the Contessa Armandi.

She was an aristocratic beauty: the black eye, proud, deeply and voluptuously lidded, the walk, the voice, and the gesture soft, the shoulders white and perfumed as magnolia leaves, undulating in pure lines, caressed by the black and elastic braids, the bosom exquisitely modelled in ivory, marbled with bluish shadows, vaporous with embroidered veils, the train of her dress whispering caressingly behind her, the tip of her satin slipper that glittered now and then like

a serpent's tongue, the haughty brow and the fascinating smile. — She was forty.

When they found themselves face to face with Velleda, those two women graceful in different fashions exchanged a glance that might have been called the flash of two dueling swords, while they bowed graciously. — The Contessa smiled at Adele, at Signor Forlani, and turned to look at him as he moved away.

All eyes followed Signorina Manfredini; indeed it seemed that the graces of her person smiled at finding themselves in their own element; in her elegant ease there was something impatient, avid, feverish, that glittered in her eyes, and dilated with her rosy nostrils, while she waved her Chinese fan. Alberto too caught himself following the direction of all those looks, and gazed long at her; then, uneasy, he sought Adele with his eyes.

Velleda stood by the *étagère*, surrounded by the most elegant young men, like a fawn encircled by a pack of hounds; but the fawn held her own on every side, with spirit, with a smile, with a word, with a gesture, witty, caustic, graceful, and impertinent. Two or three times she turned her eyes by chance upon Alberto, and all at once she signed to him with her fan to approach; she took his arm and moved away.

“I could not bear it any longer!” she said, laughing.

The poor young man felt himself all in a turmoil.

“It is natural that everyone should pay court to you....” he stammered.

“Would you like to pay court to me as well?” she said with a singular accent and smile.

Alberto fell mute, and the smile died on her lips. They walked slowly through the rooms, she beating with her fan the time of a waltz they were playing.

“How beautiful it is!” exclaimed Alberto.

"It is Strauss," she answered, absent.

"And why not dance a turn?"

"Apropos of paying court?" — she said, smiling.

Alberto wished to smile with the same ease, but he succeeded very badly.

"Well...." he said; "yes!"

"No!" she answered in the same tone, but a little more decidedly.

The young man insisted with unusual warmth; she grew more capricious and more obstinate, shook her head with a certain resolute grace, and bit her lips with a certain malicious little smile, leaning her shoulders against the *étagère*, and clasping the fan in her hands. Now and then, without her being aware of it, seductive rays escaped from her eyes. All at once without saying anything, while she seemed firmer than ever in her refusal, she laid her arm softly upon his shoulder, and let herself go.

She danced in the German fashion, rather upright, her head high, and her arm extended. Now and then she said some word of no importance to him, or shook with inimitable grace her little blond head. She stopped all at once, a little flushed, a little bewildered, disengaged with an imperceptible impatience the hand he still held, flung him at point-blank a singular look, face to face, and grew slightly pale.

"I am not dancing any more," she said to him; "I am tired."

The Contessa Armandi was close by and exclaimed:

"What a beautiful couple!"

Velleda answered with a graceful bow. Alberto, passing beside a mirror, cast a glance into it and then blushed at having done so; but in the mirror he caught two great eyes that followed him lovingly from the depths of a sofa; he went toward poor Adelina, who sat modestly crouched between two *mammas*, and who seemed to revive as she saw him coming and smiled at him with her eyes.

“Are you not dancing?” asked the cousin, when they were alone.

“You have not asked me to dance,” answered Adele in a timidly caressing tone.

“There are so many young men!....”

“I do not want to dance with the others....”

“Why?”

“Because.... because.... because I do not want to.”

He bent his head, still burning with the breath that Velleda had cast upon it, and moved away lost in thought. He had been for some time in the embrasure of a window, his forehead against the panes, looking into the dark, when he heard a rustle of dresses near him, and found the Contessa Armandi beside him.

“Are you not dancing the cotillon?” she asked him.

“No, Contessa.”

She seemed to wish to add some other word but made him a sign with her fan, smiled, and moved away. He followed mechanically with his eyes the whirl of that dance in the midst of which the Contessa stood like a queen, of whom everyone disputed a smile, a turn of the waltz. Suddenly that queen went straight toward him, threw him like a sultana her embroidered handkerchief, placed upon his shoulder her arm splendid with gems and with nakedness, and into his arms her sinuous and elastic waist — then, when she had finished dancing, she thanked him with a smile.

“I wish to know you better,” she said to him; “let us take a turn.”

All eyes turned upon that fortunate man and that haughty beauty as they passed. He thought of the day when he had seen her softly reclined in her carriage, in a cloud of dust and of veil.

They entered the conservatory, perfumed, silent, dark. The Contessa sat down. The talk went by starts, disjointed, with a certain capricious whimsicality that she knew how to give it, gliding through

all the serpentine zigzags along which she wished to make it pass, sparkling, coquettish, elegant as herself. Then she said not a single word more, rested her chin on her hand, and looked here and there with inattentive eyes; the fichu breathed ever so lightly, and cast a certain sweet livid shadow upon the alabaster bosom; she opened and closed her fan mechanically, and made the sticks rattle against one another. All at once she planted upon Alberto's face a singular look and smile, and said to him:

“But we are compromising ourselves horribly, Marchese!” She rose laughing, and moved away.

When the guests of the Villa Forlani left the fête it was two in the morning. The night was dark, the sky without stars, the country fearful. From time to time the wind moaned among the distant gorges. Adele, a little melancholy, sat in the depths of the carriage, wrapped in her cloak. Velleda held her face to the window. Alberto breathed with full lungs.

“What a beautiful evening!” he exclaimed.

Velleda turned a rapid glance upon him.

The dreams of that night! peopled with all the phantoms of love, with all the fevers of youth, with all the lures of vanity, with all the intoxications of pleasure! — Poor Adele! if she could have guessed them!

CHAPTER XI

Alberti awoke late, thoroughly worn out, and with a heavy head. A ray of sun pierced between the slats of the shutter and made the varnish of the chest of drawers gleam; he smiled at it, then remained staring at it with wide eyes; at last he rose with an inexplicable ill humor.

His first glance was for Velleda's window: it was closed. At breakfast time, entering the dining room, he cast an anxious look about him.

"Are you ill too?" Adele asked him, running to meet him in high spirits.

"Who is ill?"

"Velleda, who is not coming to breakfast because she is so tired that she is quite unwell. You danced so much!"

Alberto let the girl's artless smile and cheerful air fall from him. Breakfast was not very gay. Uncle Bartolomeo went out as soon as he had risen from table, and left them alone.

The girl looked at her cousin by stealth, offered him the matches and the tobacco-pouch, sought to anticipate all his wishes, and, after having hesitated a long while:

"What is the matter with you?" she asked.

"With me? Nothing."

"That is not so; something is the matter."

The young man felt that observation pierce him to the heart, and remained a moment without answering.

“But what would you have me ailing of?”

“Ah! if I only knew!” the girl answered artlessly.

For the first time the young man could not sustain the maiden’s clear gaze; he lit his cigar and went out.

Finding himself in the open, the air, the sun, the perfume of the fields, all those wholesome and genuine things, seemed to purify him and restore his strength. The drunken phantoms of the night, which had need of lamplight, of stearine, and of the shadows of the curtains, melted away in the clear sunshine, and there remained only Adele’s sad and pure little figure, with her little white hands clasped upon her knees, and the great azure eyes that questioned him timidly.

The next day the Contessina Manfredini appeared at dinner time, fresh and rosy as before. Alberti felt a singular vexation at seeing her so. “Have you recovered?” he asked her.

“You see!” she answered quietly.

They were taking coffee in the garden; Velleda set her cup upon the marble table and began to rock in a wooden armchair. “And your friend—is he not coming back?” she asked Alberto after some time. He answered, with a little surprise: “He will come tomorrow or the day after.”

“Ah!”

She rose, left the two cousins in the garden, and went to seat herself at the piano. The touch of her hand was dry, nervous, almost harsh; the melody wandered disjointed, and as if smothered in the midst of a storm-cloud of chords there was the indolence, the nonchalance, the heedlessness of one who goes following her own thoughts upon the keys and disdains to seize them. That strange music burst from the open windows and overpowered—I would say disturbed—the solemn peace of the evening; one seemed to hear in it

outbursts of gaiety and stifled moans, and it had something of the player's own bizarre grace.

Alberto approached the piano and stood watching Velleda. She seemed a marble statue that played, calm, impassive, her eyes fixed upon the music.

"Will you sing something?" Adele asked.

She shook her head, continuing to play, then left off, and rose.

"So soon!" said Alberto; "at least go on playing!"

Velleda raised her eyes coldly upon him and asked:

"What do you wish?"

"Why.... whatever you please."

She began to turn over some music without adding a word, set it upon the stand, and began a song by Schubert.

Adele had seated herself on the sofa; Alberto, leaning against the tail of the piano, kept his eyes fixed upon the player; she did not lift hers from the page, with a certain haughty coldness; she put her whole soul into her hands, whose rings sparkled far more than her eyes, and one saw only that bosom swelling by the glossy reflections of her gown, upon which fell the light of the candles. Little by little the sound died in the strings, her hands stopped, and she bowed her chin upon her breast.

"Is it finished?...." Alberto asked, as if starting awake.

"Yes," she answered abruptly.

And she went to arrange a flower in her hair, kissed Adele, barely nodded to Alberti, and went away.

"One stifles here!" Alberto said to his cousin: "I am going into the garden."

The next day Gemmati was to arrive. Alberto went to meet him, and after the first handshake his friend asked him:

"Well, what is the matter with you?"

“What do you see amiss? I am perfectly well.”

“Is everyone well at the villa?”

“Everyone.”

“Are we sulking, eh?”

“No!”

“Do you still love each other?”

“I love none but her!...”

“Who is talking to you of others?” said Gemmati.

CHAPTER XII

Alberto drank of that subtle poison which penetrated him without his being aware of it, and the intoxication of today gave him thirst for tomorrow—often it was nothing more than a gesture, an inflection of the voice, an absent glance, a smile barely indicated. He lived in a continual agitation. He did not even perceive that he sought every means of remaining near the Contessina Manfredini, that beside her he was quite another man, that he could not satiate himself with gazing at her, that he was restless, peevish, brooding when he was obliged to stay with his cousin; he did not notice the innocent subterfuges, the artless maneuvers that poor Adele invented to see him smile; he did not guess at the questions that were in her silence, the anxiety that was in her looks. The poor girl sought at least Gemmati's company as if to unburden herself with him, as if he possessed something of his friend, and she would often stay near him quite silent, or pensive, or talking to him of indifferent things, often thrusting back the tears that veiled her sight, without ever daring to reveal her grief to him. Uncle Bartolomeo no longer looked at the time, no longer rubbed his hands, and took snuff with much emphasis. Velleda noticed nothing, did not appear to avoid Alberto, but she met him very rarely alone. On the contrary she found herself more often with Gemmati, was more willing to converse with him, showed herself gracious toward him, had herself accompanied on her walks, and let fall upon him the weight of her odd little caprices.

Once Gemmati, returning from the hunt, had met the girls, Alberti, Uncle Forlani, the Zucchi couple—the whole company, in short—at the garden gate. All had crowded about his well-filled game-bag, congratulating him. Velleda alone remained silent. Signora Zucchi, however, who was very tender-hearted, somewhat dimmed the fortunate hunter's glory with compassionate exclamations over a "faithful turtledove" that hung dangling by one wing, and took it amiss of the cruel sport, the hardness of heart, and so forth. Velleda, very grave, interrupted her.

"If I were a man I should wish to do nothing else."

"And you, why did you not come?" Gemmati asked his friend, as they set out toward the villa.

"I am no hunter," said Alberti with a little irony; "I have not your skill."

Gemmati was somewhat surprised by the tone of that answer; he gave over gun and game-bag to a servant, and went with the others; but through the day he was pensive, and even uneasy. He looked at times at his friend, all clouded over, and visibly avoiding being found with him. At last he took advantage of a moment when they were alone, and said to him:

"Alberto, listen to me.... For some time now you have had it in for me!"

"I?" said Alberto without looking at him.

"Yes, you, and I do not know why. What have I done to you?"

"Nothing; you deceive yourself. Why should I have it in for you?"

Gemmati took his hand, which he did not dare refuse him, and said, looking him in the eyes:

"Can you be jealous?"

"Jealous?..." said Alberto, starting, "and of whom?"

The other made a movement of surprise.

“Why.... of Adele.”

“Why should I be jealous?” Alberto replied after a brief silence, and raising his eyes to the other’s face for the first time. “Are you not paying court to Velleda on your own account?”

“I?”

“Yes, you!” he insisted with a strained smile; “or else it is she who is paying it to you.”

Gemmati burst into a good frank laugh.

“Are you mad? I am a poor devil of a budding physician, and she a contessina who has more rings than I have pennies.... How can you think it?... Besides.... But what is it to you?”

“It is nothing to me.... nothing at all. I said it to convince you that I could not be jealous of you on Adele’s account.”

Gemmati remained a moment longer looking him in the eyes, and pressing his hands; and he resumed presently:

“Listen to me, Alberto; perhaps you do not know yourself what a treasure is the little heart of your Adelina, and how she loves you, the poor girl, with what nobility and what delicacy.... and how she hides from you her fears, the griefs you give her without perceiving it.... You know that if you betrayed her you would be doing.... Come, we love each other well enough for me to say the word just as it is—a piece of baseness!”

For some days the poor girl too had loved solitude, not because she saw herself neglected by her cousin, for when she saw him smile paradise opened before her, but for the pain of seeing him so.... so.... she herself did not know. He found her on that bench where the moon had seen them one beside the other, and felt something that gnawed at his heart; the poor child sat looking at him timidly, opening her eyes wide to conceal the tears that were coming forth, and not daring to call to him even with her looks—he approached her, with a false

smile, like a guilty man. Then Adele seized his hand with animation and burst into tears.

“Why do you weep?” said Alberto, almost with tears in his own eyes as well.

“Oh, because I am happy!... See what a mad creature I am!”

They remained together a little while; he spoke little and absently; she looked at him by stealth, as if she feared to caress him with her glances.

“Alberto, will you permit me to say something to you?” she stammered at last, timidly.

“Speak.”

“Confide to me what is the matter with you!”

“But what do you see in me?”

“I do not know... You are no longer the same...”

He flushed slightly.

“Why do you ask me that question?” he said abruptly, lifting his head from a sort of meditation.

“Because... because you are much changed.” He seemed to hesitate.

“Do you fear that I do not love you?”

The girl looked at him in astonishment, and answered artlessly:

“Why should you not love me? Have you not told me yourself that you love me?”

“I mean... if you fear that I love you no longer!”

“Would you not tell me so in that case?” Adele answered in the same manner, and without withdrawing her eyes from his.

“Then?..” the young man stammered—and that “then” drove itself like a nail into his thought.

“Then I should be truly base!” he murmured when he was alone, and fleeing across the country as if someone were pursuing him.

CHAPTER XIII

“How is it one has seen nothing more of you, Marchese Alberti?” he heard someone exclaim behind him.

He turned and saw the Contessa Armandi on horseback, who had stopped in the road, two paces from him. The Contessa sat well in the saddle; her riding-habit traced elegantly her beautiful figure; the blue veil fluttered over her face, as if it were kissing her; the mare, her bit all white with foam, stretched out her neck and shook her pretty little head with the grace of a tamed gazelle.

“One must needs encounter you on the road!” said the Contessa Armandi, stretching her hand down to him at the height of her knee. “A fortunate thing that you come in search of sweet sunsets and fine views!... Would you make verses as well, Marchese?”

Her smile was so gay that the young man felt it almost communicate itself to him, and he answered:

“I have not that vice, Contessa.”

“You are in love, then?”

“You yourself come here without making verses or being in love...”

“How do you know?” she asked with a smile that utterly disconcerted him.

“Why...”

“I cannot be in love with my husband.... or with my Zelia,” she added with that biting and graceful little laugh, looking at him boldly

and coquettishly, and playing with the knob of her riding-whip among the mare's mane.

"Yet," she resumed, "you who have neither husband nor Zelia will love the fair one, or the dark.—Which of the two?"

The young man flushed, wished to deny it, and remained embarrassed. The Contessa sat looking at him with her elbow on her knee, her cheek in her palm, and a provocative irony in her eyes.

And after having listened to him thus, half ironic and half mocking, she added with great seriousness:

"It is true! You are too young to love the dark one, and you will love the fair one only for a quarter of an hour. You love nothing but your own youth—and woman in the nebular state.—Farewell. When you have need of good counsel come and find me; thus I shall have that visit of yours which I have been expecting this long while."

And she spurred Zelia, without giving Alberto time to stammer the excuses that could be read upon his face. Then she suddenly checked the mare's bound, and raising herself in the stirrup with a graceful and daring air, she turned back and said to him from a distance:

"Oh! I am not angry... and for proof!..." On the bank of the road a belated daisy was putting forth; she cut it with a stroke of her whip—"and for proof I leave you a remembrance: consult the oracle, Marchese."

And she vanished like a flash of lightning.

"Have you seen the Contessa Armandi?" Gemmati asked at table.

"Yes."

"What did she say to you?" Adele added.

Alberto entangled himself in the telling of a little story half true and half invented, grew confused, and even turned a little red. Uncle Forlani coughed two or three times, and Velleda cast him a rapid glance.

“What a beautiful lady!” he said, to change the subject.

The next day, when Alberti was about to go to the Villa Armandi, he met the Signorina Manfredini by chance near the gate.

“Are you going to the Contessa’s?” she asked him.

“Yes.”

“Do you really set store by paying that visit?”

“Why... set store by it...”

“If you do not set store by it, do nothing about it for today. The weather is fine; we shall go to the Sassosa in the carriage with Adele.”

And for the first time she lowered her eyes before his look.

“Yes!...” he said, “yes!”

CHAPTER XIV

Adele accepted the invitation all joyful. It was so long since her cousin had seemed to be in a sulk with her! But at that moment her father appeared, with a face darker than usual, and called his daughter into his room under pretext of having a serious talk with her.

Alberti was listening very absently to the talk that Velleda kept up, she being far calmer and more mistress of herself. Adele returned shortly after, pale, all in a turmoil, and with her face still wet with tears.

“What has happened?” her cousin asked in a low voice.

She looked at him with tearful eyes, her bosom swelled, and she burst out weeping.

“Nothing! nothing!” she answered obstinately to all his questions, he who felt his heart pierced by that weeping.

After about half an hour the uncle returned. He was grave of face, but with that kindly-gruff air which suited him to perfection. He was most amiable with Velleda, and patted his nephew on the shoulder.

“Your bay seems to me a little ill,” he said. “Will you come and look at him?”

Alberto felt dimly that his bay was far better than he himself felt at that moment; yet he followed his uncle, whose face grew more overcast as they moved away from the arbor where they had left the girls. Arrived in the avenue opposite the stables, which were on the

other side of the villa, he stopped short, dominating his nephew with all the majesty of his corpulent stature and of an uncle's look.

"Alberto, you are the son of my dear Cecilia!" he began solemnly.

"Uncle..."

"And you are also an excellent boy... I have no difficulty in saying so."

"Oh, uncle..."

"I wish you well and always shall, as the second father that I am to you. You can see how I have received you in my house, and how..."

"Thank you, uncle!..."

"But what return do you make me?"

Alberto turned the color of live coals.

"You have bewitched that poor child of mine! Speak...."

The nephew, with all the colors of the rainbow in his face, kept his eyes fixed on the ground, as if he had wished to sink into it. The uncle was silent with majesty, waiting for an answer for some seconds; then he resumed in a paternal air:

"I perceive from your embarrassment that you understand you have conducted yourself very badly, and that you are sorry for it!..."

And he made a second pause; but the answer he awaited did not come.

"I have only become aware of it today; too late! But could I have mistrusted you, my own blood, my second son, for such I have held you?..."

Alberto did not breathe a word, but went ruminating how the devil his uncle had come to perceive it just now when he scarcely thought of his cousin any longer, and he remembered the sneeze he had heard that first time he had spoken with Adele from the window, and which he had then wrongly attributed to his uncle. The latter, seeing that his

nephew could not resolve to speak, and remained planted there as if he had been of stone, resumed:

“Mea culpa! my loss! I shall pay for the broken crockery! I who have been too blind, trusting as... as an honest man... That poor girl will go through some great trouble... but patience!”

“I shall marry her!” answered Alberto, pale as a rag.

“My son!” exclaimed Signor Forlani, embracing him tenderly. “I have never doubted you!”

They returned to the arbor, caring no more about the bay, who was quietly eating his oats. Velleda, without raising her eyes from her work, shot them a glance that would have done honor to a diplomat. Adele bent her head still lower, and grew pale.

“My daughter,” her father said to her in a tone suited to the occasion, “your cousin Alberto has asked me for your hand.”

Adele let her work fall from her hand, and turned white. Velleda rose as if a spring had been released, ran to her in a flurry, embraced her and kissed her again and again, then turned to Alberti, smiled at him graciously, and held out her hand.

“God bless you, my children!” concluded Signor Forlani, embracing the two young people at the same time.

“And how did Papa come to perceive it now?” Adele exclaimed artlessly when they were left alone.

The poor child’s happiness was so great that it seemed to radiate upon the others as well. There was so much affection, so much gratitude, so much abandon, so much expansion in her joy that Alberto believed for an instant his love had been galvanized.

Gemmati had made a trip as far as Pistoia; returning in the evening he found everyone in festivity, and when he learned what it was about he embraced Alberto and said to him with that calm and frank manner of his:

“Well done, my friend!”

CHAPTER XV

Alberti was up unusually early. Returning from his walk, he heard the piano being played, and entered the drawing room.

He found Velleda at the pianoforte; as he appeared in the doorway the last notes seemed to start.

“Oh! Signor Alberto!”

And she held out her hand with perfect calm.

He sat down beside her and remained listening.

“Don’t you know?” she said after a few moments, and without ceasing to play, “I am expecting Mamma today.”

“Oh! Shall we have her with us for some time?”

“For a day. She has come to fetch me.”

“Are you going away?”

“Yes.”

“When?”

“Tomorrow.”

“So soon!”

“It is more than a month that I have been here.”

Alberto was silent, and she continued to play.

“What piece is that?” he asked at last.

“A study by Liszt. Do you like it?”

“Yes... very much...”

He rose and began to look at the pictures hanging on the walls. Then he came back to sit in the same place, and after a few moments of silence he said to her:

“Shall we see each other again?”

“Why... yes...”

He said no more; the piano too fell silent. They remained quiet, motionless, without looking at each other. All at once footsteps were heard near the door.

“Leave me!” Velleda exclaimed abruptly, addressing him with the *voi* for the first time.

Gemmati entered, grave, cold; he exchanged two or three words with the Contessina, then took Alberti by the arm and led him outside on a pretext.

After some hundreds of paces, Gemmati raised his eyes to his friend’s face for the first time and said to him:

“I have come to find you to tell you one thing:”

“Tomorrow I am going away.”

Alberto seemed for an instant struck by that sudden announcement; but all at once he flushed in the face and answered, forcing a smile:

“Are you accompanying the Contessina Manfredini?”

“I go alone,” Gemmati answered coldly; “I shall leave this evening.”

“Oh, do as you please!”

Gemmati, after a slight pause, resumed:

“So you have done it?”

“Done what?”

“That piece of baseness!”

“Luigi!” cried Alberto.

“Do not fly into a passion, because with it you prove me right: see, I who am not in the wrong will not grow angry: if you shout, I shall shout louder than you what your conscience tells you in an undertone: if you try to strike me, I shall strike harder. I shall leave this evening, because I do not wish to stay and see certain scenes; you infuriate me, and that poor child moves me to pity; my words have availed nothing; at least I shall not see with my own eyes... If you have the strength to be what you have always been, an honest man, I shall come to embrace you and ask your pardon... If not... we shall not see each other again; farewell!”

CHAPTER XVI

Toward evening the Contessa Manfredini arrived. She was a handsome lady who had stopped at forty, blonde as her daughter, with thin lips, an affable smile, and that gentle Tuscan accent which seems a caress of speech. She might have been called a woman all honey from her hair to her mouth; she was discreet, indulgent, reserved, simple and witty; upon occasion and when she chose she could assume certain matronly airs that had to be seen! She was so kind and affectionate with Adele as to have made Velleda jealous, if Velleda had not been as good as her mother; she found two or three words to send Alberti into raptures, and was so gracious with Signor Forlani that he, to answer gallantry in his own fashion, would have liked to make her drink of every flask in his cellar. After dinner the girls sat down to the piano, Signor Forlani set out the famous chessmen, and the wind began to moan outside.

“Do let us hear something!” said Alberto to Velleda, in a voice slightly moved.

She seemed to hesitate.

“Be good, now!” added Adele.

“It is the last time we shall see each other,” she answered at last, turning to Alberto; “I can refuse you nothing.”

“The last time?” exclaimed Adele.

“I said it in jest, you know!”

And she placed herself beside the piano, chose her music, and Adele prepared to accompany her.

She sang with one hand resting on the pianoforte; the light of the candles, screened by the shades, played with the delicate chiaroscuro of her face; in her voice there were vibrations that made one start, that the listeners felt run through their fibres; the players had left the chess: Adele herself from time to time raised her eyes toward her, with a feeling of admiration. All at once Velleda flashed at Alberto, who was listening, his eyes fixed upon her, pale and troubled, a glance swift and flaming as a sword-thrust.

“How you sang this evening!” Adele said to her, embracing her.

She smiled absently.

“Have them give me some orange-flower water; I feel a little agitated.”

Adele went herself.

Velleda remained at the piano, and saw Alberti without looking at him. He drew near her, as if fascinated, staggering, and placed himself beside her—she seemed not to perceive it.

“I should like to speak to you!” said the wretched man at last, in a muffled voice.

The Contessina closed the book tranquilly, and lifted her serene eyes upon him:

“I am listening.”

“I should like to speak to you alone, tonight, in the garden!” Alberti repeated, with the almost threatening obstinacy of one about to lose his reason.

“Is he mad?” she said coldly.

The young man’s lips went bloodless, and trembled two or three times without being able to utter a word: “Yes, I believe I am mad indeed!”

“But I am not, sir!”

Alberto looked at Velleda in such a manner that she, in a drawing-room full of people, was afraid.

“You will be the cause of some misfortune!”

“I?”

“You!” he answered with firmness, looking her steadily in the face.

“Do you know what you are proposing to me, sir?” said the girl with pride.

“I need to speak to you, tonight!” Alberto insisted with a frightful tenacity.

Adele was entering at that moment by a door beside the piano, and heard those words as if a demon had engraved them in her heart with his claw. She leaned against the door before coming in; but in the weakest girl there are miraculous energies, and she had the strength to show herself calm when she lifted the curtain. Alberto was insisting with his look, without perceiving her.

Velleda guessed a little embarrassment in their mutual bearing. “Do you know what I was saying to him?” she said in her ear, “that I am jealous!”

The two betrothed started in different ways.

“Jealous of me?” stammered the poor girl.

“No, but of him. He will steal your heart from me.”

Alberto lowered his eyes and blushed.

The Contessina began to talk of a thousand things, witty and easy as ever, and the conversation became general; she cast and gathered in her undulating nets of words, which had different meanings for the different actors in that scene. Adele, her soul torn with anguish, watched her cousin, who seemed intent upon some inward discourse. All at once, glancing sidelong at Velleda with a kind of possessed

look, he blurted out, beside the purpose: "Well?" a well that would have jarred horribly in the general conversation, if at that moment everyone had not been distracted by a discussion of some warmth. Adele was heroic by force of soul; Velleda showed a surprising presence of mind: she took up the music of *Un Ballo in Maschera* absently, began to turn over the pages, and hummed, "I shall be there... at three." She rose, sat down at the piano, as if suddenly taken with the desire, and began to play the stretta. "Thank you!" Alberto said to her with his eyes. Adele felt something break inside her breast.

CHAPTER XVII

It was one of those last nights of autumn that prelude the winter, dark and stormy. The trees writhed under a furious wind that moaned like a human voice; the dogs whimpered in fright; the air was so charged with electricity that one felt that vague sense of terror, the fantastic attraction of the night.

Alberti sprang down from the window, that same window he had climbed out of some time before with a wholly different love in his heart, and he did not turn his eyes toward his cousin's except to spy whether he might be seen. Within him there was but a single idea, indistinct, blind, fascinating; he walked up and down the avenue that ran before the villa, his hair on end and sweat upon his brow, while the wind howled, and the leaves of the trees seemed to rattle as if under hail; the darkness that wrapped him penetrated him through and through; he felt within himself a kind of stormy moaning, like the wind that dashed the dead leaves against his face. Two hours passed in a flash; he would have walked the whole night without noticing it, through rain, through snow, through the hurricane.

All at once he felt himself seized by a hand, as if the darkness had taken flesh.

"Velleda!" he exclaimed, breaking out with that name which filled him entirely.

"Well, what do you want?"

"Velleda!" he repeated.

She did not see him, though she almost touched him, and that voice, in the dark, frightened her.

“Do you know what you have made me do?”

“Yes, I know!” he answered resolutely.

“You! another woman’s betrothed!...”

“Yes!”

“The betrothed of my friend!”

“Yes!”

“You threatened to do some madness, to make me commit a madness!”

“Yes!”

“What have you to say to me?”

“That I love you!” he said in a muffled voice.

“I came here to tell you that I am the daughter of the Conte Manfredini!” answered Velleda, her voice trembling with pride.

“I came here to tell you that I am a coward!” Alberto retorted.

A few instants of silence followed.

“Oh, if I could have foreseen!” she said at last.

Alberti exclaimed harshly:

“You have known it for a long time!”

“Sir!”

He did not bat an eyelid.

“Yes,” he went on with feverish exaltation; “you caught my Cain-like pallor, you guessed my trembling and my Judas looks; you looked at yourself in the glass, and thought: I am beautiful! this man must love me like a madman! this man must twist and crawl like a viper crushed beneath my little boot!”

Velleda started, as if the demon of pride had caressed with a tongue of fire all the vanities of the woman.

“Yes, I have seen all that,” she said, “and I have been stronger than you!”

“You laughed at it!....”

“I loved you, sir!” she said with nobility.

Alberti staggered, and sought in vain for a word that might express the bursting forth of his passion:

“I want to see you!” he cried. “Let me see you.” She caught his eyes glittering in the dark like those of a wild beast. The frantic man forced her toward that part of the avenue where the trees were thinner and the darkness less dense, seized her by the temples, threw her head back, and kissed her with a look of flame. Velleda uttered a cry, which the wind smothered.

“Marchese Alberti,” she said, pale as a spectre, “I had not offered you the insult of distrusting you.”

He drew back two or three steps.

“Listen to me well, sir! I am Adele’s friend, and I still feel myself worthy of her, and of myself. This is the last time we shall see each other; I speak to you as across an impassable abyss, as if I were about to die for you, that is why I have hidden nothing from you and hide nothing now. I shall never return your love! I shall do my duty, and I pray God that you may do yours.”

“What is my duty?” Alberti asked, like a man struck by lightning.

“Forget me; it is the best you can do.” Alberto answered with a dark smile.

“Well then, I shall do mine!” added Velleda after an instant of silence.

“I have foreseen everything you might do,” he said with desperate tenacity. “You will flee me: I shall follow you; you will despise me: I shall live to see you; you will not love me: I shall love you!...”

As he spoke it seemed that his strength failed him; he sank slowly upon his knees and remained with his head in the dust. Velleda cast a long look upon that man who was sobbing at her feet.

“Alberto!” she said softly,—he sprang to his feet—“Alberto, let us part worthy of one another; let us forget a moment of weakness and of folly; let us be strong!...”

“What need have you to be strong?” asked the young man with a terrible ingenuousness. “What weaknesses do you feel? What follies do you fear?”

She bowed her head without answering.

Alberto waited two or three seconds in mortal anxiety.

“But speak, in God’s name!” he cried, delirious, shaking her hands roughly. “You are driving me mad!”

“No!” she exclaimed. “No!.... no! Never!”

And she fled like a shadow.

CHAPTER XVIII

The peasants of the neighborhood heard the dogs barking all night as if some wild beast had been ranging those hills. Alberto came in toward noon, on the pretext of having taken a long morning walk, tired, panting, feverish. At the villa he found everything in an uproar: the servants were rushing to and fro, the carriage was before the door with the horses still steaming with sweat; Uncle Bartolomeo had only just returned in the doctor's company; during the night Adele had been seized by a most violent attack of fever. At that news Alberto's legs gave way beneath him.

He found his uncle on the threshold of her room.

"Where have you been?" he asked him.

He stammered out lies, like a guilty man. The uncle was so troubled that he did not perceive his nephew's trouble.

"Poor Adelina is ill, you know!" he said to him. "Nobody knows what the devil is the matter with her; even the doctor has lost his Latin over it. Go in, go in. Adele, here is Alberto!"

The young man met Adele's eyes, burning like coals, that fixed him without a word; all the muscles of her face seemed to come undone. The doctor stood at the head of the bed, and held the invalid's pulse between his fingers; he turned upon the newcomer a look that seemed searching.

"Who is that gentleman?" the physician asked Signor Forlani in a low voice.

“My nephew Alberto, my daughter’s betrothed.”

“It is strange!” muttered the other. “I thought I felt the pulse start.”

And he set himself again to look in the face of the invalid, who lay motionless, with staring eyes, flushed cheeks, her little hands that from time to time convulsively clutched the turned-down edge of the coverlet, and her lips shaken by a nervous tremor.

The room was almost dark; one heard only the tick-tack of the clock and the chirping of the birds on the windowsill.

“We had spent the evening quietly at home,” Signor Forlani was saying by way of information; “my little girl was well and cheerful as ever: she did not call once in all the night; Gegia, who sleeps near her room, did not hear her stir or draw breath; this morning then she finds her for me in that state, and with the window wide open, from the great wind last night, or because she opened it herself, without remembering it afterward, feeling herself choking from the blood that was mounting to her head. From eight o’clock till now she has been in that state the whole time; she does not speak, she does not answer, she seems to have no consciousness. The Contessina Manfredini, her dearest friend, came to bid her goodbye before leaving, and she did not notice it; on the contrary, seeing her come in, she turned pale, closed her eyes, and when her friend would have kissed her she was seized by a fit of fever or of convulsion, and took to trembling and shivering so that it was a pity to see; she did not answer a single word to all that the Contessina said to her, she seemed not to hear anything at all, and went on convulsively clutching the turned-down edge of the coverlet, as you see her doing now; from that time she has never opened her mouth.”

The doctor said nothing.

“Look, Adele, here is your Alberto!” resumed Signor Forlani in a loud voice.

Alberto, pushed by him, approached the bed. The invalid fixed him with those wide, glistening, sightless eyes so that he could not help lowering his own.

“Are you ill, poor Adele?” he murmured in a moved voice.

The poor girl began to tremble, as if seized by the shudder of fever, but she did not answer.

“It is your Alberto!” the father insisted.

She trembled more strongly.

“Don’t you know me?” stammered the young man, not knowing what to say, bending toward her.

“She has gone!...” said Adele with a breath of voice scarcely audible, and with such an accent as tore his heart.

“What did she say?” asked the father.

“I did not hear...” answered Alberto, lowering his eyes before her eyes, which still fixed him.

CHAPTER XIX

The following days passed in alternations of hopes and fears for the young girl's life. Alberto no longer dared to appear before her and was always asking news of her, restless, agitated, more suffering than she. Had she died, it would have seemed to him that he had committed a murder.

At last Adele grew better; but as she advanced in her convalescence she showed herself colder and more reserved toward him, sought a thousand pretexts not to receive his visits, avoided answering him and looking him in the face. At last one fine morning Uncle Bartolomeo came into his room, and after talking to him of rain and fine weather, as if he did not know where to begin, told him at last, with a thousand protestations of regret, that as for the marriage nothing would come of it, at least for the moment.

"Adele will not hear of it. It is a little whim of convalescence, what would you have? A clever fellow who'd know how to read them. She was very fond of you, and she is still, a great deal. But what the devil of a notion has jumped into her head? What's to be done? It grieves me more than you, I who should like to call you son twice over!... But it will pass!.. Oh, it will pass."

Alberto understood far beyond his uncle, and found himself small before that noble sacrifice of the girl's; but selfish as a lover, he could not guess how many tears and how much pain that little whim of convalescence had cost poor Adele.

A little later he received a letter from her.

“I know all. Forgive me, Alberto, but my heart was breaking. God has given me the strength not to betray myself, and no one shall ever know the reason of my resolution. But I must tell you, lest you too should believe it a caprice... that my refusal may not humiliate you... and to tell you that I love you still. You will understand that if I write you this, now, it means that I shall never be yours again, we shall never see each other more... and I beg you to go without seeking to see me. Farewell.”

The cousin left for Florence in secret, like a thief, without turning a glance toward that window whose shutters had remained obstinately closed for a long time.

CHAPTER XX

Alberto had arrived in Florence in a singular state of mind—ashamed of himself, seeking Velleda and fearing to see her again, having often before his eyes the pale face and the fever-burning eyes of his cousin, and drinking, without perceiving it, the fascination of that other and so different beauty that had seduced him, with the very air he breathed, it seeming to him that the wind of the hills gave back the perfume of that blonde hair, that every corner of the city, that the elegance of the fashion shops, the splendor of the equipages, the smile of handsome women, the youth that he felt swelling, exultant, in his veins, had something of the Manfredini about them.

The mother and daughter lived in a pretty little villa, small and coquettish, set against the pleasant hill of Bellosguardo. The garden was diligently kept, the spearheads of the gate seemed gilded yesterday, the walks had neither a stone nor a blade of grass, the enclosing wall was tapestried with climbing plants, the shrubs were carefully pruned. The house was of two stories, simple, white, surrounded by trees, with green shutters, behind which the panes were seen to glitter.

When the timid lover dared to push his inquiries a little further, he learned that the little villa was deserted, and that the ladies Manfredini had not yet returned to town.

Alberti was almost unknown in Florence. That state of isolation gave a factitious tenacity to his passion even without his imagination,

which persisted in draping his heart in mourning.—Yet he was twenty.

Meanwhile Carnival had come, and the young Ortis had made no scruple of going to a masquerade at the Pergola; he had been jostled hither and thither, he had been bored, but he had stayed looking on with eyes as wide as they could open. All at once a pretty little mask stopped full in front of him, transfixing him with a devilish smile and with two eyes sparkling through the holes of the mask.

“Ciao!”

Alberto fixed upon her a long look, which was worth at least as much as the *ciao*.

The little mask was dressed as an Italian page of the thirteenth century, slim, fresh, elegant, and she seemed as beautiful as a Love.

“Do you know you’re a handsome little blond!” the little page said to him, in the official language of the stage at La Scala, taking his hands.

“I don’t understand Turkish, pretty mask.”

“Don’t you understand that I like you?”

“And you?” answered Alberto, grown bold himself; “are you beautiful?”

“Look!”

She drew aside the mask quickly and dazzled him.

“Farewell, Marchese Alberti!” said another voice near him that made him start.

“You’re a Marchese too?” asked the little page.

“Does it vex you?”

“You’re so handsome a youth that you may as well be a Marchese too.”

“Leave that girl,” the first voice said to Alberto, in a brief accent. “I have come down into the pit for you. I must speak to you.”

He saw beside him a lady in a domino, dressed in black, all veiled, without a jewel. Of those two masked women who were disputing his arm, one was modelled like a Venus by her tight costume: she had curling hair, a flashing eye, an alabaster throat, she was rosy, coquettish, fascinating; the other had only the carriage of her head, the elegance of her figure, the charm of her accent, the aristocratic perfume of her handkerchief, and the laces that fell upon her gray glove—and it was enough. This one took the young man's arm as a thing of her own, and the crowd soon separated them from the little page. They went toward the corridors of the boxes, the masked woman in front, mounting the stairs with a free and light step, without saying a word, lifting a little the hem of her dress over the embroidered petticoat. When they had reached the third tier and the darkest corner of the corridor, she stopped suddenly, took his hands, looked him in the face, and said:

“Traitor!”

“You know me?” exclaimed Alberti, astonished.

“Do you remember Belmonte?”

He seized her hands, searching her everywhere with his look.

“Who are you? Tell me who you are!”

“I am your cousin Adele!”

At the first instant Alberto turned pale, drew her quickly toward the more lighted part of the corridor; then he smiled with an effort, and murmured:

“It is not true.”

The masked woman smiled too.

“For whom have you betrayed me?”

“Tell me who you are?” Alberti repeated, trying to read in that look which glittered in the shadow.

"It is useless for me to tell you, since you do not know me and never will."

"Never?"

"Never!"

Alberto gazed at her anxiously, not daring to utter a name that came to his lips with certain impulses that were, I would say, vertiginous.

"What sort of life are you leading?" she exclaimed at last, with a bizarre inflection of voice. "Why is one never to see you anywhere? Do you still love that other one?"

"I go everywhere," answered Alberto, eluding the question.

"Everywhere is too little. Are you going on Saturday to the ball at the Pitti?"

"No."

"Go!" the little mask insisted, with a pressure of the hand.

"Shall I see you there?"

"No."

"What does it matter to you, then, that I should go?" She seemed to hesitate.

"Shall I give you a token by which to know me?"

"Give it to me."

She drew off her glove and held out to him her hand, white as marble and veined with blue.

"Will you remember it?" she said to him, smiling, with an accent that pierced him to the heart.

"Oh!"

"Kiss it..... Farewell."

"Wait!" cried Alberto. "Do not leave me so. Shall we see each other again?"

“No! no! I have told you!”

She had freed herself again, and was about to turn the corner of the corridor.

“Have you fallen in love already with my hand?” she said, stopping an instant at the head of the stair. “Well.... I have left you at least a remembrance..... Remember me. Farewell.”

The next day Alberti saw Velleda again of a sudden, and when he least expected it—she was passing in a carriage before Doney’s, and she did not notice him, who had stopped on the pavement as if his breath had failed him—or she would not notice him. At the turning of Santa Trinità the Contessina put her head at random to the carriage window, and looked toward Via Rondinelli. He saw for an instant, through the glittering glass, her blonde hair.

CHAPTER XXI

Alberti had received an invitation to the ball at Court, without knowing from what quarter it came; that was perhaps a good reason for not failing to appear, had there not been others besides. He went.

The first person he saw, surrounded by the crowd, courted like a grand duchess, was Velleda. She stood there exactly as a grand duchess would, and did not notice him. All at once she came toward him resolutely and held out her hand with a fine smile; then, seizing the moment when no one could see or hear them, she froze the joy that was bursting, triumphant, in his eyes, turning suddenly grave and cold.

“Everyone knows that we are acquainted,” she said to him. “Ask me for a dance.”

They made two or three turns through the rooms, speaking little, and looking here and there.

“Have you presented yourself to Mama?” she asked him afterward in the same manner.

“... No...”

“What will she think?... Present yourself.”

The Contessa Manfredini received Alberti with her smile and her honeyed chatter.

“Too kind, really! — We have been away from Florence. — We have been traveling. A beautiful city, Naples! Do you know it? —

And Rome? Vesuvius? — We live at the Villino Flora, just outside Porta Romana. We receive on Mondays. Do not fail us.”

The allusions to Belmonte, and to the Forlani family, were gracefully avoided.

“Have you any engagement with Signor De Marchi?” the Contessa asked her daughter, who had drawn near again. Velleda grew pensive for an instant, as if she had not understood the question; she shook her head a little quickly, and answered:

“No... I do not remember...”

Alberti caught a rapid, keen glance that the mother darted at her daughter. While he was leading Velleda to take her place in the quadrille, she asked him negligently:

“Has Mama invited you to come to our Mondays?”

“Yes.”

Then she slightly knitted her brow, took her place, pushed back the train of her gown, and said nothing more. She executed the various figures of the quadrille with her habitual grace and ease, somewhat cold, indifferent, addressing Alberti only so much as was necessary so as not to attract notice.

“The day before yesterday I saw you in Florence for the first time,” the Marchese began. She said not a word.

“Did you know that I was here?”

“Yes,” she answered, dry as dust; and she began to beat time with her fan.

And after some minutes of silence:

“Beautiful, that music!”

“It seems to me I have heard it.”

“Where?”

“At Belmonte... at the Villa Armandi...”

“You are mistaken,” she said coldly.

They were silent.

“Did you enjoy yourself on this journey?” Alberti asked.

“Very much!”

“You have been away a long time!”

“You think so!... barely four months.”

He bowed his head.

“Too many people!” Velleda murmured, to break the silence.

“True.”

“Have you seen the Contessa Armandi in the other rooms?”

“No.”

“She must be here. It seems to me I saw her a moment.”

The quadrille was over. While Alberti was leading her back, Velleda asked him:

“Have you promised Mama to come?”

“Yes... Does it displease you?”

“Why should it displease me, sir?” she said haughtily.

“Give me a glass of water,” she added immediately, as if to mitigate the harshness of her reply.

After they had crossed two more rooms, she resumed, looking attentively at the designs on her fan:

“And do you not think of traveling as well?”

“Why?” Alberto answered with a little surprise.

“Because you are young, and the world is beautiful. Go to Rome, to Greece, to the East...”

“You send me a long way off,” Alberti answered, smiling with tight lips.

She, after toying with the tassel of her fan, answered slowly:

“Do as you please.”

“Give me your orders...”

“Orders, I!” exclaimed Velleda, tossing up her head, “and by what right, sir?”

“Advice, at least...”

For the first time the haughty girl raised her eyes to him, and looking at him fixedly:

“I thought you had no need of it,” she said. “But since you desire it... I have given it to you... Go.”

She drank calmly, passed her embroidered handkerchief over her lips, took his arm again—he who no longer said a word—and had herself accompanied to her place without adding anything more.

A handsome young man, in the uniform of an embassy attaché, approached her with eagerness the moment he saw her seated, and bent toward her to say something. Alberto heard her answer coldly:

“Thank you, sir. I am tired.”

“Will you dance no more?” asked the Contessa.

“No, Mama: I should like to be at home already.”

The mother turned a penetrating look upon her, and said: “Let us go, then.”

The young diplomat accompanied the two ladies. While Alberto was about to leave as well, he met the Contessa Armandi.

“Oh! You here! I thought you still at Belmonte. Are you going away too? Accompany me to my carriage, in that case...”

She handed him her wadded mantle, her hood, her boa, that he might help her a little; and she went on chatting while the clumsy cavalier entangled himself among all those articles: “And how is it that you find yourself here, and alone? and your little cousin? — This other end here, on the shoulder. — So it has gone up in smoke, then? — Wrap the boa well; they say it is cold. Thank you, so! — Through your fault, I am certain of it; I had predicted it to you, do you

remember? — Pull the hood up a little. — I did not hope to meet you: what luck!”

“How is it that I did not see you at the ball?”

“You were so occupied! But I do not take it amiss, you know!”

At this moment the young fellow who had accompanied the ladies Manfredini came back in, and bowed deeply to the Armandi.

“All alone?” she said to him.

The young man avoided answering, making a bow and a half-smile.

“Who is that gentleman?” Alberti asked, following him with a long look.

The Contessa’s eyes sparkled with a malicious irony: “Signor De Marchi,” she answered, “an attaché of the Neapolitan embassy. — A handsome young man, is he not?”

And she went down the stairs, barely leaning on Alberto’s arm. He, as he offered her his hand to mount into the carriage, asked her:

“Will you permit me to accompany you?”

“No. You could no longer pretend to be ignorant of where I live, and you would be obliged to pay me the visit of Belmonte.”

“I have deserved it!”

“I am not angry” — and she pressed his hand, smiling at him from the depths of her hood. “No, truly!”

The carriage drove off.

CHAPTER XXII

The first time that Alberto went to the Contessa Manfredini's Mondays it seemed to him that he caught in Velleda's eyes an expression of surprise and of vexation. But the young girl was too well bred to let this appear otherwise than by surprise, and she received him with a little coldness, it is true, but becomingly. She neither avoided nor sought occasions of finding herself alone with him, and when this happened, by chance, she knew how to carry it off perfectly, dominating Alberto with her superb calm. She addressed him as she did all the others, neither more nor less, sometimes with a shade of irony, sometimes with impertinent coldness, often as if she wished by her bearing to ask Alberti tacitly why he continued to frequent her house despite her prohibition, quite clearly expressed. The mother, on the contrary, as if she had wished to soften and make excuse for her daughter's manners, treated Alberti affably.

One evening when the milder air of spring permitted the windows to be left open, Velleda approached Alberti with her easy gait, and said to him calmly:

"I have something to say to you, sir" — and she preceded him onto the little terrace. "Do you know that Signor De Marchi has asked for my hand?"

"I suspected it..."

"I did not wish.... I had no intention of marrying..." she added in a short, resolute voice, without looking at him. "But since you have forced me to it I have said yes."

Alberto delayed some minutes before answering.

“Do you order me not to come to your house any more?” he asked at last.

“Now it is useless,” she said with a glacial and superb smile. “I have burned my ships.”

The news of that marriage was not long in circulating among the friends of the Manfredini household: at first discreetly, afterward with greater assurance. De Marchi had thinned his visits; Velleda treated him with greater reserve; but it was known that on both sides questions of interest were being negotiated, and that was perfectly in order.

“The incense is burning!” said the Armandi once, coming out of the Manfredini house together with Alberto.

Velleda had somewhat softened her bearing toward Alberti, whether because his resignation had disarmed her, or because, after the resolution taken, he inspired her with no further fear. She traversed with the ease of the great world that period, so difficult for a girl, of the questions whispered by the family friends into Mama’s ear, of the more or less veiled allusions, of the indiscreetly reserved glances. From time to time she seemed a little abstracted and pensive; she had certain moments of almost gloomy silence, or of gaiety as if irritated, or of unreasonable asperity. All this fell more frequently and more directly upon poor Alberti, as if she could not forgive him for having forced her to an untimely resolution. Sarcasm came frequently to her lips, and she herself blushed sometimes at her stinging epigrams; a moment later she seemed to repent and to have the intention of making him some apology, such as her proud nature could make, with a kind word or a delicate attention. Alberto grew pale, or flushed; he suffered, but he did not dare to give up seeing her. Often he caught her eyes fixed upon him, charged with anger, frowning, dark: then her laugh was more biting, or, strange thing, her

speech was more gracious. At other times it was she, on the contrary, who caught Alberto's glances turned toward De Marchi with the feverish admiration of envy. De Marchi was a formidable rival, handsome, highly placed, elegant and witty — the poor lover suffered the most cruel jealousy: that which humbles and annihilates.

One Monday when there were more people than usual at the Manfredini house, Alberto found himself a moment alone near Velleda at the garden door, and they began to speak of the last opera at the Pergola, and of the races that had been held at the Cascine. For some time there had run between them the good relations of people completely indifferent. Velleda therefore did not move, and went on talking calmly and at greater length than usual; she hummed between her teeth the airs she remembered, and made the sand grate under her restless little boot; she asked him what the horse was called that had won at the races, and to how much the first prize amounted. Alberti answered a little distractedly, as often happened with him, but to the point.

“Do you like the races as well?” Velleda asked him.

“I will not have you marry De Marchi!” Alberti answered all at once, abruptly, seizing her hands.

She cast him a wild look and stood fixing him so, with her arms rigidly stretched. They added not a word — they remained looking at each other. Little by little her eyes grew veiled, her face turned ashen, and her arms slackened. Then she freed herself with a desperate effort and went back in as if fleeing.

CHAPTER XXIII

After some days it began to be whispered behind the fan that the Signorina Manfredini's marriage had stumbled upon grave difficulties of interest. De Marchi had left for Naples, with the object of facilitating the negotiations with his family; the girl showed herself rarely; the mother was more serious than usual, and showed herself most amiable with the most slanderous of her friends.

Alberto and Velleda had not exchanged a single word more. She no longer had the rigid haughtiness of formerly, the firmness of the glance, the sureness of the intonation. She had the air of one defeated. Before him she fell mute, and lowered her eyes. One evening, walking in the garden, he took her hand, and she left it to him. Thus she abandoned herself to him.

The Contessa Armandi had become intimate with the Manfredini household: yet she showed that she had not forgiven Alberto the visit he had not paid her, and which afterward she had not permitted him to pay. For the rest she was exceedingly capricious, and to avenge herself she seemed to have adopted the system of making him lose his bearings. Now she was ironical, impertinent, bantering, disdainful; now she had herself accompanied to her floor, or in the carriage, and she always left him at her door, saying to him: "Thus far!"

One evening when at the Villino Flora the conversation had been more disjointed, and Mama Manfredini had shown herself more pre-occupied than usual, the Armandi said to Alberto as they were leaving:

“By the bye, why do you not marry Mademoiselle Velleda yourself?”

Alberto received the question like a thrust full in the breast. The Armandi did not give him time to answer, and added at once gaily:

“That other would be a mistaken marriage. The Signorina Manfredini is not rich, and the budding ambassador possesses barely enough for his wife’s gloves. It is fortunate that the child has more sense than her mother, who has set her heart on the diplomat’s livery, — and she will think twice before saying yes!”

“It takes more than that!”

“And yet you said the incense is burning!”

“I said the incense, but I did not say the nuptial torches!” the Contessa answered with her little ironical laugh. And she mounted into the carriage.

Alberto remained pensive.

The next day Velleda questioned him two or three times with her look — he showed himself overcast. Then she went to sit in a corner, without asking him a single question.

He approached her, sat down beside her, and they began to amuse themselves with the books and the albums. After a long silence he said to her in a low voice:

“Do you know that Signor De Marchi will shortly return from Naples?”

Velleda fixed her eyes on his face, shrugged her shoulders, and did not answer. The young man pressed her hand in secret, and resumed:

“Forgive me all that I said to you that evening.... I was mad.... or something worse!”

The girl, in the shadow of her fan, did not take from him that luminous, tenacious, incisive look; but she did not open her mouth; he grew pale, hesitated, pressed her hand strongly, and stammered:

“Marry him.”

Velleda remained silent, motionless, white; at last she slowly let fall this word:

“Why?”

“Because I should never marry.”

A flush of fire ran over the young girl’s face; then she grew pale, gently withdrew her hand, remained some instants with her gaze fixed before her, her brow knitted, and at last said in a tone of voice in which one could not have guessed whether it were haughty or indifferent:

“What is it to me?”

Alberto expected surprise, indignation, anger, and remained dumbfounded by that answer. Paler than she, and with a trembling voice, he said to her:

“How you must hate me!”

She, without raising her eyes, let her hand fall softly into his.

“Listen to me, Velleda!” exclaimed Alberto with a feverish accent. “I love you in a way I should not know how to tell. In my head there is something unsound, and doubt gnaws me like a venomous worm. I need to be convinced that you love me for myself, without secondary ends, and that you sacrifice everything to me... everything! do you understand?... Forgive me! When this fatal doubt entered into me.... or was put there by a word.... I should have wished to flee from you.... and I could not. You alone can give me the desperate courage. What would you have me do?”

“We could not love each other otherwise!” Velleda answered after reflecting an instant. “Better so! Now I too can tell you that I love you!”

CHAPTER XXIV

A love so romantic was bound to seduce the imagination of the fantastical young man. His eternal passions had been so transitory, his impressions so vivid and mutable, that when he had felt the need of being confident in the feeling that filled his whole being, he had become uneasy. The love of that haughty girl who sacrificed to him the most legitimate claims, her future, and the most formidable rival, flattered at once his vanity and his heart, and the sophistry as well. He abandoned himself to it with intoxication, without examining where it might lead him, without discussing whether it were possible as it showed itself.

The two young people saw each other often; now regularly, and now by chance — it is true that they helped chance a good deal. Alberto's horse knew how to walk nowhere but outside Porta Romana, and the Signorina Velleda did what she had never done, waited for him at the window, or under the acacias of the garden. When they were together they said very little to each other; they talked of the most ordinary subjects, which for them had a hundred other meanings; their eyes met rarely, their hands never met. The Contessa Manfredini had the air of scenting the wind.

De Marchi had returned from Naples, and his first visit had been for the Villino Flora. The negotiations for the marriage were not very far advanced; some people said indeed that they had taken a step backward, but the parties concerned were all people of good society, and knew how to continue their relations in such a way as to give no

pretext to the indiscreet and the curious; the more so as serious engagements had never been officially entered into.

At one of the last receptions of the Manfredini house, De Marchi had shown himself more attentive and gallant than usual. Alberti, huddled in a corner, suffered in silence. Velleda was serving the tea, and passing near him she saw him so pale and altered. "What is the matter with you?" she asked him. He cast her a feverish glance. Velleda passed on.

Alberto followed her with an avid look. He saw her pass near De Marchi, who was leaning against the jamb of a doorway, his hand hidden in his waistcoat, the eyeglass fixed in his eye, handsome and sardonic. Alberto could not hear what the other had said to her, bending toward her; but he saw him smile, and she too smiled and flushed slightly. In the corner where Alberti was, a noise was heard of porcelain breaking; no one noticed it, or paid it any heed: the lady nearest did not even turn her head; only Velleda, from the other end of the room, turned toward that noise a glance so rapid and flashing that De Marchi adjusted his eyeglass in his eye and looked as well.

The Signorina Manfredini continued to glide among the crowd, sparkling and gracious. At last she passed near Alberto, without a cloud on her brow, without turning her eyes upon him, and threw him softly this word:

"Follow me."

Alberti went behind her into the other room, and, fearing to let his agitation be perceived, he set himself to watch with great attention the game, which he did not understand. Shortly afterward Velleda found herself near him, at her ease, jesting with the players and with those who stood watching the play. Perceiving Alberti she said to him: "Do you not smoke?" — and went to fetch him a cigar from a carved case. "Pass through there without letting yourself be seen" — she added so low that he could scarcely hear her.

That other room was a small work-cabinet which opened on one side into the mother's chamber, and on the other into that of the Signorina Manfredini. There was a large writing-desk between the two windows, a sofa opposite, and a little table beside it; between the sofa and the writing-desk opened the door of Velleda's room. The room was little lighted by a single shaded lamp set upon the table. Alberto waited some instants, uneasy, eye and ear on the stretch; the chatter of the conversation and the exclamations of the players were distinctly heard; from time to time the rustle of a gown passed across the half-open door. All at once Velleda appeared, walking on tiptoe with a rapid, resolute step, and took his hand. But at the same instant she stopped him, with her arm stretched out, and remained motionless, anxious, terrified, looking at the door by which she had entered. She pushed Alberto abruptly into her room, and had barely time to close the door. All this happened in a flash.

"What are you doing here?" asked the Contessa Manfredini, entering.

"A button is just coming off my glove...."

"You are pale..."

"I do not feel well."

"I know everything... I saw the Marchese Alberti..."

"Mama!..."

"I saw him through the mirror, I tell you, when he dropped the cup... He did not fail to make a scandal... That man wants to compromise you at any cost!"

The young girl was sublime for presence of mind, and had one of those strokes of audacity that only young ladies of the great world possess. "They are listening to us, Mama!" she exclaimed in a supplicating accent. The Contessa cast a furtive glance toward the adjoining room where they were playing, and went out.

Velleda, pale, at the end of her strength, and more beautiful than ever, entered resolutely where Alberto was.

“Well?” she said, stopping before him.

He had heard everything. “Forgive me!” he murmured. “I was jealous!...”

“Of whom?”

“Of him!...”

“Would you be here if you had the right to be jealous?” she answered with noble simplicity.

The young man cast about him a moved look, almost reverent, as if the virginal perfume of that little chamber had something august in it, and he fell at her feet.

“It is true!... What have you done, Velleda!...”

“I have done the only thing that could prove to you how I love you,” the young girl answered, without a single vibration in her voice.

Alberto dared to clasp her in his arms, and to bring his trembling lips to her brow. She half-closed her eyes, and abandoned herself softly. All at once she started, pushed him back with liveliness, and stood listening. “My God!” she exclaimed.

In a flash she composed her face and her look, went out with a feline movement, and found herself face to face with her mother and the Contessa Armandi.

“The Contessa does not feel well,” said the Manfredini. “Have you some cordial in your room?”

“Nothing, Mama!” Velleda answered with unusual liveliness.

The Armandi had thrown herself upon the sofa, and despite her great ailment she seemed to be a good deal better than the girl, who was pale as a rag. She had cast a rapid, penetrating glance upon Velleda, and had excused herself as best she could.

“I shall find something,” said the Manfredini after having darted in passing a keen look at her daughter.

“I will go, Mama!” exclaimed the latter, whose terrible anguish betrayed itself in her accent. But before she could throw herself before the door, the mother had entered precipitately.

The Armandi took the girl’s hand, to thank her, without taking her eyes from hers.

The Signora Manfredini returned almost at once, perfectly calm, holding in her hand a little bottle which she made the Contessa smell. Mother and daughter did not exchange a look.

The remedy seemed to benefit the Contessa immensely, and after five minutes she was returning to the drawing-room on the Signora Manfredini’s arm. Velleda stopped a little longer before the mirror to arrange some small disorder of her toilette, without even turning her eyes upon the glass. She accompanied with a long look through the mirror the two ladies, and when she was certain of being alone, she rushed into her room and swept it all in a single glance. There was no one. She ran to the window, a first floor above the ground, and found it half-open; she stifled a cry, and fell upon her knees.

The next day, at four o’clock, the Marchese Alberti presented himself to the Contessa Manfredini and asked for the hand of Mademoiselle Velleda.

CHAPTER XXV

The Marchese was not a diplomat, but he had thirty-two thousand lire of income, and the marriage was soon arranged.

"I knew it!" exclaimed the Contessa Armandi with a biting smile, when they gave her the news.

And she added, perhaps to soften or explain that singular assertion:

"That young man has a bump for marriage."

The same evening, as she was about to leave, she said to Alberto:

"I had told you that you would end by marrying her yourself. You are made for one another."

And she turned her back on him. Leaving, she did not notice his salute, and did not answer him; all at once, turning back and holding out her hand:

"By the bye, my congratulations!" she said to him.

Velleda loved her betrothed very much; but she loved him as she could love, with much reserve, and a little coldly in appearance. Alberto envied her the unalterable ease and the self-command. The electricity with which her ardent soul was charged hid itself under a glacial exterior, and crackled only in some flash of the eyes, or in the reticence of a smile, or in a pressure of the hand longer than usual, as they parted at the door that led into the garden. That modesty of *bon ton* had its grace.

The Signora Manfredini seemed Alberti's true lover; she stroked him, caressed him, flattered him, kept him close at her skirts, and

granted him the honor of offering her his arm very often, far more often than he would have desired. Someone among the friends of the house had asked which of the two Manfredini the Marchese Alberti was marrying.

The marriage had been fixed for September. The ladies Manfredini were to go in June to Leghorn, and Alberti was to join them, after having made a run through his estates, and given the directions for certain restorations that were needed at a little villa on the Lake of Como, which Uncle Bartolomeo had saved from the wreck of the paternal fortune, and in which the bride and groom were to pass the autumn.

At that time in Florence one talked of nothing but a great Roman lord, newly arrived, who had shown himself at the Cascine in a superb equipage. Prince Don Ferdinando Metelliani was a little man ten or twelve times a millionaire, who sat throned upon the four cushions of his phaeton like an ugly Apollo. The crowd stirred at his passing like a swarm of ants surprised by a peasant's foot, envied him, admired him, derided him, deified him; all eyes turned toward his shining coach; his name, his wealth, his age, his vices, ran upon everyone's lips; the most beautiful and the most retiring looked with greater attention than they are wont to grant a mere mortal at that little ape who stared at them insolently and blew in their faces the smoke of his Havana, and they found him chic because he drove his four horses upon the crowd as if he felt himself rich enough to pay for the bones he should break. The Prince descended from that Roman patriciate which had five centuries of existence when the most ancient nobility of Europe was ploughing the earth or serving in its legions; he was an officer in the Noble Guard, and this soldier, descendant of a family that had led to victory several generations of the masters of the world, had refused to fight a duel; he was forty years old, and had worn out all the pleasures of life; he heard mass every day, communicated twice a month, threw gold under the

slippers of courtesans, and had had his only sister shut up in a monastery so as not to give her a dowry. — Over all this, two million scudi.

Prince Metelliani frequented the best society of Florence, and had known the Signora Manfredini at the Neapolitan embassy; Velleda's haughty beauty had struck the dissolute patrician, and only before her, who did not turn a glance upon him, had he bowed his bald and proud head; he had set himself with the obstinacy of an all-powerful man to pay court to the only woman who did not pay it to him. Mademoiselle Manfredini was too proud to notice it, and when she saw the first cloud on Alberto's brow, she knitted her own. Once when the Prince had shown himself more gallant than usual, she, with an imperceptible sign, called her betrothed, who was hovering nearby, and presented him to Don Ferdinando. Those two men exchanged a greeting of cordial antipathy.

But the Contessa Manfredini coquetted with Metelliani in her daughter's place. When she entered a drawing-room on his arm, or when she could present him to her friends, she seemed radiant, and she had come to calling him simply Don Ferdinando. Don Ferdinando let her do so, graciously. The daughter, on the contrary, preserved an Olympian serenity; only when the noblest, the most beautiful, the most elegant women stooped to beg the attention of that little man, who seemed to care for no one but her, her rosy nostrils swelled ever so slightly. From time to time she was distracted or pensive; sometimes Alberto caught her fixing upon him a strange look, as if she saw him for the first time, and were examining him tacitly: she had never been willing to tell him why, and she always ended by bantering him.

The friends of the Manfredini house had arranged an excursion to Fiesole, and naturally the mother and daughter were of the party; as Alberti, still living as a bachelor, had only two horses, one of which was a saddle-horse, Prince Metelliani had put his carriage at the

disposal of the ladies Manfredini. This circumstance had given rise to a little dispute with Alberto, who was a little jealous of the Prince, without being willing to confess it; but the Contessa had displayed in the struggle all her worldly vanity, all her mother-in-law's high-handedness, and had won. Velleda had accommodated herself to the victory with the superb indifference that was peculiar to her. On the return from Fiesole the long line of carriages, headed by the Manfredinis' dazzling Dumont, had taken a turn through the Cascine, and at the turning of the piazzone the Prince had come to meet them on horseback. When Velleda, stretched softly in the superb calèche, turned a look upon that immense crowded square, and saw all eyes fixing themselves on the magnificent horses, on the rich liveries of that man who stood before her with his hat in his hand, her bosom swelled violently.

Alberti was in the wrong to take his leave a little abruptly that evening. Velleda had said to him, more coldly than usual:

“You have a singular character, really!”

When he went away she followed him with a look charged with thoughts; then she slightly raised her shoulders.

The next day they were about to go out in the carriage — a hired carriage — and seeing her betrothed still sulky Velleda said to him, laughing, as she buttoned her glove:

“Come!.... Would you be capable of being jealous of Metelliani?”

“No!” Alberto answered with a little air of pride just such as a jealous man's.

“So much the better!” she said — but she laughed no more.

CHAPTER XXVI

At the beginning of spring the Contessa Armandi had left for the country, and had shown herself no more at the Manfredini house; she had only returned in June for two or three days to Florence, before going to the baths; but chance had so arranged it that she had not met with Alberto again.

Signora Manfredini, without knowing why, had postponed until the second fortnight of the month the departure for Leghorn, and therefore Alberti too had delayed his. Velleda made not the slightest observation; yet she had grown peevish, capricious, moody, and sometimes even hard and unjust toward her betrothed. The mother took her daughter's part, and gave promise of a mother-in-law with all the trimmings, or rather with claws. Then Velleda would have moments of more expansive affection than usual, like assaults of repentance, which, with her character, seemed the more extraordinary.

Alberto had so high an idea of Velleda that he would have thought it a mortal insult to her if he had confessed the unjustifiable but invincible temptations of jealousy that assailed him from time to time. Metelliani was so base and so ugly that he would never have believed possible a thought of Velleda's for that man of whom he was jealous. Don Ferdinando had meanwhile become one of the most assiduous habitués of the little villa Flora. Signora Manfredini always found a way of letting this fact fall into the conversation, and Velleda could not help being inwardly flattered by it, since Don Ferdinando

was the idol of the highest society, and the noblest ladies were jealous of that preference. Metelliani possessed that great-gentleman's ease which adapts itself equally to impertinence and to fine manners; the respectful homage of that man, proud and contemptuous toward all others, must have flattered enormously the self-love of the vain girl; she had ended by thanking him for it with a graceful word, with a smile, with a glance, always, however, with that shadowy reserve which was her fairest attraction. Alberti suffered like a damned soul, blushed and grew angry with himself, but without being able to master it. Willy-nilly, it was he alone who, amid so many smiles, played the part of the tedious one, and Mama Manfredini made him understand it in every way; the daughter, who was a trifle proud, bit her lips without saying a word.

"Have you repented of having given me your word?" she asked him one day, leaving off playing with her little dog.

"I!... how?... But why do you say that to me?..."

Velleda set off chasing Gemma so madly along the garden walks that Alberto could add nothing more, and he dared not throw himself at her feet.

As Metelliani neglected no occasion of showing his assiduous friendship toward the ladies Manfredini, he had insisted upon having the honor of accompanying them to the last fête at Court. The ladies had accepted. Passing through that crowd of uniforms, of decorations, of worldly grandeurs, leaning upon the arm of that man whose name ran on every tongue, who held his head high in the Grand Duke's house, Velleda felt something she had never felt before, which made her lift her head with an imperceptible movement, as if she had wished to throw over her shoulders, after the fashion of a royal mantle, the rich mass of her hair. She cast upon the prince a rapid, dazzling glance, in which the sparkle of his decorations and the embroidery of his uniform seemed to be reflected.

What a wretched evening for poor Alberti, who had to endure the mother, and saw his betrothed always at a distance, abandoning herself with radiant carelessness to the pleasure of being courted! He tried to draw near the Contessa Armandi, so as to remain neither alone nor with his mother-in-law; but the Contessa too turned her back on him—though without having noticed it, to be sure—for, meeting him a little later, she showed herself most amiable, took his arm, and set about walking through the rooms.

After chatting a good while of various subjects she asked him, with a singular accent:

“Are you amusing yourself?”

The question was the simplest in the world, but Alberto found himself embarrassed in answering: “I perceive,” he said at last, “that I am not made for these amusements.”

“What would you have! Sometimes one must sacrifice oneself for others. Velleda enjoys herself so much! is that not a pleasure for you?”

“Yes,” he answered, very dryly.

The Contessa had one of those bursts of hilarity that made her formidable; so that Alberto turned purple. But at once she, to show him in a certain way the true cause of that laughter with a double aim, added:

“That poor Metelliani looks to me like an Indian rajah, so tricked out and loaded with diamonds.”

Alberto shot at the Roman rajah a glance which the Armandi caught.

“Without flattery, do you know that yours is a fine triumph?” she said to him. “It would depend only on Velleda to see all those trinkets laid at her feet, and to have a princess’s coronet at the carriage door!...”

“If I were grateful to you for such a preference it would seem to me an insult to my betrothed,” answered Alberto, trying to adapt himself to the Armandi’s bantering air, but with too much vivacity.

The Contessa planted upon his face a sharp look and an incredulous smile, and said to him quietly:

“You are jealous!”

“I?... of that fellow!...”

“Proud man!...”

And she began to beat time with her fan to the music that was being played. “Ta... ta... ta... Shall we sit here?”

She changed the subject, and they set themselves to watching the coming and going of the crowd. A little later the Contessina Manfredini and Prince Metelliani passed by. The Armandi had not said a single word, but she broke off in the middle of the sentence she had begun, and simply followed them with her gaze. Velleda sent them from a distance a graceful nod.

“Will you too come to Leghorn?” the Armandi asked the prince.

“Yes.”

“But Tuscany is positively stealing him!”

“I ask nothing better than to be stolen, beautiful Contessa.”

She burst into ironic laughter, but she flushed. “Pray help yourself!” she said to him, turning half her back.

Alberto too had turned to flame in the face; he cast at Don Ferdinando a challenging glance, and said to him in a slightly trembling voice:

“It is singular, however, that you have been seeking in vain for some time.”

Velleda bit her lips, and seized the first pretext for withdrawing.

“What have you done, you rash man!” exclaimed the Armandi when they were alone. “You have ruined yourself!”

“How?... why?...”

“You have furnished Velleda with the weapons she was seeking!... Let us part, let us part!”

The ladies Manfredini left as they had come, together with Alberti. Velleda spoke little, and, alighting from the carriage, offered him her hand as usual. He left her a little abruptly.

The next day, going to the little villa Flora, he was told that the ladies were in the garden; but he found there only Velleda, who was reviewing her flowers. The girl greeted him coldly, went on talking for some five minutes with the gardener of gardenias and magnolias, answering Alberto's questions with monosyllables, and then set out slowly toward the house, preceding him by a few steps. Before reaching the door she stopped short, and said to him, turning toward him:

“Sir, I beg you to take back your word.” Alberto remained for an instant stunned. “Why?” he stammered.

“Let us not both lower ourselves with superfluous explanations: you know the reason far better than I. You are perfectly free to follow your inclinations, but I beg you to respect me enough not to make me a spectator of them. Let us part quietly, as well-bred people, as good friends, while there is yet time.”

Alberti said not a word, and remained as if of stone, gazing at her as she toyed absently in the air with the flowers she had gathered. “Listen, Velleda!” he exclaimed then with a burst of affection; “I could wish to kiss the sand you tread upon!... Thank you!...”

The Contessina looked at him astonished. “For what?...”

“You are jealous!... Then you still love me!” Velleda knitted her brow, and for an instant seemed troubled and hesitating. “Who has told you that I am jealous?” she answered then haughtily.

“But then?... But why?... But then why do you wish to leave me?”

After a few moments the young girl raised the head she had held bowed, and answered slowly:

“Because we do not suit each other.... We have been mistaken. Let us set it right while we are in time.”

“And setting it right will cost you nothing?” asked Alberto, pale as wax.

“Nothing,” she said after a few moments.

“Let us set it right, then!”

They took a few steps in silence.

“We leave the day after tomorrow for Leghorn,” resumed Velleda in a calm voice. “This evening we shall go to the Armandi’s, and tomorrow we shall pay the last farewell visits; then we shall be extremely occupied until the moment of departure; so we shall be able to silence the gossip of the indiscreet for the present. During the bathing season we shall have all the time we need to arrange matters in the most convenient way....”

Alberto bowed in silence.

“Is it useless for me to see your mother again?” he asked her.

“It is useless; she knows everything.”

She held out her hand languidly, barely brushed his, and went into the house.

“Poor Adele!” murmured Alberto, as if only then he guessed what his poor cousin must have suffered, when the sharpest pain of life had bitten her.

CHAPTER XXVII

The Marchese Alberti found at his house a note announcing the approaching marriage of his friend Gemmati with his cousin Forlani.

“Sometimes chance has a singular logic!” he thought.

His old servant came to bring him the lamp toward eight o’clock, although he had not asked for it, and inquired discreetly whether he felt unwell, and whether he wished to dine at home.

“No,” answered Alberto. “Do you know, Toni? Adele is getting married! She is marrying Gemmati!”

The Contessa Armandi occupied a very beautiful apartment in Via Larga, and as it had a garden attached, she still received, although the season was well advanced. Toward ten o’clock Alberto went to Via Larga, and had his visiting-card sent in to the Contessa.

She came to meet him at the drawing-room door. She was too great a lady to ask him any question; but she was too much a woman to resist the temptation of launching her little claw-stroke.

“What good fortune?... at last!” she said to him, holding out her hand.

Alberto seemed calm, and had a nervous smile that might pass for ease. Sitting beside her on the sofa, he thanked her for having lifted the interdiction that forbade him to pass her door.

“Do not thank me, for I have no merit in it....” replied the Armandi, fixing upon his face, like interrogation points, her eyes and her smile.

It was still too early, and the Contessa and Alberti remained alone for half an hour talking of indifferent things.

“And the ladies Manfredini?” asked the Armandi absently.

“They will come later.... probably.”

The Contessa let that *probably* pass, and changed the subject.

Little by little the friends of the house began to arrive, and the Armandi presented the Marchese Alberti as if he had arrived from Australia. The conversation became general. Toward eleven the Manfredini entered with the inseparable Don Ferdinando. The Contessa, rising to go and receive them, furtively pressed Alberto’s hand, and whispered these words:

“Prudence! I entreat you.”

Velleda possessed a perfect ease, and although Alberti’s unexpected presence at the Armandi’s must have surprised her, she showed nothing of it. Metelliani seemed radiant; the Contessa Manfredini was majestic.

Some had sat down to play; two or three ladies were humming and trying over music at the piano, in an undertone; the principal group was between the two windows of the drawing-room, near the sofa, where were the Armandi, the two Manfredini, Don Ferdinando, and Alberto. Many words were spoken, because nearly all the actors in that scene had a preoccupation to conceal. Alberto made a display of a feverish gaiety that crackled in paradoxes and epigrams. Velleda, after having cast at him secretly two or three glances between surprise and curiosity, had taken part in the conversation with her usual sparkle. The Armandi, like a skillful conductor, directed the performance, and gave the tone to the general conversation.

At that time there was talk of nothing in Florence but a poor girl who had asphyxiated herself with charcoal, because they wished to force her to marry one man while she loved another. The novelty of that kind of death, the death of the poor in purse and in spirit, had put

the subject in fashion; it was much discussed in aristocratic drawing-rooms, and the ladies aired over it their scented sentimentalism; the Armandi alone had guessed that it was a dangerous topic, and tried to change the subject; but Alberto clung to it with avid obstinacy, as if he felt himself strong on that ground, and displayed for the occasion a provocative cynicism.

“I wager that the fiancé proposed to this girl was not rich,” he said.

“Why?” asked Signora Manfredini imprudently.

“Because if he had been rich, the girl would have resigned herself to marrying him instead of killing herself.”

“How horrible!” exclaimed the ladies, waving their fans.

“Ladies, we cannot judge of this with our ideas. She was a poor girl of the people...”

“And for that?... Could she not love?...” interrupted Don Ferdinando, who was in his quarter-hour of tenderness.

Alberto laughed in his face insolently.

“And what has love to do with that?...”

The ladies were embarrassed, including the Armandi, who did not know what bearing to assume. Signora Manfredini had turned as red as a turkey; but the daughter had remained perfectly mistress of herself, fanning herself, however, with a little animation. She alone had the courage to fight, with the same weapons, against that desperate man who was intoxicating himself with epigrams.

“Have you news of your cousin Adele?” she asked him quietly, as if to turn the conversation.

“My cousin is very well; and she is marrying my friend Gemmati,” answered Alberti in the same tone.

“You do not believe in love, then!” insisted Metelliani with a millionaire’s stubbornness, and seeking to compromise him in Velleda’s eyes, for he too was jealous of Alberto.

The latter planted his eyes in the other's; and answered ironically:

"The subject is beginning to bore these ladies. Shall we rather have a game of cards?"

The prince seemed to hesitate; but at last he bowed his head, and preceded him to the little table. While Alberti followed him the Armandi said to him softly:

"Alberto!"

He did not notice the troubled accent and the confidential word; he reassured her with a counterfeit smile, and passed into the other room.

The two players sat down facing each other. The Armandi, uneasy, came and leaned upon the back of a chair, appearing to take a great interest in the game; Velleda did not betray herself, but she was uneasy too, and hovered about the card-room with a restlessness she could not master. The two adversaries, seated so that they almost touched, did not raise their eyes from the cards; they seemed completely absorbed in the game, and in the candlelight they were pale.

Alberti played like a man in a fever, and who loses upon his word. His eyes fixed themselves from time to time, glittering, upon the prince's face, which remained impassive, and in the shadow of the screen seemed of marble. Metelliani was too much a man of the world to give Alberti the slightest pretext for a provocation; he played coldly, as a great gentleman, and was lucky as a millionaire. Both said only the indispensable words—the prince with his unalterable phlegm, Alberto arming them with all the points of epigram, without succeeding in making his adversary's eyes flash, or his face flush; he lost always. At last, as if that calculated imperturbability had made him lose his head, he rose, threw the money upon the table with an insolent air, and said to Don Ferdinando:

“You asked me whether I believed in love. Now that we are alone I tell you that I believe in it when, instead of gaining something by it, one loses—as I believe in a player’s honesty when he does not always win.”

And he remained standing on the other side of the table, still provoking with his attitude. The prince at last raised his eyes to him, stroked his little beard, and answered coldly:

“I have a hundred and twenty thousand scudi a year, sir.” He rose as well, and turned his back on him.

Alberto felt a trembling hand seize him by the arm.

“You had promised me!” the Armandi said to him, pale herself.

He passed a hand over his forehead, as if to set his thoughts in order.

“You are right!... I beg your pardon! I do not know where my head is!”

They remained silent, both of them, standing by the window.

The last carriage, which was that of the Manfredini, passed the door. Alberto hid his face in his hands and burst into tears.

“You suffer too!... at last!...” burst out the Armandi, with an inexpressible accent.

Alberto remained stunned by that violent explosion of an inexplicable feeling which that woman had concealed beneath her frivolity, and which now burst forth full of anger and of tears. He seized her hands, and looked at her for some moments with a thousand confused sentiments in his eyes burning with tears.

“You love me!” he exclaimed.

The flame of pride dried her eyes in a flash.

“I?” she said, frowning and with impetuosity. “Are you mad?”

He was not listening to her: he had a storm in his soul.

She tore her hands violently from his, drew herself up to the full height of her beautiful person, and remained a moment with her eyes closed, pressing her breast with her hands.

“Marchese!” she said then quietly. “Know that I respect myself immensely.”

Alberto raised his head, looked at her wildly, as if he did not understand what was happening outside himself, and then stammered:

“Forgive me! I am mad...”

And then he burst out with desperate bitterness:

“Yes, I am mad... look!”

“Let us part friends,” said the Contessa after a brief pause, “true friends.”

CHAPTER XXVIII

It was not yet eight in the morning, and Alberto was already about to leave the house, when Toni came to tell him that a person, who had something pressing to speak of, was waiting for him in a carriage at the door.

Alberto saw, huddled in the corner of the fiacre, a veiled lady. When he had seated himself, the Armandi said to him with animated concision:

“What do you mean to do?”

“Nothing.”

“Nothing is too little! You were already about to go out at eight in the morning! Had I reason, then, to be uneasy?”

“Well,” she resumed after a brief silence, “tell me the truth: do you mean to fight?”

Alberti bowed his head without answering.

“Prince Metelliani is most religious, and is not in the habit of fighting. What could you do to force him to it? Slap him? He will have recourse to the courts, and to avenge himself he will have you mortally insulted by a servant of his who will be overjoyed to earn a decent tip by going to prison for his master. Do not commit follies, for pity’s sake! They will serve nothing.”

“It is true,” answered Alberti in a brief tone.

“We have said we are true friends, and I have therefore the right to give you advice. First of all, why would you fight? For spite or for jealousy?”

“I do not know...” answered the young man after a pause.

“You do not know?... already!...” she said with a gay smile—“so much the better!”

They were going along the great avenue of the Cascine; the air was still cool, the sky was blue; and the great trees rose on either side like immense walls of verdure. For a long stretch Alberto and the Contessa remained silent, looking absently at the groves. At last the young man cast two or three furtive glances at her, and said hesitatingly:

“Have you really forgiven me?”

“For what?” she asked, darting a penetrating glance at him.

He fell silent; but the Contessa, without giving him time to open his mouth, added with a burst of coquettish laughter:

“Ah!.... I had thought of it no more!”

The Armandi, despite the oddity of her character, had shown herself, as she had promised, a true and sincere friend to Alberti in the tedious period that had followed his rupture with the Manfredini. He went to see her more often, and found pleasure in chatting with her of indifferent things or in unburdening himself of his black humor. The Contessa possessed the rare quality of knowing how to listen. More than once the young man had caught himself in mute contemplation of that fine, aristocratic hand which indolently caressed the ribbon of her little gorget, the puffs of her fichu, and he would puzzle over where he had seen it another time.

The Armandi too was leaving for the baths, and little by little Alberto had ended by going to see her almost every day. On the eve of the departure they had lingered longer than usual on the little

terrace, contemplating the last rays of the dying sun. Alberto was taciturn, and the Contessa too had spoken very little.

“You are not at all cheerful this evening!” she said, as if to drive away the sadness that was invading her as well.

“Will you stay long at the baths?”

“It will depend on my husband; but then we shall go to the Lake of Como.”

He bowed his head and remained silent. She too became abstracted.

Then she said to him, lowering her voice, without knowing herself why:

“Truly.... are you sorry that I am leaving?”

“Yes,” answered Alberto without raising his head.

The Contessa fell silent again. At last she took his hand, and said to him softly, in a moved voice:

“I do not love you, I cannot love you, and I shall never love you. After what has been between us we can be nothing but friends.—Will you?”

He pressed the hand she held out to him, without having the courage to say a single word.

The next day Alberti had gone to take leave of the Contessa. At the moment of parting she asked him:

“Will you come to see me on the lake?”

“Yes.”

“Do not fail. Come between the fifteenth and the twentieth of August.”

And after a few moments:

“What will you do now? Will you remain in Florence this summer?”

“I do not know.”

“Go into the country, to the baths, travel. You have need of distraction; listen to your friend.... and above all try to fall in love, but with judgment, mind! enough not to lose your head over it.... Farewell.”

CHAPTER XXIX

The Contessa had promised Alberto to write to him, but she had done nothing of the kind. She was a little surprised, and, let us say it, even vexed at seeing no letter arrive from the young Marchese. He, on the other side, stubbornly refused to write to her because she had not troubled to send him a single line—and both, without perceiving it, were sulking, exactly like two lovers. The woman was fighting also with Eve's curiosity, and she was the first to be vanquished.

"My friend," she wrote to him, "are you dead? are you alive? where are you? Since the newspapers bring no news of you, you will permit your friend to inquire directly. Have you then followed my advice? already in love? or have you turned Trappist? You promised to come and see me on the lake between the fifteenth and the twentieth, and it is already the twenty-fourth!"

On receiving that letter Alberto had remembered the sweet and melancholy sunsets on the Arno, when the Contessa stood beside him, thoughtful; but reading its contents he fell from the seventh heaven; and, child that he was, he had the temerity to wish to fight on the same ground and with the same weapons against one who was stronger than he; he answered:

"I have followed your advice: I have traveled! I am in Milan, and I am amusing myself famously. I am in love, with judgment, with a pretty girl whom I had met at a masked ball at the Pergola, and whom I saw again here at a certain suburban tavern, where a friend of mine—I have many friends—who is taking a wife, was giving us a mad

dinner to make an end of his follies. Her name is Selene—the beloved—(a fine name for the boards, is it not?) a dancer at the Royal Theatre of La Scala, first quadrille; she marches on tiptoe as if it were nothing at all, and we love each other beyond words. Seeing me she recognized me at once, and made an *oh!* that made us old friends. She calls me *biondino*. Our friendship has been easy and prompt, and it is for this that it is without a cloud. You see then, my friend, that there is nothing to fear for my head. We do not tear our hair, we have not the paltriest jealous rival to challenge, nor the smallest balcony to scale; there is not the most innocent tear, not even the shadow of a true and great passion.... But so it is, one lives all the same. My Selene is very beautiful—nothing more—and she says many kind things to me in her fashion, among others that she would love me even if I were as poor as Job, and that my purse has nothing to do with my happiness. I take her at her word, and I have weaned her from beer; she is teaching me a little Milanese, so we improve each other. Sometimes, it is true, she remains staring at me with her eyes wide open—she has magnificent great eyes—as if I were talking Turkish to her; but it will be because she does not understand my Tuscan well, or because I bore her with my fancies: but they are fancies and they will pass. Speaking of fancies, do you know? the Contessina Manfredini has gone to Castellammare with Prince Metelliani—and Mama, of course.—They passed through Florence. Everyone there said that she will come back either a princess or dead.

“Conclusion: If I turned Trappist, should I not be right?”

The Contessa was about to reply with a letter that began: “You are truly on the way to turning Trappist!” but she thought better of it and tore up the sheet. Alberto, who was burning to have an answer, after two days could no longer keep up his part, and wrote:

“My Contessa, I do not know why, truly, but I am as sad as a funeral; that poor girl is not to blame, nor am I. I have decided to change the air, and I need you to scold me and advise me like the boy

that I am. I remember that there, on the shores of the Lario, there must be a certain little villa of mine, which was destined to be my nuptial nest. I drive away the fear of marriage, and I come to nestle there tomorrow itself: it will be the thirtieth of the month.—Since it is written that my visits must always arrive late, will you permit me to present myself to you tomorrow in the evening?”

Reading that letter the Contessa smiled, and then grew serious. She reread the few lines two or three times, consulted the calendar, sat down at the table to write, and at last shut the letter in the drawer, and rose.

CHAPTER XXX

The day had been hot and stormy, but the evening was enchanting. The moon was rising behind the mountains, a few little white clouds were still scattered across the sky, the lake seemed the color of steel, furrowed here and there by sudden luminous streaks; from time to time, at long intervals, a breath of cool breeze made the trees rustle and the waters of the lake undulate.

The Contessa Armandi had passed one of those cross-grained days on which she would have given I know not what to be able to say that she had a headache: she had been idle, restless, nervous, bored; she had wandered about the drawing-room, looked at herself in the mirror, stationed herself at the window, then begun to read, thrown the book aside and leaned against the *étagère*, watching the clock-hand with a yawn, and had remained watching it for half an hour without noticing it; at last she opened the piano, and set herself to playing, at first listlessly. Suddenly the gate-bell was rung; then she made a movement.

“The Marchese Alberti,” announced the servant.

The Contessa nodded, without turning, and continued to play.

Alberto entered, approached the piano, and placed himself behind her; she greeted him with a nod, without turning her eyes upon him, warming to a difficulty of Schubert's. At last she stopped playing abruptly, and rose.

“What a pity!” exclaimed Alberto. “Go on, I beg you!”

“No, it bores me.—How are you?”

“Very well; but you are not as usual.”

“I? You are mistaken. How did you come?”

“By boat, from the lake. I heard your music as I approached the villa, and I should perhaps have done better to stay there listening....”

“You would have done worse, because I was horribly bored. Do you like that piece?”

“Very much.”

“Play it, then.”

“Willingly, if you wish it.”

“Not for me!” she said, turning her back on him.

“For whom, then?”

“Why.... for those who are on the lake.... for the fishermen.”

Alberto had remained motionless: then he began to draw on his gloves again, and went to sit near her, who had seated herself on the sofa, leafing through a new book.

“What is the matter?” he asked her softly, after having waited in vain for her to raise her eyes.

“Nothing. What do you find in me? It has been a wretched day. That is all.”

“And I have come at a wretched moment?”

“On the contrary, I was expecting you.”

“What are you reading?”

“A piece of nonsense”—and she threw the book away—“play something, then!”

“What do you wish me to play?”

“Whatever you like.... that *Addio* of Schubert’s.”

“But if you do not like it!...”

She shrugged her shoulders with an inimitable movement.

Alberti sat down at the piano. The Armandi leaned upon the music-stand, then began to leaf through some music, at last went to take up again the book she had thrown away.

Alberti turned, stopped playing, and remained some minutes with his eyes fixed upon her, his elbow resting on the piano and his forehead on his hand. Suddenly he rose and approached the sofa.

"Have you finished?" asked the Armandi, raising her eyes in surprise to him.

"Yes, had you not noticed?" She smiled, and closed the book.

"What do you do at Bellagio? is there much company? do you amuse yourself? are you bored?"

"Yes," answered Alberto absently.

The Armandi cast him a glance between the absent and the penetrating, and set about rearranging the objects on the table.

"Is the evening beautiful?" she asked then, without thinking of what she was saying.

He turned his eyes to the wide-open window, which framed the most beautiful moonlight, and answered:

"Most beautiful."

"Have you been on the lake today?"

"I came by boat, I told you so."

The conversation, deprived of nourishment, fell away altogether. The Contessa looked about her, as if seeking a pretext to break that silence.

"There are cigars on the little table," she said to him; "smoke, by all means, we are in the country."

"Thank you."

"Tell me: what is there that is new? What do they say at Bellagio?"

"They say the silkworms are doing very well."

"Ah! We shall have cheap silk, then?"

“Certainly!”

“What good fortune!”

Suddenly the door opened, and a pretty little girl of nearly five came running in, and went to throw herself into the Contessa’s arms.

“Gently, darling!” exclaimed the mother, kissing her. “What will the gentleman say of a young lady who comes in so madly?”

The child turned to look at the gentleman with great timid and curious eyes. Alberto said to her, putting his arms around her:

“Will you allow me to give you a nice kiss, mademoiselle?”

The child, very seriously, consented with a nod, and held out her rosy cheek.

“How beautiful she is, and how she resembles you!” said Alberto, kissing her.

The Contessa rang a little hastily, and consigned her daughter to the governess.

“Why send her away?...” asked Alberto, surprised by that abrupt dismissal.

“It is late for her, it is nearly ten;” she answered very dryly.

Alberti rose.

“But I am not a child!” said the Contessa, laughing, and withdrew the hand he was pressing in order to take his leave.

“I have come at a bad moment indeed!”

“No.”

“I am not boring you?”

“Talk, be silent, read, play, but do not leave me alone with my boredom, for I should be capable of throwing myself into the lake,” she said with the same smile.

“So much the better!”

The Armandi cast him a silent glance, and leaned against the back of the sofa, contemplating the designs on the fan.

A long silence ensued.

“And your dancer?” she asked then, absently.

“She is very well,” answered Alberto without raising his eyes from the album.

And they were silent again.

All at once Alberti fixed his eyes on her face and asked:

“Why do you ask me about my dancer?”

“So... to talk of something...”

He closed the album, rose, went to see what hour the clock showed, and sat down again without opening his mouth.

The Contessa had followed him with her gaze, and had grown thoughtful. In her turn she too fixed her eyes on his face, and said to him:

“Why does it vex you that I should speak to you of your dancer?”

“It does not vex me,” answered Alberti a little abruptly.

“Need I remind you of our compact?” resumed the Armandi after a slight hesitation. “Are we no longer friends as before? Have I no longer the right to take an interest in you? to give you advice when the occasion arises? You are young and full of heart—too much so, perhaps.—Did I not tell you that that girl suits you, since she is not dangerous to your imagination?”

“Thank you.”

Another long silence ensued.

“Listen to me,” resumed the Contessa at last, while Alberti sat with his head bowed. “I have always spoken to you with such frankness that I have not even left you the right to be unjust. You know that I do not love you, and that I shall never love you, but that I am very fond of you—in another way—and that your friendship is most dear to me.

But the day on which you love me will be a great evil, think of it! If I have a lover I shall tell you of it first—nothing more—to prove to you the frankness of my feelings, and to compel you to remain what I desire you to be for me. Is that enough? Can you promise me always to keep our relations within these limits? You are a man of honor—go or stay.”

Alberto remained silent for some moments. Then he answered:

“You are right.”

The Contessa pressed his hand.

“This evening I have been cross, and perhaps even unkind”—she resumed gaily.—“It is a matter of nerves; forgive me, my friend. Shall I play you a piece to reward you for the boredom?”

“Yes,” he answered absently.

The Armandi sat down at the piano, and played at length without interruption. Alberti seemed to listen attentively, silently, and when she rose, a little tired, he did not so much as open his mouth to thank her.

The woman, seated in the darkest corner, had been silent for some time; the silence was profound; from time to time a breath of breeze pushed toward the interior of the drawing-room the gauze curtains and the perfume of the flowers that were on the terrace; from the open window one saw the surface of the lake rippling in silver streaks.

At last the Contessa rose without saying a word and went slowly out onto the terrace. Alberti followed her. They leaned upon the balustrade, looking at the lake. Not a light was to be seen; midnight was striking slowly.

“Already!” murmured the Armandi.

Alberto took his hat to go. She barely answered his farewell, and did not even turn to see him leave. She heard vaguely the closing of

the vestibule door, and a little later the Marchese's steps in the avenue.

"Is your boat down there?" she asked suddenly and with animation from the height of the terrace.

"Yes."

"Can you row?"

"I believe so."

"Send the boatman away, and wait for me."

After a few moments he saw her appear before him, drawing on her gloves, with a veil over her head, her face white and serious, her eyes glittering.

"Can you really row?" she repeated briefly and without turning her eyes upon him.

"Yes, yes."

She sprang into the boat without adding another word, and sat down in the stern.

The little boat glided over the tranquil waters, and when they were far from the shore, Alberto dropped the oars. The Contessa watched in silence the luminous streak that fled before them on the dark surface of the lake, and the water that rippled sparkling about the oars. She was half reclining on the cushions, holding her head a little thrown back upon the carpet that grazed the waters, and looking upward; from time to time she darted a glance at Alberto, who kept his eyes turned elsewhere, and said not a word. The silence had a voluptuous charm; that pale light seemed to pour forth waves of I know not what seductive mist; one o'clock was striking. The woman turned her head indolently toward the place where the last strokes were still undulating, and all at once, fixing her glittering eyes on Alberto's face, she said to him, in that languid posture and with a brusque and almost irritated accent:

“Marchese Alberti, if at this moment there were in you also the Conte Armandi, and if one half of your person swore to the other half that he was not his wife’s lover, would you believe it?”

Alberto remained stunned. Then he started up all at once, and said to her in a trembling, stifled voice:

“Contessa, if now you had to throw yourself into the lake, or into my arms, which would you prefer to do?”

She had risen too; she stood upright in the stern, slightly pale, with wandering looks, her lips ashen and smiling.

“At least I should not wish to commit one folly after another,” she answered with a crackle of convulsive laughter.

He seized her hands.

“Wait!” she said, serious, resolute, and in an agitated voice. “Would you swear to throw yourself into the lake..... if I wished it?”

“Yes.”

His sudden movement threatened to capsize the little boat. The Contessa staggered, uttered a little cry:

“Let us not begin at the end!” she said.

The first glimmerings of dawn were whitening the sky when the boat touched the shore. The moon was wan, the lake seemed darker; the Contessa was pale, pensive, she seemed vexed. She sprang quickly onto the bank so as not to touch the hand the young man offered her; she pushed the little boat brusquely with her little boot, and set out at a slow pace toward the gate, looking with absent eyes at the light that still burned in the drawing-room.

“Farewell,” she said to him in an uncertain voice, without looking at him, her head bowed.

CHAPTER XXXI

Alberto set out slowly, wandering at random with a cigar in his mouth, his face pale, his eye burning and fixed before him, looking mechanically at the lake, the mountains, the people he met. The fresh morning air made his lungs expand with force, and seemed to infuse him with an exuberance of life. The song of the birds, the thousand scents of the fields, the first rays of the sun, penetrated him vaguely, subtly, with another aspect, as though they belonged to him and were in the world only for him, incarnating themselves confusedly in an image fixed in his brain, in his heart, before his eyes. His thought was inert or vertiginous; all the events of that night jostled confusedly against one another in his memory, and dazzled him with the luminous intermittence of the electric light. He could not have expressed what he felt, whether he was happy or not; he felt a great bewilderment, a feverish desire, an immense joy, tumultuous, restless—and she, always there, before his eyes, within him, everywhere.

The streets were beginning to fill, the lake swarmed with little boats, and Alberti kept wandering about that villa which exerted a fascination upon him. She must be there, behind every shutter, anxious, longing as he was, seeking him too with her eyes, with her memories, with her reverie. He contemplated that terrace where they had been together, that balustrade against which she had leaned, that flight of steps by which she had descended, that lake upon which their little boat had rocked softly, surrounded by discreet, sweet, mysterious darkness. All those things were now flooded with

sunlight, without shadows, without veils, petulant. He heard within himself that word—"Wait for me"—and that little stifled cry.

Toward eleven he could no longer resist the desire to see her again, as though he had left her a century before, and he went. The maid told him that she was sleeping. He had it repeated to him twice, as though he himself were not quite awake, and turned away. Then he came back, and left for her his visiting-card, upon which he wrote in English, in pencil:

"I envy you who can sleep."

He went to the hotel, threw himself upon the bed, and slept two or three hours a drunkard's sleep. A letter from her came to startle him awake.

"My friend," it said, "will you come tomorrow at four? I shall have Signora Rigalli as well, and we shall have some music. I count upon you. Today I dine with the Corvetti."

The handwriting was elegant, traced with a firm hand; the signature was in full: "Emilia Armandi."

The poor young man remained half an hour turning and turning over in his hands that little scented sheet, and rereading those two lines so simple, so clear, which he could not succeed in understanding.

He passed the whole day in a kind of drowsiness and bewilderment, thinking of her, of what she might be doing, of what had happened, of why she ordered him not to see her until the morrow, of how she could wait until that morrow without suffering as he suffered. He started at remembering with miraculous precision her words, the tone of her voice, the perfume of her hair; he stood looking at the lake, that same lake, which was beginning to grow dark, and upon which the stars were beginning to sparkle. Among the disorder of his ideas there was one more insistent than the others: why she had made him promise to throw himself into the lake, and

why she had not then commanded him to do it. Did she know that he would not have obeyed her, and that such a love made him a coward?

The next day, setting out toward four o'clock for the Villa Armandi, he met Signora Rigalli, who was going to embark together with a merry party.

"Are you not going to the Contessa Armandi's?" he asked her with a little surprise.

"No. Emilia was to have come with us, indeed, but this morning she wrote me that she has changed her mind. Will you be of our party?"

"Thank you, I cannot;" and he moved away, puzzling over why the Armandi, in a note of three lines, had thrown in even the music and Signora Rigalli.

He found the Contessa in her drawing-room, upon her sofa, surrounded by her friends, men and women; he was received with her best smile, and was presented to the others without the slightest embarrassment. She was perfectly mistress of herself, full of spirit and ease—she even jested at his somewhat wild-eyed air—she spoke of races upon the lake, of pleasure-parties, of the adventures of the bathing season. Someone asked after Conte Armandi, who was still in Turin although the session had been closed this long while.

"He will come as soon as possible," the Contessa answered, "when he has finished I know not what work of I know not what parliamentary committee"—and turning to the lady at her side she added, smiling: "That blessed politics is a dangerous rival."

Alberto listened to her voice, and looked at her beautiful hands, adorned with wide lace cuffs, which she pulled up when they fell along her arm. At her last words he fixed his eyes upon her face; then he blushed, without knowing why, looked away, and took part in the conversation with a nervous vivacity, by fits and starts, with long

interruptions that would have greatly surprised all those who were present, had they not all been perfectly well-bred.

“Are you not going with Signora Rigalli?” he asked all at once.

The Contessa turned upon him a tranquil glance and answered:

“No.”

“She told me, however, that she was counting upon you....”

“Souvent femme varie!” the Armandi answered with the utmost ease, and smiling a little.

CHAPTER XXXII

At last the visitors went away little by little. Alberti and the Armandi remained alone, seated one beside the other, and for some instants silent.

The Contessa rose suddenly, drew away from him abruptly, cast an uncertain glance about her, then came toward him resolutely, making the skirts of her dress rustle with the hiss of an irritated serpent, and planted herself before his face.

“What is the matter with you? speak at last! speak!” she exclaimed angrily.

“Nothing; what should be the matter with me?” he answered harshly.

The woman’s lips trembled convulsively, and stirred two or three times as if to speak. But all at once she broke out in an indescribable accent, covering her face with her hands:

“Ah! how you punish me!”

He rose, took her hands, which slipped from him, and remained some time without finding a word. “What have I done to you?” he stammered at last.

“You have done nothing to me!” the Armandi exclaimed disdainfully.

Alberto took her hand again; this time she abandoned it to him without perceiving it; she kept her eyes fixed upon the carpet, grim,

scowling. All at once she said to him in a short, agitated voice, planting in his face a glance lucid and cold as steel:

“Because I have given myself to you! Five minutes before becoming your mistress I would rather have thrown myself into the lake, had I been able to imagine it! Now you have the right to doubt it!”

Alberto turned red and pale. “Do you not love me?” he said to her, loosening her hand.

“What would you think of me now if I did not love you?” she answered, smiling a smile that lifted her upper lip with an expression of untranslatable bitterness. “But I should not have wished to be your mistress... I swear it to you by my daughter... by my daughter!” she repeated with force, looking at him haughtily in the eyes, and shaking his hand, as she observed an imperceptible movement of his. “You had preferred another woman to me, and I was proud...”—and bowing her head with a sarcastic and fierce resignation: “Now you see that I am so no longer!”

She sank back upon the armchair and hid her face in her handkerchief, without moving any more, without saying a word, so proud and scornful that Alberto did not dare to draw aside so much as a corner of that handkerchief.

“What have I done to you?” he replied at last, clasping his hands. “Do you not see how I suffer, how I love you, how I have suffered at not being able to see you?... Have you read my card?”

“Yes.... and my maid before me.”

“I wrote in English for that very reason....”

“You should have written in Camaldolese: it would have been less suspicious, and less compromising.”

She spoke low, with calm, with an accent of ironical resignation, her face downcast, and her hands crossed upon her knees.

“I was wrong!” Alberto answered, somewhat vexed; “forgive me. I loved you, I had lost my head. I did not think of the proprieties, of the world, of the servants... I needed to think of you.... to do something for you.... I had nothing else to say to you....”

“Not even that you would have made music with Signora Rigalli, so as not to compromise yourself by your writing. Is it not so?” the woman interrupted.

“Oh!”

“Why do you blush at having reproached me with it half an hour ago? You were right!” she resumed with the same calm in her speech, in her accent, in her countenance and in her attitude. “Your love is open, frank, and sincere—I have spoken before you of my husband, and I have not blushed in the presence of those who heard me. I have feigned indifference and ease; I have lied toward you, toward my duties, and toward the world—you have the right to think that I lied also when I told you that I love you! Half an hour ago you looked me in the face, astonished, two or three times, and you blushed for me—I saw you.—You are not to blame. I am a wife, I am a mother, I have social duties, and I am your mistress: it is impossible to reconcile all that is contradictory in my condition, without lying. I have humbled myself in your eyes, making the sacrifice of my pride and of my delicacy before you—for you.—I do not reproach you. Is it your fault if everything is on your side? frankness, loyalty, delicacy, honor, and, as the safeguard of all this, your sword? You have everything that I have trampled under my feet... for you.”

At these last words the sarcasm broke out in her vibrant, hissing accent, in her bitter smile and in the hot tears which she dried spitefully before they had yet sprung in her eyes. Each of those words, each of those accents, struck Alberti in the face as he stood silent, motionless, flushing and turning pale by turns, as though he felt himself slapped by his own conscience.

“Why have you loved me?” he asked at last in a voice trembling and stifled.

The Armandi raised upon him her eyes burning with tears and with anger, as one dazed, and did not answer.

“Why do you not drive me away?” Alberti repeated.

An indefinable expression, an I know not what of astonished, of anxious, of angry, of vengeful, of enamored and of fearful, flashed in the Contessa’s glance. She remained some time without saying anything; then she threw her head back upon the chair-back, with a feline movement, and with her hands interlaced behind her neck, with the wide sleeves falling along her white arms, she answered languidly, looking at the ceiling.

“You are right. The best thing will be not to see each other any more.”

Alberto remained motionless, looking at her. All at once he flung himself upon her like a lion in love, seized her by the waist, without saying a word, and lifted her in his arms. She planted her eyes, sparkling like murderous weapons, in that pale and distorted face, holding herself away from him with all the strength of her stiffened arms, and suddenly she flung herself at his neck, and kissed him furiously.

CHAPTER XXXIII

At Bellagio the Marchese Alberti had the reputation of being somewhat eccentric, and indeed he led such a life as to justify that reputation. He would not show himself to anyone for whole weeks together, and then all at once he would run to every gathering, take part in every amusement; thirsting for pleasures, he often mounted on horseback, took Numidian gallops, or slept for twenty-four hours, or one met him ranging the most deserted little paths at hours fit for poets, or he passed the nights at infernal play, losing large sums, which he did not pay within the twenty-four hours, but which he always paid. The ladies closed one eye upon his eccentricities because he had both of them very handsome, he was young and rich, and sometimes even graceful and amiable. That bit of rough bark which still clung to him, and of which they vied with one another in trying to rid him, gave him also a certain rustic attractiveness—they said. He had the best horses, the most devoted friends, and once he begged two of these to go and challenge a certain person, who had told him that he had also the most beautiful mistress. The two friends began by laughing, but to pacify him they had to end by telling him that it was really not a case for taking amiss a compliment with which many others would have been highly flattered. Alberto had taken it into his head that that compliment was injurious to the lady's reputation. The more intimate of the two, he who dined most often with him and who owed him most, drew him somewhat aside and said to him:

“My dear fellow, are you quite sure you were that lady’s first lover?... Well... There is nothing to blush at... Let us leave it rather. A duel would compromise her infinitely more. Let us go to supper and sleep on it.”

The Contessa received Alberti frequently by day, even when she was not at home to all the others, and in the evening, when she made music: the Marchese was a distinguished pianist, and the Armandi loved music passionately—everyone knew it. Alberti saw her at every gathering, in every country party, in every crossing of the lake, he often accompanied her on horseback or in a carriage, alone or in numerous company, he stood with ease in her drawing-room, accompanied her at the piano, and played the gallant with her women friends; he knew how to conduct himself with tact, respected the demands of society, and bent his head with grace to the little hypocrisies. She, on the contrary, stood among those reefs with her head high, with aristocratic ease, dominating all that she could not raise up to her; she refined Alberto, she perfected him, she would stand talking with him beside the piano, near the work-table, or have herself accompanied into the garden, giving him her parasol to carry for her, and she would let him kiss her glove—so that every time she allowed him to snatch that glove from her, or preceded him under the thick trees of the little wood, smiling, hesitating, looking about her as she gathered up the folds of her dress, and walking on tiptoe, it seemed to him that the sky flung open both its doors. Never again had she been willing to go even once upon the lake with him.

The return of Conte Armandi was approaching; Alberti knew it vaguely, but he had never dared to ask the Contessa of it, and she had never spoken to him of it. One Friday, when he had gone to her to arrange an excursion upon the lake, and they had told him that she would be back in a few moments, he had sat down at the piano to beguile the time, and was running through some music which the evening before he had sent her himself. Indeed he heard the drawing-

room door open, and he rose, believing it was she. Instead it was the child, who arrived running before her mother, and seeing Alberto had stopped upon the threshold.

“Do I frighten you, Mademoiselle?” said Alberto.

At that moment the Contessa entered as well; she held out her hand to him, throwing the parasol upon the table, and taking from her daughter the wide straw hat.

“How red you are!” she said, kissing her. “Go to Tilde.”

The little girl returned her kiss, and before going offered Alberto also her flushed cheek. He caressed her upon the hair.

The mother drew the child abruptly to her, kissed her again, with a singular vivacity, and accompanied her as far as the door.

“Why did you not kiss my little girl?” she asked him, coming back.

Alberti delayed an instant in answering; but she, without giving him time, went to the piano, and took up the music-book that was upon the desk.

“I thank you for the music,” she added without turning round, leafing through it. “I glanced at it only yesterday. It is really beautiful.”

And she came back slowly toward the sofa, without lifting her eyes from the paper, sat down, and spread the book upon her knees.

“Have you taken a long walk?” asked Alberti.

“Have I made you wait? Forgive me. I had gone to meet Armandi. Instead I receive a letter that puts off his coming until tomorrow.”

“Ah!”

“Will you be of our party at dinner tomorrow?”

“Thank you.”

“You refuse?” she said, flushing a little.

“Yes.”

“Let us speak of it no more.”

She rang the bell and had her little embroidery-basket brought to her.

“Will the Conte stay long?” asked Alberto, toying with the ball of yarn.

“About a month, until we go to Belmonte; then he will be in Turin for the reopening of the Chamber.”

Alberto bent his brow upon his palm, and after a brief pause said softly:

“So then... we shall not see each other until June?”

“How do you expect me to see you again without presenting you to my husband?”

“It is true.”

The silence that followed had something embarrassing about it. The Contessa, wholly intent upon her embroidery, resumed at last:

“I know that last evening you made a heavy loss at play. I have the right to speak to you of it, because I am your best friend. It is unreasonable, my dear.”

“I might also have won. I am unlucky, that is all,” Alberto answered dryly.

“Well then, have sense also for the luck that you lack: do not play.”

“Do you wish it?”

“I beg you.”

“I will not play.”

She bent her head.

“What beautiful work!” said Alberto a little later.

“Do you like it?”

“Very much. Is it intended for a man?”

“Yes.”

“And... without being indiscreet?...”

“No indiscretion, my dear,” the Armandi answered, smiling; “on the contrary, what is most legitimate: it is for my husband.”

“Oh!... a regular wedding-present!” he said through clenched teeth.

The Contessa smiled without lifting her eyes from the embroidery, and flushed slightly. He took out his watch and rose.

“Farewell,” the Contessa Armandi said to him, holding out one hand, while with the other she counted the stitches of the pattern.

Alberto snatched the embroidery from her, and tore it.

“Marchese Alberti!” the Armandi exclaimed, drawing herself up, proud, angry, and imposing.

The Marchese took two or three staggering steps toward the door, stopped upon the threshold, and exclaimed, wringing his hands:

“Ah! how vile I am!”

“You are a madman!”

She turned her back upon him, going toward the window; and then, turning quickly toward him:

“Are you jealous of my husband?”

Alberto turned pale.

“So much the better!” the Contessa exclaimed with an irritated smile.

“Why?... why will you have it at all costs that I should shake that man’s hand?” said Alberti in a threatening accent.

She fixed him an instant with eyes of challenge and of anger:

“Because I have given you my honor, and I want you to give me yours!”

CHAPTER XXXIV

Alberto left that same evening for Milan, and went to drop like a bombshell at Selene's house.

"She is not at home," they told him.

It was one o'clock after midnight; he went to the Club, and passed the rest of the night there.

The next day he had not long been up, when Selene entered like one possessed, slamming the doors, and humming.

"Why, was it you, my fair-haired boy? Did you come looking for me last night? have you come back? forgive me if you did not find me at home; I had gone to the Carcano."

"At one o'clock?"

"Yes, afterwards we had gone to supper with Irma, you know, dark Irma, do you know her? she was treating us to a chic supper because it was her name-day. How are you?"

"I am very well, thank you."

"Have you come from the lake? What have you brought me from the lake?"

"I have brought you a bracelet."

"A beautiful one? Let me see it. Where is it?"

"At Bigatti's. If you are in a hurry you may go and fetch it."

He wrote upon a visiting-card two lines for the jeweler, who knew her very well, and gave it to her. She wanted to throw her arms about his neck.

“I have given it to you; I have not sold it to you,” he said, putting her aside. “Let me be.”

Poor Selene went away quite crestfallen. Alberti ordered the servant always to say that he was not at home whenever she came to look for him.

He went to the Corso, to the fencing-room, to the Club; he played, saw his friends again, and took part in their suppers and in all their pastimes. Giunti, the emeritus Nestor of the set, had taken him under his protection. “He is of good stock and good mettle,” he would say. The Nestor was forty-seven years old, had two great ladies who disputed him between them, and a mistress for whom he threw money about with both hands. Alberto’s friends were all fine young fellows,—open purse, heart proof against the sword, and a somewhat loose tongue. In their gaiety, in their conversation, in their revels, there was a perfume of mirth, of wit, and of youthful cordiality that intoxicated the most sober.

One of the finest evenings of July Alberti had come out of the Club, together with two friends with whom he had dined; his pupil was somewhat dilated, it is true, but his legs were steadier and his tongue freer than the others’. They went upon the ramparts in a carriage, chatting, smoking, and laughing aloud; the air was cooled by a light breeze that came from the Alps; from the little wood there exhaled from time to time vigorous scents; one met only some couple walking slowly, talking in an undertone, and vanishing under the trees of the avenue, or some brougham going at a little trot, the horse sniffing the dust and the coachman counting the rising stars. Alberti little by little had become silent, had thrown himself back in the carriage, and had let his cigar go out. All at once he had the carriage stopped, took leave of his friends, set off on foot along the Corso, stopped the first fiacre he met and had himself driven to Selene’s.

“Oh!” she exclaimed, seeing him appear before her, and remaining with one hand on the leaf of the door, with great astonished eyes. “I no longer expected you.”

He bent over the candle, and lighted another cigar.

“Did they tell you I came looking for you?”

“Yes.”

Selene went in a hurry to fetch the card that Alberti had given her for Bigatti, and tore it into a hundred pieces.

“Then here is your bracelet! I do not want it.”

“How beautiful you are when you are angry like this!” Alberti answered, after having fixed his eyes upon her for some seconds without batting an eyelid.

“Are you in love? what is the matter with you? are you in love?”

He did not answer.

“Are you angry with your fair one? speak!”

Alberto shrugged his shoulders and said coldly:

“Do you want me to go?”

“Yes, yes, go!”—and then, seizing him impetuously by one arm. “No! do not go!”

And she remained looking at him greedily, still holding him by the arm, and her eyes grew dim.

“How can she help loving you, that proud creature?”

She threw her arms about his neck. He who was about to leave quietly, when he felt himself clasped by those arms, forgot the Contessa.

He went out after half an hour, dark, wild-eyed, vexed,—the poor girl had not the courage to detain him. He had his horse saddled, and flew to the Villa Armandi.

It was past two when, having left the horse, he set out on foot toward the villa. All was dark; only at the window of the Contessa's chamber was there a light.

That light blinded him, fascinated him, pierced his heart like a point of red-hot iron. He would not have dared to repeat all the thoughts that stormed in his mind: there was a kind of acrid jealousy, which had a singular modesty; he would have killed the Contessa with his own hands rather than reproach her with the tortures she was making him suffer at that moment—and he remained savoring them one by one, until that light went out. The next day he wrote to her:

“Will you have me to dinner today?”

He was answered with an invitation from the Conte and the Contessa Armandi.

CHAPTER XXXV

Conte Armandi was a political man, a gentleman to his fingertips, dignified, serious, cold, and a man of the world: he had the reputation of having sown his wild oats in his youth, which had left him an elegant pleasantness of manner and a slight tendency to epicureanism, which fitted him like a glove. He stayed in Turin during the parliamentary sessions, and the rest of the year he traveled, and went to the baths, where the little clique of his political friends would assemble.

When Alberti entered the drawing-room the Contessa was not there; but the husband received the young Marchese as an old acquaintance, and spoke to him of the late Marchese, who had been his friend, and of the Marchesa, who was called in Milan the beautiful Tuscan. The Contessa kept them waiting a little, so that it was almost the Conte who had to present Alberto to his wife.

“My dear Emilia, I am grateful to you for having made me renew an old family acquaintance.”

“At last!” she said to Alberto, holding out her hand to him.

When the three or four friends who were dining at the Armandis’ were assembled, the Contessa took the arm of the last arrival, Captain Marteni, and passed into the dining-room. Alberto sat beside Signora Rigalli, who this time had indeed come.

Captain Marteni, of the Piedmontese carabineers, was a very handsome man, with a broad scar that crossed half his forehead, and with two blue ribbons in the buttonhole of his civilian coat; he was a

personal friend of Conte Armandi, who had induced him to come and spend his month's leave upon the Lake of Como. The captain did gallant honor to the table, to his hosts, and to his lady, with a somewhat soldierly gallantry. The ladies were mad about that handsome soldier who had won at Custoza and at Goito his ribbons and his scar, and they talked of it so much that the captain, as a man of wit, had tried two or three times to change the subject, and at last had taken refuge with the Contessa, going to take coffee in the drawing-room.

All evening the Contessa had directed her glances and her speech to Alberti only a very few times. The guests had followed the first couple into the drawing-room and had stopped in various groups. Alberto had gone out upon the terrace: Conte Armandi was talking with two others by the fireplace; Signora Rigalli was besieging her carabineer upon the sofa; the Contessa was beside the table: after a few minutes of that disconnected chatter that sets conversation going, she cast a rapid glance about her, poured coffee into a cup, and went straight toward the terrace. Alberto was standing with his back against the balustrade, and seeing the Armandi appear in the luminous opening of the balcony, he started up; she seized his hand and said to him in an undertone, rapidly, with an untranslatable accent:

"Now there is nothing I would not do for you. What do you want me to do? speak!"

He seized her hand, fixing his eyes upon her. Thus they remained some instants silent and palpitating.

"You know that my husband would kill me?... Do you want me to have myself killed? Do you want me to ruin myself for you?" she said, trembling and agitated. "Do you want it?"

At that moment the Conte had finished talking with his interlocutor, and was approaching the terrace: he drew aside the curtain, stopped a little upon the threshold to accustom his eyes to the

darkness, and exchanged a few words with Alberti. The Contessa re-entered sipping her coffee tranquilly, with the most careless smile upon her whole person. Passing near Signora Rigalli and Marteni, she said, laughing:

“Frankly, my dear Virginia, would you wish to be a man, a captain, wounded, and decorated?”

“But.... if I were not what I am.... I should like to be so!”

“False ideas, my friend! one of the many social injustices! There is only a woman capable of doing what the captain would not dare to do, not even with the hope of a third medal, for....”

She sat down upon her favorite armchair, leaning her head against the back, and drinking her coffee with a kind of voluptuousness, of pride and of triumph.

“For what?” asked Marteni.

“For a mere nothing, for a caprice.... for a cup of coffee....” the Armandi answered with a burst of laughter. “Take mine, which is empty, Captain.”

The guests had gone away little by little. Alberti had remained talking with the Armandi near the door.

“Will you come tomorrow?” the Contessa asked him, seizing that very moment. “Come at four. I have some new music.”

CHAPTER XXXVI

Count Armandi had gone out toward three o'clock: he liked the music at the Regio, or at La Scala, with the accompaniment of ballet-dancers, and he had the good taste to remain in his wife's drawing-room only when she was not receiving: he had therefore mounted his horse, and had gone to dine at the villa of a friend.

He was going quietly at a walk, cigar in his mouth, bending over the stirrups to observe, like a good horseman, his horse's action, and taking pleasure in posing him as if they were in the riding-school. The day was fine, freshened by a pleasant little breeze that set fluttering the signal-flag placed at one side of the road that was under repair. The Count's horse took a whim at the sight of that petulant flag that fluttered before his eyes, jibbed, and went past snorting, looking at it askance, with smoking nostrils, and fighting the hand; Armandi tried to steady him: horse and rider grew stubborn, grew restive, giving the reins, rearing, spurring, and backing toward that part of the road which was all torn up and scattered with holes, as if the Count had of set purpose determined to break his neck; all at once the horse put a foot wrong, fell, tried generously to rise again with desperate efforts, and at last, overcome by pain, rolled over without uttering a neigh, like a brave fellow. Armandi had sprung nimbly to his feet out of the stirrups, and tried to revive with the bridle and with his voice the poor animal, which had anguish in its eyes, lifted its head and fell back. "Poor Falco!" the Count said to him. At last, seeing that there was really nothing to be done, he commended Falco

to the workmen who were laboring on the road, promising to send help at once, and instead of returning on foot by the way he had come, which would have been too long, he went down to the shore in search of a boat, and had himself taken by water to his villa.

The villa on the lake side had a gate that opened upon the microscopic landing-stage where the Count's two little boats were moored. A hundred paces farther on was the gardener's cottage, set against the enclosing wall, tapestried with jasmine, and whose red roof made a pretty sight against the dark green of the great trees of the little wood. The Count went and knocked upon the window-panes with the pommel of his riding-crop, had the gate opened, dismissed the gardener, and set off along the avenue that led to the terrace. He walked slowly, and from time to time stopped as if to listen, and raised his eyes toward the windows of the drawing-room.

The avenue, before issuing at the steps of the terrace, wound about a great basin shaded by magnificent aquatic plants, and forked to lead into a little path that conducted to the stables, passing before a rustic cottage that had been shut up for a long time.

The Count had taken the little path; he kept his eyes fixed upon the abandoned cottage or upon the stables, trying to see someone to send to the rescue of poor Falco.

He passed beside a pavilion of boxwood and myrtle, kept with the greatest care, open on four arches, ornamented with seats and statues, before which the little path turned abruptly to climb the slope toward the cottage.

Alberti had arrived at the appointed hour. The Contessa was expecting him: he approached her rapidly, kissed her hand, and said to her in a brief voice:

“Your husband?”

“Gone out.”

“Will he return soon?”

“He will dine out.”

“How beautiful you are!” he exclaimed.

She freed herself from the hands that were clasping her wrists and went to pull the bell-cord.

“Leave that door open,” she ordered the servant. “It is too hot.”

“Do you not love me?” Alberto said to her in a low voice, answering the timid glance, as of excuse, that she turned upon him as she sat down again beside him.

The Contessa bowed her forehead into her hand. After a moment she answered in a moved voice:

“If I love you!”

“You love me in a singular fashion, indeed!”

“Singular indeed! I am a madwoman! I do not know where my head is at certain moments.... Last night I did not close an eye, thinking of the folly I committed yesterday evening!...”

“Forgive me!... If you knew!... Forgive me....”

They spoke in a low voice, almost without looking at each other, mastering themselves that their faces might remain impassive, lest some indiscreet mirror should betray them to the curiosity of the servant who was in the other room. Those ardent passions, which hissed like the breath of steam imprisoned beneath that mask of indifference, had something irresistible. The Contessa rose, went to open the shutters, and began to look out.

“There is a fresh little air that restores one,” she said after a few moments. “In the garden it must be delightful. Shall we go?”

Alberto followed her.

She went a few steps ahead, with a listless gait, swinging her arm a little, and holding her parasol upon her shoulder. One could see her bust bend and arch with a graceful elasticity under the light tissue that swelled and rippled by turns. She stopped at the openings of the

avenues, set upon her eyes, to look far off, the hand that in the sun seemed of a transparent rose, then set off resolutely, with a vague heedlessness: the avenue climbed the slope, winding; the Contessa paused from time to time to recover her breath, and turned toward Alberto to say some word to him. At a certain point she held out her hand to him, without turning; he kissed it.

“What would you have me do to prove to you how much I love you?” she said to him resolutely.

“Give me the key of the gate that opens upon the lake.” She turned, looked at him very gravely, and shook her head two or three times.

“You see!” said Alberto bitterly.

The Contessa pressed his hand, leading him with a gentle violence; she turned the corner of the avenue that climbed to the abandoned cottage, and entered the pavilion.

She stood upright under the flowery arch, looking at the lake that glittered in the depth of the prospect, and with her hands resting on the stick of her parasol. The little breeze set her dress fluttering, and modeled it upon her.

“Would you live with me, down there, in Switzerland, in London or in Paris?”

He seized her hand with impetuosity.

“And would you do it?”

“If I could!...”

“What would it be then? a vulgar thing! The attraction is in the struggle, in the sacrifice, in the abyss...”

The Contessa planted in his face a deep and pensive look. Alberti avoided it, as if all the contradictions that there were in that woman’s state leaped to his eyes; he felt that his very silence reproached him with it, and he was obliged to have recourse to paradox to justify himself and her. She listened eagerly, more convinced than he,

fascinated by that false eloquence of passion; she smiled and said to him:

“That is the theory of the forbidden fruit...”

“How do you love me?” he asked after a voluptuous silence.

She was seated languidly, a little bent toward him, holding his hands, shaded by the thick twigs, and all perfume. He looked at her eagerly.

“Thus!” he said to her with a kiss.

“Hush!” exclaimed the Armandi, starting and turning pale. “Someone is coming!”

The sand of the little path that crossed the avenue by which they had come was heard to crunch.

“Your husband!” exclaimed Alberti in a muffled voice, and instinctively making a shield of his body for her.

The woman twined herself about her lover, and hid her face in his breast with a voluptuous terror. They remained a few moments motionless, hidden in the darkest corner, holding their breath, with the two hearts beating one upon the other. The footsteps were heard approaching slowly, passing beside the pavilion, and drawing away little by little. The Contessa raised her head timidly, and for the first time drew breath. The two lovers looked at each other, pale as wax; her eyes grew veiled, and she abandoned herself softly in Alberto’s arms.

“Emilia! for the love of God! take heart! he might return!”

She would not leave him, and gazed at him with eyes swimming in a delicious languor, as if the danger, the anxiety, the fear had given I know not what devouring and irritating attraction to desire, to guilt, to the beloved man. She remained in that sort of ecstasy with her head resting on his shoulder, with her mouth half open, pale, frightened, and smiling.

“Let us go! let us go, Emilia!”

Emilia rose, wavering, rubbed her eyes a little, stretched her arms languidly with a tigress's movement, looked at him with sleeping eyes, and said to him:

"Pass beneath my window... I will throw you the key... Tomorrow, at midnight... if you see a light in the drawing-room... it will be a sign of yes... Go! go!"

Count Armandi seemed somewhat troubled when he entered his wife's room. The Contessa cast him a sidelong glance.

"Do you know of poor Falco's accident?" he said. "He has broken a leg!"

On her husband's entrance the Contessa had drawn abruptly away from the window.

"But where? how?... And you?" she asked.

"On the high road, just as it might have been in this room. I could not say myself how it happened. Poor Falco! I have been to the stables to send every possible help, but unfortunately I fear it will be useless... I am perfectly well, as you see... But you, what is the matter? You are a little pale yourself!"

"This accident..."

"What would you have? Let us speak of it no more. What have you been doing that is pleasant?"

"But you see!" said his wife, showing him the embroidery she had in her hand.

"And the Marchese Alberti has not come?"

"Yes."

"Have you made music?"

"Very little; I did not feel well. I have a little headache..."

"Has the Marchese just gone?"

"Half an hour ago."

“Oh! but is that not he... down there?” said the Count from the window. “Where the devil does he come from, then, in this sun?”

The Contessa went to the window as well, smiling and curious, threw a glance outside, shrugged her shoulders, then sat down again. “To walk in this fine sun!... That young man is a little mad.”

“He will have paid some visit in the neighborhood,” said the Count instead.

CHAPTER XXXVII

Armandi was to leave for Lake Maggiore together with his friend Marteni for a hunting-party.

The hour of departure had been fixed for ten in the evening. The Count had so thoroughly assured him that he would be punctual, that he had told his friend to go frankly alone if he should be more than five minutes late, since that would be a sign that some unforeseen business or impediment had befallen him. He had taken coffee in his wife's drawing-room, and had been chatting quietly with her until the hour of departure, smoking his cigar, and reading some passages from the fashion papers that were on the table. His wife worked beside him, and bent her head close to his to look together at the engravings in the paper. From time to time she turned her eyes upon the clock, and said smiling to her husband that he would not be in time. At last the Count rose, ordered the carriage, and pressed his wife's hand.

"When will you return?" she asked.

"The day after tomorrow, or Thursday at latest."

"A good journey."

Armandi went to the window to see if the carriage were at the foot of the stairs; he looked at the starry sky, and said to his wife:

"The evening is magnificent; will you do me the pleasure of accompanying me as far as Marteni's?"

"Willingly, but I fear I shall make you late."

“We have time to spare,” he said; “your clock is galloping. You will put something over your shoulders, that is all.”

The Armandi showed a certain eagerness in complying with her husband’s courteous wish; he thanked her, offered her his arm, and got into the carriage with her.

“By Heaven!” he exclaimed at the moment of departure. “I have forgotten my pocket-book, no less! That is what comes of doing things in too great a hurry!” And he sprang to the ground at a bound, but was a good quarter of an hour in returning. The Contessa was more impatient than he.

“Go at a gallop!” she ordered the coachman.

The Count threw himself back in the carriage and began to smoke. His wife sustained the dialogue alone, with a certain restless and nervous vivacity, leaning out of the window from time to time; her husband confined himself to preventing the smoke of his cigar from annoying her, and to turning his head toward her now and then, to give her signs of assent.

“The Captain left twenty minutes ago,” came the servant to say.

“Just as well!” said Armandi gaily. “I lose a hunt, but I gain the pleasure of spending the evening with you.”

She thanked him with a pale smile, and they turned back. This time the Contessa too had thrown herself back in the carriage, wrapping herself in her shawl; she was silent and seemed somewhat preoccupied. Arrived at the villa, she sprang to the ground first with vivacity, and mounted nimbly the few steps; her husband, however, forestalled her in opening the door, and preceded her into her rooms.

“Why have you left that light burning?” said the Armandi abruptly to the maid.

“You had not ordered me to put it out...”

“You are a stupid creature! Go!”

“Come, come, do not be angry,” added her husband. “After all, what harm is there?”

His wife tore off her gloves, threw them on the sofa, and moved two or three objects with impatience.

“I disturb you, perhaps...”

“Do you think so... quite the contrary!” she answered, darting a glance at the clock.

“Indeed! it seems that your clock has more sense than mine!” said Armandi, setting his by that of the drawing-room; “I am a good half-hour slow.”

And sitting down beside his wife:

“Will you give me a little music?”

“I am not really in the vein, my dear... But if you absolutely wish it...” she added with a dejected smile.

“Absolutely?... Why no! I wish whatever gives you pleasure.”

She bowed her head slightly, and began to look here and there in an absent manner. The silence was beginning to become invincible.

“Shall I read you something?” asked Armandi.

“Do.”

And she began to listen, with her forehead on her palm, in the shadow of her fan, darting at him by stealth rapid and flashing glances. He did not perceive them; he read with his beautiful clear and limpid voice, and turned the pages quietly. All at once the Contessa rose as if she were suffocating.

“What is the matter?” asked her husband, lifting his eyes from the book.

“Nothing... go on,” she answered, sitting down again.

“It is useless, since it does not interest you.”

And he closed the volume.

The Contessa remained a few moments with her head in her hands. Armandi went on turning over the fashion plates. At last she rose suddenly, white as wax, and said to him, holding out her unsteady hand:

“I do not feel well. Good night....”

The Count rose as well, took her hand without saying a word, and held it between his own; she began to look him in the eyes with a certain uneasiness. The clock was striking the twelve strokes of midnight; the muscles of the woman’s face had a slight tremor, then relaxed, loosened, and, fascinated by the danger, losing her head, she turned toward the balcony that gave upon the terrace with an invincible movement, and tried to free herself from her husband, who still held her hands with a loving violence.

“Stop!” he said in a brief voice.

They remained looking at each other two or three seconds—the woman let herself fall slowly upon the sofa.

Armandi went to open the little valise that he had had set upon the table, and drew from it a pair of traveling-pistols. His wife, beside herself, rose to cry out, to do I know not what, and remained terrified, petrified, under his firm and threatening look.

“Silence!” he said to her in a muffled voice. “If you take a step, if you utter a cry, I will kill him like a dog!”

He went resolutely toward the balcony, opened it, and found himself face to face with Alberti.

These two men said not a word, made not a gesture. The Count, paler than Alberto, had the pistol in his fist and his finger on the trigger. At last he said brokenly:

“Marchese Alberti... I could kill you like a thief tonight, or run you through the heart with my sword tomorrow.... But I will not do it.... I cannot.... One day perhaps you will know why.... and you will know also that we are even!”

Before Alberto had been able to recover from his surprise, he had closed the balcony.

CHAPTER XXXVIII

Alberti passed a terrible night. He had seen, through the panes of that balcony, the woman whom he loved to madness, sunk upon the sofa, with her head in her hands—she had not taken a step toward him, she had not uttered a cry, he had not been able to stretch out his arms to succor her, or to snatch her from the jealousy of his rival; that alone designated their reciprocal situation with a terrible eloquence. His love exalted itself at her danger, at the thought of the tears he could not see. He formed the most insane projects; he went a hundred times to spy upon the windows of that house. The next day he learned that husband and wife had left at dawn, no one knew for where.

The young man burned to follow her, but where? He did all that it was possible to do to have news of her; then he hoped that she would write to him; then he sank down. Little by little he began to think of her with a melancholy sweetness, dreaming of the solitary castle where the jealous husband had probably shut her up, of the tears she must have shed, of the sad and dear memories that must have returned to her mind while she fixed her beautiful eyes upon the stars... And all this would perhaps have been possible; but Armandi knew the world and women too well to contribute, by solitude, to the exaltation of his wife's little passion. After a brief explanation, made with grace and after the manner of well-bred people, they had both ended by agreeing that the best thing to do was to go to Baden. The Contessa, after that terrible shock, had shown herself almost grateful to her husband for his conciliatory spirit, and for her part had loyally

lent herself to repair the harm done. Once the first dismay was past, her love, let us call it so, had looked at the matter from the worldly side, from the side of her husband's reasonings, and had come to its senses.

Meanwhile time flowed over the husband's rancor, over the wife's melancholy, and over Alberto's imagination, as if it had charged itself with being able to bring these three persons together again, without inconvenience, in the same drawing-room, sipping coffee, chatting quietly of fashions or of politics.

Alberti after some months had resumed his old habits. At the beginning of winter he learned from a friend returning from Baden that the Armandi had been the most beautiful, the most elegant, the gayest lady to be found at the baths. The bacchanal of the European summer babel brought crashing down in a burst of laughter the melancholy house of cards in which his mourning fancy had shut up the sighs of the beautiful woman, while he rocked in his armchair smoking his cigar. His fatal spirit of analysis had scope to make him long meditations, bitter, irritating, which wounded not only his youthful illusions, but his self-love as well.

With the winter the swallows of high society had returned, and Alberti learned that the Contessa had gone to Turin with her husband. At that news, at knowing her so near, he felt blaze up in the depths of his heart, we will not say love, but desire, curiosity, a certain spiteful obstinacy, and he went and saw her again. How she was changed! not in person, the Contessa was still young and beautiful; but her manner, so strange, so indifferent, began again to turn his head or to make him lose it. The Armandi, however, was not a woman to lose hers when she did not choose, or to let herself be dragged by the chignon from an embarrassing situation. At last she answered him, giving him an appointment in one of the most remote avenues near the Botanical Garden.

When the young man saw her descend from the hired cab, he felt his heart beat as of old, more strongly than of old perhaps. She came toward him a little hesitating, and held out her hand.

“Shall we get into the carriage?” he asked her.

“No.”

“Why do you not send your carriage away, in that case?”

“Leave it there.”

Alberto was silent, and foresaw all that she was to say to him with her quiet voice.

They took a few steps in silence. The Armandi had not noticed the arm that the Marchese offered her.

“Listen, Alberto,” she said to him at last, “we must part.”

He felt burst in his heart, mount to his head, drown his voice in his throat, all that he had suffered, feared, and hoped for her—he said not a word, he did not turn a look upon her.—She pressed his hand.

“It is necessary!” she added.

“Do you wish it?”

“It is necessary. My husband has forgiven me, but he knows everything... and he is here... What would you have me do?...”

There followed a brief pause.

“What are you thinking of?” she said.

“I am thinking that truly you must love me no longer, if the last time you see me you can have the courage to say goodbye to me in the presence of your cabman, to prevent me from at least letting you see my tears.”

“How unjust you are!”

“It is true, forgive me... I suffer so much!” he exclaimed sadly, and shaking her hands.

She did not answer, and turned back to return slowly toward the cab that was waiting for her.

“I ask of you a last sacrifice: leave Turin.”

“Is it not enough that I renounce seeing you?”

“And my husband?”

“Very well, I will go.”

The Contessa continued to walk on.

“Do you really wish me to say goodbye to you before the coachman?” murmured the young man with all the bitterness that gnawed his heart.

She stopped, turning only just toward him, pressed his hand, and without lifting her veil said to him:

“Goodbye!”

The young man’s lips trembled without being able to utter a single word. He saw her draw slowly away, and get into the carriage.

Then he wiped away in secret a tear—the last.

The next day he left indeed, out of a proud respect for his word, or out of a spiteful self-love. To see such ties broken with so much indifference had wounded him deeply, but he had loved that woman so much, and so differently from the others, that it seemed to him there must always subsist between them an indissoluble bond; his grief had a certain voluptuousness that he liked to savor in going to bury himself in the country; but his country place was too near Milan, and his friends were not long in going there for a hunting-party—to divert him.—Thus he learned after some time what he ought not to have known: Captain Marteni, in the absence of Count Armandi, who was in Germany on a diplomatic mission, was compromising the Contessa a little, and the Contessa was letting herself be compromised. Alberto ran to Turin, and with the unjust and unhealthy curiosity of a rival succeeded in convincing himself indeed that the Captain was precisely what is called a successor according to all the rules.

Then he went to look for Captain Marteni.

He found him at breakfast. The Captain, on receiving his visiting-card, had remembered him, perhaps a little too well, and invited him to take a place at the table, as an old friend. Alberto refused coldly, saying that the object of his visit did not permit him to remain long. The Captain grew serious, emptied the glass he had offered, and raised his head as if to listen with greater attention.

“We shall not need many words to understand each other,” said Alberti. “You are a soldier and a gentleman, and you will find the thing perfectly natural. We are rivals; there is no need to name the woman we love or have loved. I have come to seek by common accord a pretext for fighting without compromising that person’s name.”

The Captain seemed to reflect a little.

“First of all,” he answered, “permit me a question: are you on the side of one who loves, or on the side of one who has loved?”

“That is of no consequence.”

“I beg your pardon, it is of a great deal of consequence.”

“Sir, it seems to me that we are wandering!” said Alberti with a shade of provocative irony.

The Captain preserved the most perfect calm.

“Excuse me, I ought to have begun with another question: do you believe you were the first lover of that lady?”

“Sir!...”

“My dear Marchese, I am a captain in the Carabinieri, and as such I am a little the soldier, and a little the lawyer; let us reason, then, since there is always time to pierce one’s skin. If you are convinced that you were not the first lover of that lady, as probably I shall not be the last, and if you are equally convinced that we succeed one another regularly, in that case which of us two would have the greater right to challenge the other? You, because I have come after you, or I because you have preceded me?”

“That is to invert the question in a singular fashion.”

“Simplify it, rectify it as you please; I am here to listen.”

“I have not come to tell you, nor have I any need to tell you, what my opinions are upon that lady; and it seems to me that so many words are not needed between two gentlemen to pierce one’s skin, as you say.”

“My dear Marchese, you have rectified nothing, and you cling to the provocation like a man who has no better reasons to put forward. But I am older than you, I am an officer, I have two medals, of the sort that give one the right to be always calm, and I may permit myself to believe that all possible explanations are truly needed between two men of heart, before putting hand to steel, especially when they are seated, as we are, before a good table. You come to challenge me out of self-love, out of spite, rather than out of jealousy; without thinking that you place your self-love between the fourth and the sixth of those who would have the same rights as you. For my part, when the hour of my successor comes, I shall shake his hand like a good comrade—upon my word of honor!—as I propose to you to shake this that I hold out to you. Now, if these reasons are not enough for you, and you are really looking for a pretext, tell me that this glass of wine I offer you is bad, I will throw the bottle at your head, and I put myself at your disposal.”

Alberti slowly raised the glass, and drank.

“Bravo, so!” exclaimed Marteni, pressing his hand warmly.

“One last word, sir... How long... have you been my successor?...”

“Why that question?”

“To make my reflections upon it,” answered Alberti with a bitter smile. “It is a question that does not in the least concern that lady, upon my word of honor!”

“... For nearly two months...”

“Thank you!” answered Alberto after a little hesitation.

CHAPTER XXXIX

Several years had gone by, and Alberti had begun again to lead the life of before, worse than before, abusing everything, exaggerating the evil that he himself sought, cursing the good that he could not attain through weakness of character, hardening himself in a skepticism for show because he knew no other women than those who fed his vanity, or his pleasures, vain and capricious like himself, and because he had no other friends than those with whom he had fought over a mistress or a game of cards. He had with him all the misfortunes: a warm imagination, a weak nature, a most sensitive heart, but not tempered by domestic affections, and a certain ease of fortune that did not permit him to see life from one side only: that life had been occupied only with idleness, or laborious with pleasures. At twenty-eight he found himself isolated, weary, without a purpose, without emotions that were not unhealthy, without enthusiasm, without a tomorrow. He experienced moments of weakness and of discouragement beyond words, but he was ashamed to confess them; in the uproar of a party or of a revel he thought with dejection that the next day he would amuse himself in the same fashion. Often, at night, returning weary of pleasures, he envied his coachman or his valet who stood waiting for him, yet without being able to form an idea of how one could live in their condition.

For the rest he led the life that all the others led, drank, gambled, fenced, and smoked more than the others: he was a little pale in the morning, and had a pulse a little agitated in the evening: nothing

more. From time to time the memories of his first youth, which seemed to him so distant, breathed upon his heart, like the breaths of the sea-breeze on a hot summer night; he savored them tacitly, with half-closed eye and cigar in his mouth, let his thought wander there and his heart rest, and when he started up of a sudden, a little ashamed even, the world that most surprised him, that seemed to him most false, was that in which he lived.

In one of these states of mind, Selene had found herself in his way, or in his arms; he had proposed to her that they should go and live together in the country, as if she could have given him back the virgin transport with which he had fallen in love even with a ballet-dancer; he proposed to her in earnest a cottage and his heart; the girl, who remembered of what fiber that heart was, answered, "Cuckoo!" he added that the cottage should be hung with silk, and carried her off from the impresario and from half a dozen lovers, still dressed as a bayadère. Their friends said that they were both drunk. Giunti sent a note of condolence.

"My dear fellow," Alberti said to him the first time he saw him again, "if that girl pleases me, why should I not love her? Do you think your Marchesa is worth more merely because she is rich? Selene possesses nothing but her little satin slippers, and she needs money as a pretty damsel needs a husband, or a pretty lady needs a lover—nothing more, nothing less—she is neither a young lady nor a Marchesa, she is nothing but beautiful, and it is therefore the most natural thing in the world that I should give it to her."

"All that is very well; it is not of that that I mean to speak. Give her what you like, ruin yourself if you will, no one will find fault; but leave her in her place, or rather put her there, buy her horses, jewels, but do not go and make yourself ridiculous with pastoral love! What the devil! you are a man of wit. What do you mean to do with Selene the whole blessed day, after you have told her in every tone that you love her?"

“The life I lead wearies me.... bores me to death.... I want a change.”

“Poor Selene!” muttered Giunti.

Poor Selene loved the handsome blond as she could, as much as she could, but she was accustomed to laugh and to frolic, and that lover who kept her at a distance, and who was seeking the x of love, made her horizon more dreary than the gray clouds of winter. The Marchese Alberti had lost his old Toni, and had for valet a young fellow. Some time later he perceived that he was also a handsome young fellow, discovering that he did him the honor of being his successful rival. When he had incontestable proofs of it, he called Selene and said to her:

“Tell me, do you like Cesare? Don’t stand there blushing, child! we are not on the stage.—He is a fine man, I have noticed it, and I don’t blame you, no, upon my word of honor.... if he were as blond as I.... just so much!... I might perhaps have the right to be jealous....—But what the devil! you ought to have warned me; I might have run the risk of kicking my rival. Will you marry him? tell me? Don’t play the fool. I am not angry, I tell you, but you understand that I cannot pay my rival’s keep, nor leave you in the street. I give you as a dowry what I had promised to give you in exchange for your faithful love, but I condemn you to marry him—and forgive me if you find me severe.”

After this tirade he left for a long journey, carrying with him his unhealthy habits, and the fatal germs of a skepticism which, among people who occupied themselves with him only to sell him pleasures, far from the places dear in memory, could do nothing but grow worse. He grew old before his time, running through the world like the Wandering Jew, driven by I know not what fatal restlessness that pursued him always everywhere, seeing and seeking nothing of the various customs of men but the worst side of them; he lived so many long, long years without any genuine feeling, without any of the more

intimate affections, that he grew accustomed to believe it a wretched privilege, that heart which he felt beating in his breast at distant reminiscences.

In this time Uncle Forlani had died, leaving Adele an orphan and alone. She, to comply with her father's insistent wish, who proposed that she should marry Gemmati, had said yes; but at the last moment, with the loyalty that formed the ground of her character, she had gone down one fine morning to find Gemmati, who was walking in the garden, and had said to him:

"My friend, I have loved my cousin Alberto, you know it; what would you think of me if I married you?"

Gemmati remained thoughtful.

"Do you love him still?" he asked her.

".... Yes."

"I loved you too, because you are an angel!" exclaimed Gemmati sadly; "and to renounce you is a hard thing!... But it is necessary, is it not?"

She bowed her head.

"How you deserve to be happy! If that wretched man had a less weak character!..."

So they had parted, pressing each other's hands like two honest and loyal hearts that understand each other in a single word. He had not told her how much the sacrifice he had to make cost him, and he had accepted a post as physician on board a ship that made long voyages of circumnavigation.

Signor Forlani had left his daughter very rich, and her friends gave themselves no peace because she, so rich and beautiful, refused all the matches that were hunting her and her dowry. Adele wore the mourning of her heart nobly and proudly, without a weakness and without a lament; of her cousin, who did not in the least concern himself with her, she had learned the whole story of his life, but she

had not said a word, and had remained pale and silent; she had often inquired of him from the more discreet of her friends, with a modest and delicate reserve, and when she had had no more news of him she had shut herself up with dignity in her sadness, without letting anything of it transpire outside.

Her beauty meanwhile had developed; it was a kind of beauty fantastic, delicate, flexible, elegant, somewhat pale and diaphanous, with magnificent black hair, white hands on which the glove fitted with certain folds and a certain aristocratic grace, and large blue eyes, a little sunken, ringed with a pearl-colored furrow, sparkling with such a light as might have been called fatal, had she ever been destined to meet Alberto. She carried her graceful head high in the Florentine drawing-rooms, and with an absent smile and a deep look that had earned her the nickname of Elizabeth of England.

CHAPTER XL

After twenty years in which they had not seen each other, Alberto and his cousin met in Florence, driven by the whirlwind of fatality.

It was the first day of the races. The Cascine swarmed with spectators; the sky was blue, the sun cut itself among the branches; veils, scarves, plumes, fluttered; the meadow stretched like an immense billiard-table, streaked with the vivid colors of the jockeys who were caracoling; the horses neighed, gay accents were heard in all the dialects of Italy, flowers were to be seen everywhere, in the hair, on the dresses, in the carriages, on the horses' headstalls—there was a perfume of youth, of festival, and of spring that intoxicated.

Adele was on horseback beside the calèche of a friend of hers from Viareggio, the Rigalli, and answered the greetings of her numerous acquaintances by bowing her head gracefully, while as she talked she passed her glove over her mare's mane; as she was, in her gray riding-habit, and in her graceful attitude, she was very charming; the calèche was padded, overflowing with flowers, with the jockeys embroidered and powdered, motionless as statues, the horses restless, with eye and hock taut. A crowd of curious people had formed near that handsome group.

"Oh, whom do I see!" exclaimed Signora Rigalli all at once, "is that not the Marchese Alberti down there, arriving from India on his bay?"

Adele turned with a start, and became white as her little batiste collar.

Alberti was advancing at a walk; the horse was impatient, with red nostrils, snorting, biting the foam-white bit, and shaking it with abrupt movements; the rider was calm, serious, cold, and had a hand of iron; he turned his eyes upon the crowd absently, cigar in his mouth, and he had the dull eye, the cadaverous pallor, and an almost gloomy impassibility. He looked at that festival as a dead man might have looked at it from the tomb. Passing near the calèche he turned his eyes upon it by chance, the Rigalli called him with her most graceful smile, and he found himself face to face with Adele; a flame rapid as lightning passed for the first time in so many years over those pale cheeks. Meanwhile the Rigalli was saying to Adele:

“Will you permit me to present the Marchese Alberti to you?”

“You wish to present my cousin to me?” answered Adele, who had become calm and smiling again with a supreme effort of will, and held out to Alberto the pommel of her riding-crop across the calèche, as if she were holding out her hand.

“He is a cousin from America, then!”

“Those are the welcome ones. Where do you drop from, cousin?”

“From Calcutta.”

“It is more than ten years since he has been seen!”

“What have you done all this time?”

“I have spent it on the railway and on steamers, my cousin.”

“Have you amused yourself?”

“Why... a good deal.”

The calèche moved off at a little trot; Signora Rigalli made the Marchese promise a visit, and the two cousins found themselves side by side, in the middle of the great avenue.

“Will you permit me to accompany you, cousin?” said Alberto.

“Willingly.”

He turned his reins, and set off at a walk, beside her, followed by Adele's groom at some twenty paces.

"How do you find Florence?" she asked.

"More beautiful than ever."

"Shall you stay long?"

"I do not know myself."

"Tell me something of your travels."

"What would you have me tell you?"

"Why... what you have seen."

"I have seen, more or less, Via Calzaiuoli, Arnos, hills of San Miniato everywhere, large, small, and microscopic: and Florentines yellow, red, and black, who say 'by Heaven' a little differently from us."

"And the women?" asked Adele, laughing.

"And the women... such as men have made them."

"I do not know whether I ought to thank you for the compliment, cousin."

"Thank me for it, cousin, for I deserve it." Adele greeted a pretty young girl who was passing in a phaeton beside an elegant gentleman. "Do you know that lady?" she asked him.

"No."

"It is Cecilia, Count Armandi's daughter, now married to Livor-etti."

Over Alberto's face there passed a most rapid cloud.

"I am a man of the other world, my cousin; have the goodness to put me au courant: and the Contessa, what has become of her?"

"She has been on the Lake of Como for two years, mourning her husband's death."

"Oh!... And the Principessa Metelliani?"

"She is in Rome, president of I know not what Congregation of Charity... Does it surprise you?"

"No."

They went a hundred paces without saying anything more.

"Do you know that we meet again in a singular fashion?" said Alberti all at once.

"Singular or not, I am glad to see you."

He fixed upon her a long look, and then:

"You have a great deal of wit!"

She bowed her head slightly.

"My cousin," asked Alberti suddenly, "what would you say if I paid court to you?"

"I should say it was the most natural thing in the world."

"After what has been between us?"

"Precisely because of that."

Her mare gave a bound, and arched herself all quivering under the firm hand of the horsewoman.

"You are strong!" Alberto said to her.

"Cora is gentle," she answered, stroking her on the neck.

They were silent. They went at a little trot along one of the avenues beyond the great square; the sun, which was setting like a great fiery disk, flooded it for all its length with golden motes; a few clouds a little high on the horizon designed themselves like broad splashes of purple and gold.

"What a beautiful sunset!" said Adele, to break that silence.

Alberto raised his head, and added absently:

"It is like being at Belmonte."

"You have a good memory, cousin!" said Adele with a singular smile. Alberti wished to answer that smile.

"It is the memory of the heart, my cousin."

"Would you already begin to pay court to me?"

"Did you not say it would be the most natural thing?"

"My cousin, what would you think of me if I allowed you to do so?" asked Adele in her turn, very gravely.

"You are right," answered Alberto briefly.

Darkness was beginning to rise. She looked sidelong at that singular man.

"Have you been happy sometimes?" asked Alberti as if answering a long meditation.

"... Yes," said Adele after a slight hesitation. "As much as one can be.... And you?"

"I have amused myself," he answered with a glacial accent. They talked by starts, with long interruptions, as if answering the thoughts that were unfolding themselves through their singular situation. The Marchese from time to time cast a long look upon his cousin, who rode calm and proud.

"You are not vindictive, cousin?" he asked at last.

"No."

"What a pity!"

"And you, cousin?"

"I do not believe I have the right to avenge myself, since no one is in the wrong in this world!"

"A convenient theory!"

He rose in his stirrups with a cold and haughty seriousness:

"My cousin, when you told me that you could not allow me to pay court to you, I granted you were right!"

There was such a quiet bitterness, such an accent of conviction in his skepticism, that Adele's bosom swelled violently from time to

time. He breathed strongly, at long intervals; they rode in silence and with bowed heads.

"I thank you for this hour that I had not felt for twenty years," said at last in a muffled voice that man who was no longer moved.

She raised her head, dismayed, almost seeking whence came that voice which made her start.

"Let us turn back," she said briefly.

They passed the groom, who had stopped as well, and left him far behind. Neither of them dared for some time to break the silence that followed. The horses' tread was sonorous; the moon was beginning to rise, and to steal among the trees, gliding over the white avenue: little by little the horses had drawn together, and went sniffing each other. Alberto took his cousin's hand, which hung along her dress.

"Leave me..." she said softly.

"Avenge yourself!" answered Alberto in a muffled voice. "It is your hour!"

"Leave me," repeated Adele with so much the more vivacity as she felt herself growing weaker. "Between us there is an abyss."

"Your husband?"

"Who?" she said in a voice that made him start.

"Gemmati!..."

She pulled the reins abruptly, and rose in the saddle, pale, motionless, with sparkling eyes.

"I still call myself Adele Forlani!" she exclaimed in an extinguished voice, but with her forehead high.

The Marchese was struck dumb.

"You thought me married?" she resumed after a few moments. "And you spoke in that manner to the wife of your best friend!..."

He did not answer.

"What you have become, Alberto!" she exclaimed, hiding her face in her hands.

".... Do I horrify you?"

"No... you make me pity."

They went skirting the trees so as not to be near each other.

"How much you must have suffered to be so changed!" she said at last.

"Do you believe it?" murmured Alberti with a strange smile.

"Yes! All the sacred beliefs that were in your heart are not uprooted without pain. When you abandoned me for Velleda, when you became infatuated with the Armandi, when you made others weep and you wept, there was still something in you. Now you have nothing left. Your dry eyes frighten me!"

"And you?" he said in a voice that seemed to come from underground: "do you still believe in something?"

"I believe in what makes my heart beat."

He smiled. "Blindly?"

"I cannot doubt what I feel."

"I deceived you at sixteen!"

"I was near dying of it. How would you have me able to doubt the feeling that was killing me?"

Alberti did not answer immediately. Then he planted his eyes in her face and asked:

"You are beautiful, young, and rich; how is it that you have not married?"

"I have always refused."

"For whom?"

"For you."

"Did you love me?"

“Yes.”

“Even after my betrayal?”

“Yes.”

He remained thoughtful.

“My cousin,” he said all at once, with a wholly different accent and with a satanic ease; “I have no more hair; nor illusions; I am forty years old and have thirty-two thousand francs of debts.”

At first Adele remained as if thunderstruck, with staring eyes, as if to seize the sense of those words which she could not understand. All at once she grew red as if Alberto had struck her in the face with his riding-crop.

“Ah!” she cried. “Ah!”

And she fled at a gallop.

CHAPTER XLI

After a few days Alberti presented himself in his cousin's anteroom, and had the following note taken in to her:

"I have need to see you and to speak with you. I know that I have done you a mortal affront, and I have come to your door in order that you may have me turned away if you wish."

The servant returned, saying, "Let him come in."

He entered, a little disturbed, but with a firm step.

Adele was by the fireplace, though the spring was well advanced, her feet resting upon a little stool; she was somewhat pale herself, and when she saw her cousin she grew paler still. Alberto pressed her hand and sat down facing her.

"Adele," he said to her calmly, "I am forty years old, and I have thirty-two thousand francs of debts. Will you be my wife?"

"No."

A dark smile passed over his face.

"But if I had a daughter of sixteen, beautiful, ingenuous, pure, with all the treasures of the heart and of the mind, I would give her to you for a wife."

At first he cast her a glance of surprise; but then, in another tone:

"Unfortunately you have none!"

"Put away that wicked smile, which hurts you and me!... Why have you come, then, Alberto?"

He hesitated a little. "I do not know," he said at last. "It is the first time that I am not sufficient unto myself."

Those words seemed to strike the woman; she cast him a very rapid glance, and blushed. Then she repeated gently:

"If I had a daughter I would give her to you; she would put into your heart her faith, her affection, her holy enthusiasms; she would restore your spirit, she would make you be born again."

"You would not hesitate to give your daughter to me?"

"No."

"Now that I am so changed?" he added, with an ironical smile.

"Precisely because you are so!"

He fixed his eyes upon hers.

"Why do you not do so yourself?"

"I am no longer sixteen, I have no longer faith, and between us there is a sad past."

"So be it!" said he.

And he set about stirring the fire. They remained silent a long while. Adele stretched toward the flame her pale and delicate hands, and from time to time Alberto fixed upon them an absent glance.

"Cousin," he said after a few minutes, "if I were young and handsome, and had even the wrongs that I have toward you, would you love me?"

"Why do you ask me this, sir?" answered Adele, drawing herself up in her armchair.

"To know at last wherein this love consists," murmured Alberti in a low voice.

Adele fell back against the chair's back, and remained some time without adding a word. "How you must have suffered!" she exclaimed then.

"I have enjoyed life," he answered.

The woman turned upon him a glance between astonishment and sorrow. Her cousin held his forehead between his hands, spoke with a bitter and tranquil conviction, but avoided meeting her eyes.

“I have read clearly in human nature as in a mirror: the greater part of our sorrows we fabricate for ourselves: we poison the feast of our youth by exaggerating and complicating the pleasures of love until they result in pains, and we trouble the serenity of our old age with the phantoms of another life that no one knows. Behold the result of our civilization. I have seen savages scalp one another for a woman, for the belly, but among them there are neither suicides nor spleen. The whole science of life consists in simplifying the human passions, and in reducing them to their natural proportions. I have regulated my conduct upon this truth.... That is how I have suffered no more.”

“Oh!” she said, with immense dismay. “Oh!”

“Have you been happier than I, cousin?” asked Alberto, with an ironical smile.

Adele, pale, as if in a dream, turned upon him a frightened look. “No!” she said with force, and with her cheeks faintly coloring. “No! you do not believe what you say!”

“It is true!” answered Alberto in a muffled voice, bowing his head —“and for the first time!... You have made me doubt even of that, you! You have done me a great harm!”

“Marry!” Adele said to him, daring at last to press his cold hand. “A family would save you.... I know what it means to be alone in the world! If I could, by the sacrifice of my life, put something into your heart, I swear to you that I would do it.”

He looked at her in a singular way, a long while, without opening his mouth. “My cousin!” he said after a long hesitation, “I have scarcely known my father; my mother had not even time to embrace me before dying; once I was surprised by a husband who would have had the right and the duty to kill me like a dog.... Do you know what

that man said to me? ‘that he spared me because I was the son of the Marchesa Alberti!...’”

Adele hid her face in her hands.

“Farewell!” he said at last.

“You are going?”

“Yes.”

“What will you do?”

“What I have done.”

“Have you no purpose?”

“Does it not seem to you a purpose, to live well?”

“Are you not even ambitious?”

“What could repay me for the trouble I should take to be so?”

“What have you then before you, in your future?”

“Nothing.”

At that word she started, and rose resolutely.

“Alberto, you have said that I am beautiful, young, and rich.... Well, if I accepted your offer.... would you believe that I love you truly?”

He remained silent and astounded.

“If you believe it....” Adele took up again, stretching out her hand to him. “Press it.... I am yours.”

CHAPTER XLII

The marriage was celebrated in October. Alberti lent himself with perfect complacency to those observances which custom and propriety required. On this occasion many of his acquaintances who had long known nothing of him saw him again. He bent his head, with a tinge of gallantry, to everything that Adele found necessary, or merely becoming—even had they been prejudices;—the candor of her convictions rendered them respectable to him, whether he believed in them or not. Adele, on the contrary, put into it the blithe enthusiasm of happiness, such a radiance of her virgin and sincere affection; she loved her cousin frankly, without reticences, without doubts, with an open heart, abandoning to him with thoughtless generosity all the treasures that for his sake she had accumulated in secret in her soul. Alberti did everything that others do, with the same simplicity, without hesitating: he went to church, grave and respectful, at least to all appearance, and when Adele placed her hand in his, and he heard that she was uniting herself to him forever in a thread of a voice, and saw her sweetly moved, even that man was somewhat disturbed, and with a slight tremor pressed in his that hand which trembled.

After the religious ceremony they set out for Belmonte.

The Marchese had taken a reserved coupé as far as Pistoia, and when they were in the carriage, and Adele had seated herself, he closed the windows on the side where she was, drew the curtains, put the plaid under her feet, bestowed upon her with paternal delicacy all

those little attentions, then sat down facing her, took her hands, and said to her gently, smiling with a certain solemnity:

“I salute you, Marchesa Alberti.”

She too was moved, and a little disturbed; she looked out of the window, bashful in her embarrassment, and let her hands be pressed with an affectionate abandonment. She had a pretty gray dress, trimmed with blue, long Swedish gloves, and her delicate face seemed paler through the sky-blue veil. It seemed that Alberto could not weary of contemplating that graceful woman who now belonged to him—she, without seeing him, felt that glance, and was wholly penetrated by it. At a certain moment, still with her face to the window, she laid a hand upon his.

“Do I frighten you?” Alberto asked her gently.

She gathered up her skirts, went to sit beside him, and without answering him directly they set about talking of a thousand common subjects, without importance, which for them had hidden meanings, and enclosed I know not what mysterious attractions. He spoke little, and listened to her intently, with a certain avidity, as if he were analyzing minutely, with affection, the windings of those braids, the stirring of that veil, the flounces of that dress, the laces of those cuffs, the sudden and unreasonable blushes that rose to her face, and that he felt flowing sweetly through his veins. All at once:

“I should like to return to my twentieth year!” said that strange man, with his gaze fixed upon emptiness.

The locomotive was stopping, panting.

“Already!” she exclaimed.

“No, we are at Prato.”

“Oh!... let me see!”

And they placed themselves one beside the other at the window to look at the country—he with a feeling he had not known for a long time. All that was to be seen was green and blue; Adele, with her

hands resting on the strap, said to him under her breath some insignificant word, as if she were speaking to him of a great secret; the ribbon of her bonnet fluttered from time to time against Alberto's face; it seemed that his lungs dilated eagerly, so as to drink in all those virgin sensations that were almost unknown to him. "I don't frighten you.... truly?" he asked almost timidly and in a muffled voice. Adele sought his hand in secret, and pressed it a long while, while the conductor verified the tickets: even that sort of theft which there was in so much candor made a powerful impression upon Alberto. He took her hands, very gravely, and looking into her eyes:

"Adele mine, that priest has bewitched me."

Adele had grown grave as well.

"Bewitched or not, I am content, and I should not know how to explain to you the feeling that binds me to you. Mine is not love alone; it seems to me that you form a part of me, of my house, of my name. You are the continuation of my mother, and it is sweet to me to call you by her name. I have loved in every fashion, but I have never felt anything of what I feel now. It seems that we belong to each other by something that is in us and outside of us—the world, the law, men, God, what do I know?... If ever I should come to doubt what I feel now, I should wish to die."

Little by little he had sunk at her feet, and he spoke with such an accent of calm and firm conviction that the tears started in Adele's eyes. She bent gently toward him, put her arms about his neck, and softly reclined her head upon Alberto's head.

CHAPTER XLIII

The two spouses went to hide their happiness at Belmonte—his, however, was a little closed, hesitating, shadowy, and had always a tinge of melancholy; Adele's was frank and expansive.

Alberto had not seen those places again for more than twenty years, and each recollection, each new impression that passed over that raw soul, in spite of the great empire he had over himself, made him start; Adele perceived it, and felt herself more closely, more intimately bound to him precisely by all that good which she did him. They were always together, in the carriage, on horseback, or walking in the neighborhood. Alberti, that man tormented by the fever of movement, pursued by ennui everywhere, had passed long delicious hours, watching beside her the rain that dripped upon the panes, or the flame that crackled in the fireplace: every little thing had a new, serene, festive physiognomy; the most common occupations had a delicate attraction. He had gone with her to seek out, step by step, the places that enclosed the memories of their first youth: that bench where they had felt their first embarrassment sitting side by side, that railing against which they had leaned when they had quarreled and had made peace for the first time, that tree from which he had gathered the first flowers for her—and they said: “Do you remember?” At times these *do you remembers* enclosed a sweet reproach for certain past unkindnesses, and they were the most savory, the sweetest; they sought them out on purpose, as if to make the festive ray that shone upon them stand out by means of the shadows

—they laughed and embraced. If something had changed its aspect, if the tree had fallen, if the bench was rickety, if the gardener had arranged the flower-bed otherwise, they were true losses, and they said: “It was prettier then, was it not?”

With a noble frankness, and as if the fault were not worth the repentance, Alberto had shown Adele that avenue where he had spoken for the last time with Velleda; and he had put her hand in his and his eyes in hers. Adele had bent her head, trying to laugh at it, growing pale, blushing, and had not told him how many times she had stopped weeping in that same avenue.

“How far away all that is!” Alberto would say.

She, after long hesitations, had shown him all the relics of him that she had religiously preserved: the glove-button which she had put back for him the evening they had gone to villa Armandi, the withered flower he had let fall from his buttonhole, the scrap of bark he had cut from a tree with his penknife, the crumpled sheet on which they had amused themselves by sketching scribbles and caricatures, seated at the same table, under the same lamp, while the rain beat gaily upon the panes. He, who had thrown from the window to the wind of a hundred cities, or upon the ashes of a hundred hearths, the letters of eternal love of women who had staked their lives and his for a caprice, could not altogether comprehend the tenacity of that feeling which rendered precious those insignificant objects. Between those two who loved each other so much, who were so intimately bound, there was always an abyss which he did not dare confess to himself, and which she would not see, and in order not to see it she closed her eyes.

The optics of their ideas were immensely different: the woman’s heart, young, fresh, rich, was glad to love, clung to happiness, believed in it without hesitations, abandoned itself to it with trust. Alberto no longer possessed either that faith, or that enthusiasm, or that serenity; the life he had led had profoundly altered his way of

seeing and of judging; he had observed and studied the passions in himself and in others, but he had never combated them, and, unfortunately for him, he had not seen them combated: the sense of the just and of duty remained therefore an abstract formula, little less than an illusion.

In such dispositions of mind, and at his age, love was therefore a weakness; and love itself rendered his skepticism an infirmity rather than an armor.

He felt springing up again within him those sentiments upon which he had set his foot, but which had nonetheless disturbed the Epicurean serenity of his pleasures, now that he found them fresh and flourishing in the woman with whom he felt the need to identify himself; yet on seeing these sentiments so different in himself and in her in their development and their effects, on feeling them stir painfully in his soul rather than gather strength, he experienced from it a great discouragement, a bitterer doubt. Adele's faith—that which for him was blindness—revealed itself so firm and entire that he found himself compelled to admire it, almost to envy it, without being able to share it. Instinctively he felt himself inferior to her by all that sad science of the world or of evil which he had acquired.

Whether it were modesty, timidity, or pride, there was always in him something closed, even in the moments when he abandoned his head upon her knees like a child. Adele, on the contrary, possessed the ingenuous curiosity of one who has nothing to hide, and asked him questions to which he replied evasively, smiling at her as at a little girl, or darkening somewhat.

That somewhat cloudy serenity, that sort of mystery which was to be glimpsed at the bottom of his most expansive feelings, was another attraction for Adele's innocence—a dangerous attraction. She divined in the man she loved wounds that she was glad to heal, shrinking weaknesses that flattered the maternal and protective instincts of the woman; the haughty reserve with which her husband

concealed them from her eyes gave him a character of dignity and of strength, something superior after the manner of Lucifer. A hundred curious questions, which had come to her lips, had expired before the calm, veiled, and impenetrable smile of that man.

“What do you want to know of it, my child?” he would say to her.

And she, who made a pretension of being no longer a child, sulked at him exactly like a little girl.

Alberto too had his curiosities, unhealthy curiosities, avid, interested, vital, now that Adele was all his: he felt the need of learning how the passions developed in the midst of so much candor, what form they assumed, and how much importance they had.

“And you,” he had asked her, smiling with the edge of his lips, “have you loved no one else?”

She, who was still sulking at him, answered with the little spite of sixteen years:

“Yes, I have loved Gemmati.”

“Really?” asked Alberto, laughing.

They were leaning on that same balustrade on a sweet or mild day of November; the yellowed leaves chased one another along the avenues, the swollen torrent had grown grumbling, and the little clouds peeped over the peaks of the Apennines, just as then. She put her arm about his neck, and answered:

“No, I was only fond of him.”

“What does it mean, to be only fond?”

“It means to like talking with such a one of what most concerns us or grieves us, and to find a great relief in feeling our hand pressed when we have a heavy heart.”

“Do you know, my dear, that I call that love, pure and simple?”

“Truly?... then how is it that I was thinking at that moment of another... who was a great naughty fellow besides?”

He pressed her to his breast, very tightly. Adele had grown sweetly melancholy.

“How many times we have been here, as we are now... what ugly days!... What is the matter?”

“Nothing!”

“... If you knew what a noble heart! and how worthy he is of your friendship! When I told him that I still loved you... and that of marrying we must think no more, he did not hesitate, he made no observation, he said not a word; he bent his head, and when he left he had tears in his eyes without perceiving it... I too, who had suffered so much, and who felt how he must suffer, had moist eyes... But what is the matter with you, I say?... You are wrong, you see!”

“I know it. But never speak to me of it again, Adele!”

She bent her head, blushed, and then, smiling at him, between mischievous and blithe:

“Would you rather I did as you do?”

“As I do?”

“Why... I have nothing to hide from you... Whereas if you told me half of what you will not tell me!...”

“It is not the same thing, Adele mine,” said Alberto, very dryly.

CHAPTER XLIV

Alberti would gladly have remained at Belmonte all the winter, and even all the year. That calm and serene life, circumscribed within a limited horizon, suited the weariness of his spirit and the need he felt of being born again in that love so new, without other images of the past being able to come and trouble his thought, and to put in peril that intimacy which did him so much good. But Adele feared to weary her husband's shadowy and most mobile fancy by showing herself always within the same frame, and under the same aspect. In the purest love of woman, and perhaps in that of man as well, there is always a little coquetry; the wife wished to bind her husband to herself more closely, indissolubly, availing herself of all the advantages that the great world gives a beautiful woman, making herself seen by him more splendid, if not more beautiful; perhaps there smiled upon the woman the thought of laying at the feet of the man she loved her elegance as a great lady, and also, why not? her triumphs as a woman of the world. Alberti, fearing to show himself selfish, made no observation, and when the winter was already well advanced they returned to Florence.

The Marchesa Alberti was graceful; her happiness radiated like a seductive aureole upon her; she took with perfect ease the first place in the Florentine drawing-rooms. Alberti had been an elegant man; now he was a perfect husband: he accompanied his wife sometimes on her first visits, just enough not to attract notice, and for his own part he began again to lead more or less the life that all his friends

led; he showed himself a moment in the drawing-rooms his wife frequented, or went to find her in her box to present some friend to her. His wife was always besieged by a crowd of courtiers; he would have found it very strange had it been otherwise, so did everyone, so had he done himself, but meanwhile he suffered from it secretly, and had to make painful efforts to dissemble the steel claws that tore his heart and made anger flash in his face, or sarcasm upon his lips. Rather than betray himself he would have killed himself; but without being precisely jealous, without having lost a crumb of the unlimited trust he placed in his wife, he felt a great vexation at seeing her courted: he knew that to court means to lay siege: and yet it would have been almost an affront that his wife should not have been so, and he was obliged to press the hands of those good friends of his who did him the honor of laying siege to his treasure, and he suffered all the punishments of that worldly logic in the name of which he too had made others suffer; he suffered from it more than the others because he was prouder and more corrupt, more distrustful, more dissembling, and more in love.

Husband and wife were no longer always together as at Belmonte. They had now a hundred different occupations which parted them inexorably for several hours, and they underwent without perceiving it the tyranny of the society in which they lived. Adele, who still loved with an open heart, was most happy to lay at the feet of that sarcastic and haughty husband of hers the crowns that all her womanly vanities brought home, and seeing him smile she did not even suspect what that man suffered without a single muscle of his countenance contracting; she saw him always kind and loving, she saw him full of wit and good humor among his friends, she saw him elegant, courted and envied, she discerned not a cloud upon his brow, and she believed him happy.

They met often at the breakfast hour, and almost always at dinner. Before the servants they treated each other with a calm and affection-

ate familiarity; the conjugal etiquette cost them not the least sacrifice, because both were perfectly well-bred. At times they would sit talking over their coffee until the hour when the wife went to dress for the evening and the husband went to smoke his cigar at the Club; he accompanied her to the threshold of her rooms, and they parted with a pressure of the hand. Often in the evening it happened to Alberto to wait for Adele seated beside the fire with his forehead between his hands. The chimney-glass did not tell her what clouds had passed over that brow. Hearing the rustle of her dress, seeing her enter beautiful and radiant, he raised his head, smiling himself as well, rose and went to touch the hands or the lips that she held out to him. Then they sat beside the fire, telling each other the insignificant events of the day, and the piquant, ridiculous little stories of the evening. Sometimes the husband cast an absent or embarrassed glance upon her beautiful bare shoulders which blushed, and she lowered her eyes, and did not perceive that he too kept his fixed upon the carpet—and not serene like hers.

“How beautiful you are!” Alberto would say to her at last, with a certain resolution.

She smiled.

“How many will have told you so this evening!” She gave a pretty little shrug of the shoulders.

“I should like to be young and handsome like you!” Alberto would add, with a smile whose sadness he had difficulty in dissembling.

“Why?” Adele would ask, a little uneasy. He was slow to answer.

“Do you want us to go back to Belmonte?”

“Are you happy at least, Adele mine?”

“So much!” and she embraced him to tell him that she was so for him. “And you?”

“I... yes! yes!”

Sometimes Alberti was sadder than usual, though without cause. He darted at his wife, almost unawares, a scrutinizing glance, grew pale or flushed against his will if by chance Adele seemed more melancholy, or merrier, or more pensive than her wont. He dared not put to her the most distant question, grew vexed with himself, and tacitly asked her pardon for I know not what suspicions by kissing her with effusion. He thought often of Belmonte with a melancholy sweetness, and reproached himself for his selfishness. His sad past reared itself before him like the phantom of the penalty of retaliation.

CHAPTER XLV

The Contessa Armandi had returned to Florence from the beginning of winter, and by the advice of the physicians, by the obligation of her station, for amusement, to please her daughter, she had had to begin again to see people, and to be seen. Thus it was not long before she met Alberti. The Contessa was still a woman of wit even at sixty, and she had not thought of replacing, as she had her teeth, the claws that had fallen from her. She embraced Adele as her best friend, saw Alberti again as if they had parted the day before—and she said to him besides:

“It takes a good deal of courage to tell you that I am really the Armandi of twenty years ago, does it not? Friends who grow old far apart ought never to see one another again. You have changed as well, you know.”

“And you loved that woman,” Adele said to him, between bantering and sulky, when they were at home, standing before the chimney-glass—he had looked at himself in it a long while for the first time. He had thought of it as well, and was a little moody that evening; Adele had tried to dissipate the slight cloud; he smiled gently, still thoughtful, and said to her:

“Who knows whether in a few years you will not think the same of me?”

“Wicked! oh, wicked!” exclaimed the wife with impetuosity, throwing herself upon his neck.

Those two words of the Armandi's had nevertheless cast a great disturbance into Alberto's heart. All the follies of the past filed before him, ironical, mocking, absurd, ridiculous, taking on the physiognomy of that flabby, toothless mistress with the gray hair; he was compelled to ask himself what his feelings would have been now if the Armandi, instead of leaving him like a worn-out glove in an avenue of Turin, had gone on always loving him; if gratitude, duty, honor still bound him to that woman! All that he had felt for her would have gone, then, with the years and with beauty, since no other tie would have remained but duty, honor, and gratitude! Then he had cast his eyes upon the glass, and his thought had run at a bound to Adele. He too was changed, much changed! That doubt, that timidity, that uneasiness which had been stirring confusedly in him for some time, the Armandi had formulated neatly with her words and with her gray hair; he felt himself more changed within than outwardly; physical weariness told upon his moral prostration: all his feelings had something slack, uncertain, distrustful, except that one which was sometimes a torment—and Adele was still full of youth and beauty! His fatal spirit of analysis pushed him to fatal deductions; it seemed to him that the new feeling which filled his whole heart was an effect of that same physical and moral weariness, was that need of being restored which there is in human nature: his love was therefore the egoism of the heart, which, growing old, clings to something! But Adele, who was young and rich in affection?.... all that which had attracted or awakened the ardors of his youth must it not now attract or awaken those of hers, seduce her, make her understand to what a corpse before his time she had bound her youth? He would have renounced her rather than know her bound to him by any feeling that was not pure love. His affection for his wife became more intense, less expansive, far more timid and haughty.

Adele perceived sometimes what passed through her husband's head like a storm-cloud; she divined the disturbance that from time to

time convulsed that soul, and did not know to what to attribute it. She too became uneasy, fearful, and somewhat shrinking at times. She feared that her husband's restless spirits might awaken, and that he himself, combating them from the duty of an honest man, might not be able to help regretting in secret the liberty he had lost, and the adventurous life of former days. She too therefore had become a little melancholy, and sometimes even peevish. She would have liked to put a mute upon her husband's memory, as she could put her hands over his eyes if she wished, to keep him from seeing those other beautiful women of whom she was jealous; and then, out of a certain little pride of woman, and also out of a little wifely ambition, she would have liked to discharge upon someone, a dear someone yet to come, the responsibility of that mission. "If we had a child!" she would say to him under her breath, hiding her burning face against his breast.

He bent his head and was silent; once he answered with that smile all his own:

"You have wished to tempt Heaven, you see, Adele mine!"

In that time Gemmati had returned to Florence from a long scientific journey, and Adele had given her husband, jestingly, that news gathered in the drawing-rooms she frequented, together with the praises of the young man of science.

"Must we run away from Florence now?" he asked, laughing.

"We must invite him to dinner tomorrow, and I must get him to forgive the wrongs I have done him."

Gemmati had forgiven those wrongs, known or not, with one of those pressures of the hand which harmonized with his open and loyal face. He had seen Adele again without feigned simplicity, without affected reserve: after the first pressure of the hand, all three felt that they had nothing more to hide from one another, nothing to reproach, and they breathed freely.

“Do you know I have been jealous of you!” Alberto said to him when they were alone a moment.

“It would not have been the first time,” answered Gemmati, laughing; “do you remember the barber’s daughter at Prato? and now, after all, it is my turn to be jealous of you! Are you happy?” he added, seeing the Marchesa come in again.

“Yes,” answered Alberto with a certain liveliness.

Gemmati had a thousand things to tell of his travels, and his talk was full of spirit and of interest. The evening passed like a flash, in a sweet and tranquil intimacy, and brought into the conversation the recollection of the most beautiful evenings at Belmonte. Gemmati had become a handsome man, of energetic and virile features; he seemed to have acquired in an active and laborious life all that Alberti had wasted in his soft and stormy one. The Marchese had perhaps contemplated him with that feeling, while Gemmati talked with his wife, and when he had gone, Adele said:

“He is still young! is he not, Alberto?”

The Marchesa Alberti’s health was always delicate, and in summer the physicians prescribed that she should flee Florence. She was accustomed to go to Montecatini, to Viareggio, or to Leghorn. That year Leghorn was chosen.

“Are you coming too?” Alberto had asked Gemmati.

“I cannot. I have spent all my little fortune on my travels, and now I must be prudent. I am beginning to make myself a decent practice; do you know how we doctors are, especially at the beginning of a career? I could not leave Florence for a week without undoing what I have done so far.”

Leghorn that year was a fashionable watering-place; the hotels and the villas overflowed with visitors; never had the Ardenza and the Cavalleggeri been more crowded with elegant equipages. The same day that the Marchesa Alberti took up her quarters in the apartment

reserved beforehand by telegraph at the Hotel of Great Britain, there arrived from Berne at the same hotel one of those gypsy couples of the great world who roam through all the watering-places of Europe marked by fashion—the Prince and Princess Metelliani.

The Princess was accustomed to arrive everywhere like a queen, and to stretch out without opposition her fan like a sceptre. She was therefore wounded in the quick of her self-love on meeting at Leghorn a rival preferred, fawned upon, courted more than herself, and who besides did not seem to care for her triumph, or enjoyed it with ease as a thing naturally due to her—and who, then? that same little woman whom she had always eclipsed by the mere reflection of her blond hair! that pale, thin little figure, all eyes, who had those eyes only for her husband, and whom all those imbeciles of the Ardenza and the Cavalleggeri adored from afar like so many Don Quixotes. That very rag of a husband she herself had left her, when she had no longer known what to do with him; had it been only a question of him, she would have continued to be Adele's best friend, and besides—apart from the Prince, who in Velleda's existence had never counted as anything but a prince—her old lover had truly become a rag of a man; but now she bore her a grudge as well because that husband of hers, rag or no, whom she had bestowed upon her, who had loved her so much, her, the beautiful Manfredini!—whom she too had perhaps loved, perhaps!—should have consoled himself with that Adele of all people! should have so consoled himself as not to fall at her feet the first time he had seen her again at Pancaldi's!—she, the proud beauty who wore a princess's crown! If Adele had stolen that crown from her, she would not have done her a greater despite. The serene indifference of that rival, in love only with her husband, vexed her as well—whether it were pride, unconcern, or coquetry, they irritated, wounded, humiliated her pride, her vanity, her coquetry. Had she thought of it, she would have wished to strike that rival in the only side she showed vulnerable, in that rag of a

husband whom she—today's vanquished woman!—had thrown at her feet like alms.

For the rest, these two rivals belonged to the same society, they had been friends, they knew how to live well enough not to make a spectacle of their intimate feelings to the curious, to the envious, to the crowd, and to press each other's hands, from the very first time, with the most graceful smile. Velleda and Alberto met, greeted each other, spoke to each other in the same manner, with the same ease. She said that they had ended as they had begun—and really she was not ill-pleased that they had ended in that way.

The two friends and rivals lodged in the same hotel, on the same floor, door opposite door; they saw each other often, they met every day on the same promenade and at the same resorts. One evening when at Pancaldi's a large supper had been got up among several people, at which Adele had shone more than usual, and the Princess had been more than usually bored, while the gay company issued in a body to take a walk by moonlight, Velleda, without knowing how, had found herself last, next to Alberti; she cast him a singular glance, and then said to him, placing herself resolutely at his side:

“After all.... truly.... why should you not give me your arm?”

And they had begun to talk of this and that; then in parting she had said to him in that same tone:

“You see that we are better off this way.... than the other.”

And from that day she had set about paying court to Alberto.

Alberto had perceived it, and felt from it a secret satisfaction, a little from the instinct of an old lion that wishes to try his fangs still, but principally from a strange feeling that had reference to his wife; he was jealous without daring to confess it to Adele and to himself, and he felt a singular masculine coquetry in letting his wife glimpse, and in proving to himself, that he was still preferred to all those Ganymedes who wearied him. He was not displeased either that his

wife should fear a little for him, since he feared for her, and he too wished to lay something at her feet, one of those preferences that so flatter a woman's self-love.

Adele had begun to perceive as well the trick that the Metelliani meant to play her; but she shrank from complaints, from observations, from scenes, out of natural pride, or out of fear of the character of that husband who imposed constraint upon her, and she had shut herself up in her dignity as a wife with such a little spite as seemed ease.

Meanwhile things went forward because the Metelliani pushed them, because Alberto, without positively lending a hand, closed his eyes and let them go—and let them go also from a false fear of seeming ridiculous if he had played the puritan—and they went forward at last because Adele did nothing to keep them from going.

One day Alberti, arriving a little late at Pancaldi's, met the Princess.

"Your wife is out there," she said to him, with a slight tinge of mockery, indicating upon the sea a little boat laden with parasols, straw hats, and fluttering veils.

"Will you have us go and join her?"

The Marchese answered some insignificant word, and sat down beside her: after some talk he asked her why she had not gone as well.

"I might tell you it was because I was waiting for you, but I do not wish to flatter you. I have raced so much on steamers that the sea wearies me even from a little boat. You have traveled a great deal as well, I know."

And they set about talking of travels.

"Who would have told us that we should have to run so far to meet again... at Pancaldi's!" she said, laughing.

She had said this in a certain way, and with such an accent as to recall to him perfectly the point from which they had set out to run, and she had made him see it again in such a manner that Alberto had fallen silent.

“You did not promise to turn out so good a husband, truly!” she said to him a little after, with a capricious leap of thought.

Alberto answered the ironical compliment with an ironical inclination of the head.

“Frankly.... without a shadow of flattery.... if I could have foreseen it... I should not perhaps call myself Metelliani.”

“You see that sometimes it is better not to foresee!”

“Marchesa Alberti is a fine name. And then everyone calls you the model husband. Don’t take it amiss; it is a very beautiful thing to be in love with one’s own wife. Is it true that you are in love with your wife? Do you know that I should almost have the right to be jealous of your wife? Let us hear, Marchese, what would you say if I were jealous of your wife?”

Alberto was still struggling against her fascination.

“I should tell you that you were wrong,” he answered coldly and haughtily.

She rose from her seat.

“Frankly, sir, if I were not Metelliani, I should like to be Marchesa Alberti. Will you see me to my carriage?”

Alberti bowed, gave her his arm, and they set out. After a few steps: “Will you come to the ball this evening?” asked the Princess.

“I do not know.”

“Your wife will be there too!”

“In that case I shall come to escort my wife,” he answered with calm, and without showing that he had felt the sting.

“Will you go to the four o’clock concert as well? your wife never misses it.”

“My wife knows that I flee concerts, and will excuse me.”

The Princess raised her head, and fixed her eyes upon emptiness, knitting her brows.

“So at four you will be free?” she asked after an instant, with that same smile.

“Perfectly free.”

“I have a mind to make an excursion as far as Montenero,” she resumed with liveliness; “the day is very fresh. Will you come with me at four? we shall go on horseback. Ask your wife’s leave. Shall I ask her myself?”

“My wife will be delighted...”

She stopped, cast him a glance, shook her hair still scented from the bath with a brusque movement of the head, and with a singular intonation:

“Truly? then you will come?”

“Why, yes.”

“You are not afraid?”

“Afraid of what?”

“And your wife is not jealous of me?” she said without answering, as bizarre in her talk as she was in her nature.

“No, that I know of.”

“Really? She does not tear your eyes out? she does not torment you? It is singular!”

“Really nothing of all that.”

“And if I had the intention of making your wife jealous?”

“You have too much wit...”

“In what sense? True—thank you! You will come then to meet me at four at the Cavalleggeri—But if I were?”

“Were what?”

“Jealous—what would you do?”

“I should do everything to keep you from being so...”

“More?”

“... More.”

“Until we meet again!”

CHAPTER XLVI

Alberto remained wholly undone, his head swimming, with sudden ardors running through his veins, and he avoided his wife's glances when she sprang from the boat, supporting herself upon his hand.

The Marchese had ordered his horse for half-past three. Toward that hour Adele, having dressed, was going out to the concert, and she met her husband in the drawing-room—the Marchesa's bedchamber and dressing-room were separated from her husband's apartments by that drawing-room.—Alberto was reading, or pretending to read.

"Oh, you have not gone?" she said to him.

"No, I am coming with you. Will you have me?"

"Gladly. You will not be bored, though?"

"Far from it."

At the concert all the fashionable world was present, with the exception of the Principessa Metelliani. Husband and wife had returned home toward six, when in the corridor that separated their apartment from that of the Metelliani was heard the rustle of the Principessa's riding-habit as she came back from her ride.

At dinner Alberti was a little absent, and made visible efforts not to let his preoccupation be seen; when it was time to go to the ball he begged his wife to excuse him from accompanying her.

"Why are you not coming?"

"I am tired; I have some letters to write, and besides you know I do not enjoy myself much there."

“I would give it up myself, if I had not engaged to go with Lina.”

“No, go; amuse yourself, a little for me as well.”

The Marchesa departed; a quarter of an hour later the Metelliani's carriage was heard going out as well. Then Alberti breathed freely.

He went into his little study and set himself to reading, to while away the time while waiting for his wife, and also to distract himself a little.—As that state of agitation in which he had been all day after the first dizziness gradually subsided, through the ideas that the reading was awakening in him there returned, with a strange intermittence, the thought that preoccupied him most. At certain moments he closed his eyes, and saw Velleda as he had seen her that morning.

All at once he heard a rapid, light step in the drawing-room; the door was opened abruptly, and the Principessa entered.

She was in ball dress, wrapped in a light mantle, dazzling in her beauty.

“Has your wife forbidden you to come?” she asked with a sardonic smile.

Alberto still looked at her in surprise, without answering.

“Have you repented? Speak!”

“Yes.”

“At last!”

The Principessa did not observe that Alberti, though he had risen to his feet, did not invite her to sit down; she went resolutely toward the armchair he had left, and settled herself in it as mistress of the place.

“Why have you not even come to the ball? Were you afraid of meeting me?”

And as he did not answer, she added:

“You have done a fine thing, Marchese Alberti!” After an instant of painful struggle he said resolutely:

"I have forgiven you—forgive me!"

"Ah! you have forgiven me?—What, pray?"

"The confusion you have thrown into my mind, the agitation you have made me feel beside my wife... the blush I am forced to endure before you. Does all that not seem enough to you?"

"No!" she exclaimed with an indefinable accent. "There is something more... or worse, as you will.... that I have thrown myself at your head, that you have perhaps laughed at it with your wife, and that I am here!.... What do you think of that, Marchese?"

He gazed in astonishment at that formidable beauty, quivering with anger and spiteful coquetry—whose bare arms stood out, unknown to themselves, against the dark velvet of the armchair.

"What do you think a woman can do in such a situation?"

Alberto lowered his eyes before those flashing eyes.

"Luckily I am a woman of spirit—you have said so—and you too.... and I have no need to ask you whether you are certain that your self-love has not played you a scurvy trick.—Farewell, sir; since you want my forgiveness, I give it to you with both hands. Say nothing to your wife. What would she think if she knew that I have been here, here itself, after midnight, I, your former mistress?.... since we have loved each other, is it not so?—But truly!—she would be wrong—truly!"

She had risen in all the beauty of her elegant person, ironic, provocative, mocking, with her marble shoulders, her superb bosom, her sinuous gown, like a thing itself animate and seductive, and was about to go.—He, who had not spoken another word, seized one of her hands with violence, then the other. She, caught by that grasp, flung back her whole quivering person.

The Principessa opened the door with a dry, nervous pull; she flung Alberto a handshake without turning, and crossed the drawing-room rapidly. Alberto, coming back from seeing her out, still

confused and overturned, saw a light in his wife's room. He remained an instant standing in the middle of the drawing-room, disturbed, surprised, hesitating; then he knocked timidly at the door, which was only ajar. He found Adele before the mirror, in the act of taking down her hair without her maid's help, pale, disturbed herself; hearing Alberto enter she turned with a start.

"You have come back.... already!...." he said, avoiding looking at her.

She too lowered her eyes.

"Yes," she answered gently.

"How long?...."

"A little while.... half an hour...."

He took a few steps about the room.

"Shall we leave tomorrow?" he asked then.

She bowed her head. The Marchese went out.

CHAPTER XLVII

What a terrible night for poor Adele! Not only had she received a bitter wound to her heart and her self-love, but the whole edifice of her happiness was crumbling; that man who was everything to her was slipping from her, swept away in the whirlwind of those passions that had been so formidable for him, and that made him formidable to others.

She had not wept, she had not complained; the next morning she rose as she had gone to bed the night before without closing an eye, pale, feverish, and calmly made the preparations for departure.

During the journey they exchanged a dozen words, indifferent words, spoken in a calm tone, avoiding looking at one another, words of ice that put ice between them—she felt her heart contract, and tried at least to put a certain sweetness into them; that dignified resignation seemed to strike Alberto in the face, who felt the abyss deepening gradually between them; he felt it in his own coldness, in that I-know-not-what of embarrassed, timid, and haughty that there was, unknown to himself, in his very words.

A hundred times, in that night which was painful for him as well, he had been on the point of running to throw himself at Adele's feet and ask her pardon; but he had lacked the courage from a fatal delicacy, from a false shame, from a singular rectitude of guilt. Ask her pardon for what? for having basely betrayed her for a woman he did not esteem in the least? for having forgotten in an instant her love, the trust she had in him, their past, the days, the whole months of

intimacy, of chaste abandonment, of expansion, of a complete identification of ideas, of feelings?—for having trampled all that underfoot for blond hair and white shoulders that had thrown themselves in his face? for having insulted her vulgarly at the very door of her rooms? But to ask her that pardon—would it not have been another insult? would it not have been like asking her for a dishonorable sanction for both of them? a confessing oneself lower than the fault? Henceforth could he still tell her that he loved her still, that he had never ceased to love her—and it was true!—without feeling the blushes rise to his face? and could he believe that she had forgotten, and still loved him, without suspecting that she too was lying? When one falls one must at least have the strength not to dash one's face into the mud.

Arrived in Florence, he put forward some affairs of business, and left for the country; thus he withdrew himself for the moment from the torment of appearing before her in those hours they were accustomed to spend together. She felt a great pain, a great fear of that man's character, a great dread of crossing him, and made not the slightest observation.

Alberti had said that he would be gone a week or two, and he was gone three months. In this time Adele had fallen ill, far more gravely than she herself suspected, and had written to him of it as of a passing indisposition. He inquired after her every day by telegraph, but did not return. Besides, the news he received was always more reassuring; the Marchesa seemed entirely recovered.

From then on the Marchese wrote often to his wife, and often received letters from her. For the most part they were insignificant letters—or too significant—containing nothing but the cold formulas of conjugal courtesy, respectful and dry on his part, timid and reserved on hers. From time to time a thought coiled (this is the fitting word, for it was a serpent) through Alberto's mind: what would become of that treasure of affection that was in his Adele, now that through his fault it had been violently turned away from him? where

would it turn? upon what... or upon whom, and in what way? Then he would venture to insinuate into his letters some phrase that lent itself to an affectionate interpretation, and would seek in Adele's replies the reflection of the feeling he experienced.

Gemmati, having learned that the Marchesa Alberti had returned from Leghorn, although she had given no sign of life, had gone to call on her, and had been struck by the profound alteration visible in her appearance. After a few days Adele had fallen truly ill; Gemmati had attended her like a sister or like a daughter, and, while concealing from her the gravity of the illness, had insisted that Alberto be informed of it. The pretexts at first, and then the obstinate refusals of the Marchesa, had surprised him, and he had not been long in perceiving that something serious must have occurred; knowing Alberto intimately, he was dismayed by it more than Adele herself was.

Before yielding to the great need she felt of unburdening herself, of being comforted, of leaning upon a friendly hand, Adele had struggled much, out of delicacy, out of a feeling of dignity, of respect and of love toward her husband; but little by little something had escaped her at last; Gemmati had understood the rest, and from then on had shown himself more reserved, and more discreetly affectionate. He went to see her often, for he felt that giving her occasion to speak of him did her good, and that that poor trembling, sick heart needed to be heartened by a friendly voice; he would say a few words to her, of those he knew would help her, or remain silent, patiently listening to her disjointed and feverish talk, or her eloquent silence. She had ended by having him read Alberto's letters, so cold, so measured, and she would ask him for advice or for flatteries. She showed herself so happy when Gemmati told her that Alberto would come back to loving her, that he told her so often. The friend did her more good than the physician. She recovered indeed, or seemed to have recovered.

At last one rainy evening, toward the end of October, Alberti returned to Florence, and arrived at his house almost unexpectedly.

At the announcement of him Adele had started up suddenly to her feet, all the blood had rushed to her face, and seeing him enter she had sunk trembling back into the armchair, while the flush and the pallor alternated rapidly upon her cheeks. Gemmati observed these symptoms with an uneasy eye, and remained preoccupied. Alberti was surprised at the welcome that was given him, and seemed to halt an instant on the threshold, and to dart a rapid, deep glance at his wife and at Gemmati. Then he had gone to press her hand, had pressed his friend's as well, and had sat down and begun to talk of what he had been doing, and of indifferent things, with an absent air. Gemmati too had shown himself a little cold toward the Marchese, whose conduct his loyal nature could not excuse. Alberto's arrival had evidently thrown ice into the conversation, which proceeded coldly and as best it could. After about a quarter of an hour Alberto pleaded a great weariness and withdrew.

The next day he went to see his wife, and inquired more particularly after her health.

"And Gemmati... do you see him often?"

"Yes."

"Ah!"—and he spoke of something else.

He told her of the abundant vintage, and of the Sassosa, the famous Sassosa, and of the improvements made, the dispositions given, the pleasant occupations he had found in the country.

"And you?" he asked her. "How have you spent your time?"

"Well... well enough."

"You are very pale, you know! You must have been worse than you wrote me."

"I am better now."

"And Gemmati is your physician?..."

“Yes.”

“They say he is a good physician. He has always been a man of talent.”

“It is quite true; in a few months here in Florence he has made himself a very fine reputation.”

“And patients?”

“Many.”

“You must be doubly grateful to him in that case for his as-siduity...”—she timidly raised her eyes to his marble face—“yet I find it strange... truly!... that he should not have notified me of the gravity of your illness... very strange!” said Alberto, going out.

Adele had remained confused, dismayed, trembling; in the midst of all this vague disturbance there stole, like a ray of sun among the sad mists of her soul, the hope that in that heart of stone there was still something living that stirred for her. From then on she ventured timidly to let him too perceive something of that new feeling of hers, of that delicious hope. Alberto would turn a surprised, penetrating, thoughtful glance upon her, at those moving hesitations, those bashful and timid surrenders, those repressed impulses, that trembled in her look, or vibrated in her voice, or blazed in her sudden blushes. He too had those hesitations, those absences of mind; the ice was melting, and the doubt was vanishing. He too would catch himself remaining longer than usual beside her after dinner, and no longer seeking with such labor the most ordinary subjects for the meager official conversation of those hours, or being no longer so embarrassed if silence surprised them both, with their eyes fixed on the flame of the hearth; at certain moments his heart would give a sort of leap in his breast, the word would choke in his throat, and he would turn upon her his absent, deep eyes. One evening after taking coffee they had remained longer than usual beside the fire, she as if absorbed in that silence and deliciously disturbed, he abstracted, poking the brands

with the tongs. For some time even the rare words had come to an end; husband and wife no longer needed to speak to each other; nothing remained for them but to clasp those hands which more than once had reached out unawares, when a visitor was announced and the servant announced Gemmati.

Alberto started, rose abruptly, and took two or three steps, drawing away from his wife with animation. Then he came back; his face had resumed its usual marble mask. At that movement of her husband's she had gone the color of live coals.

"Show him in," said the Marchese, since his wife gave no order.

"Am I driving you away?" Gemmati asked him, holding out his hand.

"On the contrary," Alberti answered, without noticing the gesture and sitting down again in the little armchair.—"There!"

The conversation turned upon indifferent things. Despite the great power of dissimulation that Alberto possessed, there flashed from time to time in his words a spiteful irony at himself and at others. Adele, stunned by the light that had suddenly broken in her ideas, was often silent, often thoughtful, and seemed embarrassed. Gemmati felt the effect his visit had produced, and was embarrassed too, without knowing too well himself why. Among them all Alberto alone showed himself the most bitterly at ease. As sometimes happens, by dint of trying to stun the common preoccupation by wandering over the most disparate subjects, the conversation had slipped precisely onto the burning ground of gallant chronicle, and they were speaking of a famous duel in which a husband had been in the wrong, a duel that was then furnishing the staple of conversation in all the gatherings of the city. Adele was on thorns; Gemmati himself understood that he had made a blunder; but Alberto gave no sign of noticing.

"And you?" he asked Gemmati a little later; "do you not think of taking a wife as well?"

"At least not so far...."

"Are you afraid of being in the wrong in a duel?"

"No, because I have no faith in those reparations, and I would not fight."

"You are right," said Alberto very seriously, after an instant of reflection. "In the end, if honor has no natural foundation, it too is a social convention... a false thing... why fight?"

"Are you convinced of that?" Gemmati asked him, ironic in his turn.

"Perfectly," Alberti answered calmly.

After Gemmati had gone, Alberti remained still lost in thought; then he took his leave of his wife.

Seeing him go out, Adele was two or three times on the point of throwing her arms about his neck, weeping, and saying to him: "Oh, Alberto!..." But her husband's words, his look, his smile, his countenance froze the blood in her veins.

The next morning husband and wife's breakfast was silent. They exchanged barely the indispensable words of courtesy, and as soon as he had risen from table Alberti said to his wife:

"Are you not going this evening to the ball at the Rossis'?"

"No," Adele answered thoughtfully.

"You go nowhere any more!... it is singular!"

"If you wish it..."

"I wish nothing. This shutting yourself up in the house seems to me unseemly, barely pardonable in a woman in love... You are beginning to make our honeymoon ridiculous, my dear!... and you know well that I am not to blame for it."

And he went out.

CHAPTER XLVIII

Adele remained stunned; the blood blazed in her face, and she ran in a fury to her rooms.

Alberto had gone out, gnawed himself by fever, by spite, by rage: he went at random, almost without seeing, and turned back upon his steps, driven by an invincible craving. Then he did a thing that he himself would have believed impossible; he set himself to spy upon his wife.

The Marchesa had written a very short note to Gemmati, telling him that she needed to speak with him. Gemmati came during the evening, uneasy at that dry, terse little letter that said nothing and left much to be guessed. He found Adele with her eyes unusually bright, but pale and worn, and touching her hand: "You have a fever!" he exclaimed.

She did not hear him. After an instant of hesitation, she said to him resolutely:

"My friend... we must not see each other any more."

"Why?"

Adele turned red, with an air of modest triumph. "My husband is jealous!"

"Of me!"

"Of whom else could he be?" she said, lowering her eyes and her voice, as if a spark of those mysteries that unknown to us hide

themselves in the darkness of the soul had suddenly flashed to the surface.

“And you.... are you glad that he is jealous?” Gemmati asked in a low voice.

“Yes!” the Marchesa answered softly, with the egoism of those in love; and a smile irradiated her.

“What would you have me do?”

“Let us avoid seeing each other.”

“What will he think?... that you have warned me!...”

“It is true!...”

“That weak and sickly soul will always doubt.... Perhaps it would be worse... Something more must be done.”

“What?”

After a brief silence he said to her timidly:

“Will you be grateful to me for what I shall do for you?”

She pressed his hand, and lowered her eyes. They remained an instant absorbed. At that moment Alberto entered.

Adele withdrew her hand quickly. The Marchese barely looked at them, saw Gemmati moved, and traces of tears in his wife’s eyes; he sat down.

“I have come to say goodbye to you,” said Gemmati, breaking first that glacial silence.

“You are leaving?”

“Yes.”

“For where?”

“I am going to Naples.”

Adele grew pale. “There is cholera in Naples!” she said with animation.

"I am a physician, and I have important studies to make upon cholera."

"And you will stay... a long time?"

"I shall settle there."

"And your practice in Florence?"

"I shall make myself another down there..."

The Marchesa had not opened her mouth again.

Gemmati, without any exaggeration, bade her farewell with simplicity. Alberti accompanied him to the door, and shook his hand quite in the English fashion.

"Late or not, it is a fine action that Gemmati is doing!" he said, sitting down again beside his wife, who was motionless and white as a statue. She raised her eyes to him as if she had not quite understood.

"And speaking of departure.... I have come to tell you... I am leaving too."

Adele, continuing to fix him with wide, astonished eyes, petrified with grief, stammered:

"Forever?"

"Who has said that it is forever? I am not going to devote myself to cholera patients... I have resolved to travel a little."

"Oh! Alberto!" exclaimed the forsaken woman, in an ineffable voice, letting herself fall upon her knees.

He lifted her with a hand of iron. "Do not abase yourself!" he said to her coldly, "and do not abase me!"

The poor creature remained petrified by that incisive, hard, inexorable look, and felt the abyss that had opened between them.

They had not spoken another word, and the first news of the Marchese had come from Munich. Meanwhile Adele had fallen more gravely ill. At the beginning of spring, flattered by an appearance of convalescence, she had left for Belmonte. Her husband, who had not

failed to inquire after her, had approved the resolution, and had promised that as soon as he returned to Italy he would go to see her.

Meanwhile he did not return, and Adele's illness, after several fictitious improvements, had declared itself in all its gravity. She was dying of the disease that had snatched her mother from her; the old physician, who had known her from a child, began to make her understand that he did not intend to take upon himself alone the responsibility of so difficult a treatment, and asked for a consultation.

The Marchesa said neither yes nor no; she remained pensive, and no one ever knew what she did in the long hours she shut herself in her room. At last she answered the doctor who was insisting upon the consultation: "It seems to me that my husband's opinion should be asked...."

The good doctor did not understand the timid desire the sick woman had of recalling Alberto under that pretext, and of having him near her in those last painful days of trial. He went away shaking his head, and muttering: "Provided the answer itself is not made to wait...."

She was waiting! Meanwhile the disease was devouring her rapidly, and soon her strength failed her. Several times, seeing no letter arrive from her husband, she set herself to write to him, and had not the courage; later she had not even the strength. Then she was seized by an unspeakable fear, and for the first time let her tears escape in the physician's presence.

"Would it not be time to notify my husband?...."

"I thought she had already written.... and I am truly astonished!.... But I shall telegraph this very day...."

"Telegraph!...." she murmured: she said no more, and remained looking at the pale November sun that was setting upon the windowpanes.

Unfortunately the doctor's telegram did not find the Marchese in Berlin, where it was believed that he was: so that it lost precious time chasing after him through all the little towns of Germany. When at last it was delivered to him, Alberto lost no time and returned at once to Italy.

In Florence he found a second dispatch signed by his wife. He was worn out with fatigue and it was pouring; he had himself taken by a special train as far as Pistoia, and from Pistoia, by carriage, he set out for Belmonte.

CHAPTER XLIX

It was drizzling; the countryside was bare; the wheels of the carriage sank into the muddy road that the horses climbed with difficulty. Alberto watched mechanically the dripping of the rain upon the glasses; the slow, slow strokes of the Ave Maria were heard, and from time to time, according as the road turned, the ringing, now sharp and now muffled, of a little bell that seemed to have been pursuing Alberto for some time.

“Well?” he asked, opening the carriage-door abruptly.

“The horses can do no more.”

“Kill them!”

But as if the sound of that word had struck him, he cast a glance at the poor beasts steaming and dripping with rain, and flung himself back into the depths of the coach.

The familiar trees that flanked the road filed slowly past the windows, and greeted him sadly, bowing their heads with a low murmur. The carriage passed the gate; a little later the Marchese pressed his face to the glass to see a fountain that was falling into ruin. The carriage turned into the avenue and stopped.

“Already!” murmured Alberto.

No one had run to open the carriage-door; he sprang to the ground. The villa seemed uninhabited; all the windows were shut, the branches were stripped of leaves, and the rain fell slow and

monotonous. The little bell that had been heard along the ascent was heard again. Alberto knocked resolutely.

An unknown servant came to open to him and asked him what he wanted, as if he were a stranger: but the Marchese pushed the servant by the shoulders with a master's manner that left no doubt, and went straight to Adele's rooms. Before he had even reached them a strong and singular odor was felt; the door was ajar, and neither speaking nor stirring was heard in the room. Alberto opened hesitantly, and stopped on the threshold.

The room was almost dark; facing the door two candles burned upon a little table covered with a white cloth; on the other side was the bed, which seemed empty, screened from the scanty light by a fan. Under the covers an indistinct form was vaguely modeled, and on the pillow, barely depressed, two thick black braids stood out, framing a face whiter than the cambric upon which it rested; the eyes, on that white and wasted face, seemed two enormous dark circles, that produced a fascinating effect. On a small table beside the bed there was a heap of little utensils of silver and crystal that glittered; opposite the bed, with its back to the door, an armchair was seen, and a wholly white head that rose above the back against which it leaned. All those things wrung the heart.

The sick woman, seeing that shadow in the opening of the door, turned her head painfully, started, and made a languid movement to stretch out her hand, forming her lips into a pale smile.

"Thank you!" she murmured, in a voice that sent a shiver through his veins.

"How are you?...."

"You see."

He turned his eyes upon that white cloth, as if he had not yet seen it, and looked at it so long that Adele silently pressed the hand she held in his.

The physician had risen. "The good doctor!" said Adele. Alberto pressed his hand strongly.

"It is the second time you see me in this room!" he said to him with a singular smile. "Do you remember?"

"A long time ago, though!"

"Yes, a long time!"

And he stood looking at Adele, motionless and white in her white bed. From time to time he let a wild glance run over the coverlet, as if seeking there her body which was lost in it, and convulsively pressed her hand, as if to make sure that she was still there, and that it was not a horrible dream. Adele breathed with difficulty; the embroideries of her bodice seemed to stir like butterflies. After that long look, and a longer silence: "I want to see you!" he said at last.

Adele turned her head in a weary attitude. He laid his trembling hand upon the fan and turned it; then the candlelight fell upon the sick woman's face. He remained fascinated.

He did not weep, he did not say a word; he gazed at her fixedly like a spectre, and pressed her hand as if another hand of iron were pressing his heart; it seemed that with his eyes he was seeking avidly for something, something that was there no longer, and that made his reason waver.

She read it all in his face, and two tears ran slowly down her cheeks.

"Do you not know me any more?" she said at last in an extinguished voice. He did not answer.

"It is strange!" he murmured then dully and with a terrible calm. "I love you as I have never loved you!"

All at once the little bell he had heard along the road was heard ringing very near. The doctor rose.

“It is the horses’ bells!” Alberto hastened to say, without knowing too well why. No one answered him. An old servant entered softly, and set two vases of flowers upon the white table.

“What are you doing?” asked Alberto. The old woman remained undecided, not knowing what to say. Adele silently pressed his hand. “Will those flowers not harm her in the room?” he asked the doctor.

The latter shook his head sadly; Alberto fell silent.

The ringing of the little bell, which for a moment had been silent, sounded in the anteroom, and seemed to draw nearer from room to room, together with a shuffling of feet and a low murmuring. Alberto had instinctively taken a step backward, as if he felt himself pursued; then, all at once, he tore his hand from Adele’s, with an inexplicable movement, retreated to the middle of the room, and remained standing, pale, dark, his eye fixed on the door, fascinated.

The priest entered, the sacristan, two or three peasants; the Marchese looked as in a dream at all those people who were entering thus into his house, and approaching his wife’s bed; he saw them move exactly like the images of a dream, silent, mysterious, muttering words and making signs he did not understand; the bed was flooded with light, his wife said nothing, and he no longer saw her. Then all those people went away with the same funereal shuffling, with the same murmur of low words, leaving a singular odor he had never smelled. Adele remained lying on the bed, her hands crossed upon her breast, her eyes turned toward him, and she smiled at him serenely.

“Now leave me to confess with my wife!” Alberto said suddenly to the two or three persons who were present.

He remained a long while hidden among the bed-curtains, holding her head in his arms. He was not seen to move; not a sob or a word was heard; no one knew what that man had said to that dying woman.

When he raised his head and came out from the shadow of the hangings, he was paler than she, and his eyes were burning.

"She is sleeping!" he said softly to the doctor, gently leaving her hand.

No other sound was heard save the rain beating upon the panes. He went and leaned his forehead against them, looking into the dark. After some time he approached the physician, and asked him in a low voice:

"Well, doctor?"

The doctor did not answer. Then Alberto, in a voice still more choked: "Will she suffer much?"

"No."

"And will it be tonight?"

"Tomorrow at the latest."

He turned upon the clock a look that cannot be described.

"Do you believe that griefs.... may have killed her?" he asked then.

"Hers is an hereditary disease, of those that do not pardon.... Griefs can only have hastened its development...."

"The assassin too does nothing but hasten!" interrupted the Marchese, in the same calm and deep tone, letting himself fall into an armchair facing the physician—and he remained with his eyes fixed upon her who was sleeping her last sleep.

"She must have need of rest," the doctor resumed a little later, gently. "Take advantage of this brief hour while the sick woman sleeps...."

"And when I shall no longer be able to see her?"

The old man bowed his head.

"It seems to me impossible that I should never see her again!" Alberto murmured then as if to himself.

And an instant later:

“What will become of her, doctor?”

The latter raised a finger toward heaven. Alberto turned his eyes there too, following that gesture mechanically. Then, fixing upon the physician a singular look:

“You are not a materialist, doctor?”

“I am not a man of science; I am a poor country doctor. I have been present at many such moments, and I have seen much sorrow....”

“Have you seen persons dear to you die?”

“Yes!”

“It must be so!” murmured Alberti, after a few instants of meditation.

And he remained with his forehead in his hands, and his elbows on his knees.

From time to time the sick woman was agitated by convulsive shocks, and trembled all over; she seemed tormented even in sleep by an arcane anguish. Then Alberto would raise his head, fix upon her his eyes burning with fever, and when her breathing grew calmer, would lower them to the ground again.

Suddenly he was shaken by a death-rattle; the dying woman began to toss her head upon the pillow and called Alberto with an inarticulate sound. He sprang to his feet, and took her hand, which was cold as marble.

“Doctor!” he exclaimed in an agitated voice.

The physician took the pulse, and let it fall again without saying anything.

“Is she suffering?”

“For a little while....”

The dying woman fixed upon him her eyes that were growing dim. The rattle grew more choked, and the anguish more spasmodic. "What a long night?" murmured Alberto, wiping the sweat from his forehead.

The cow-bells of the herds going to pasture began to be heard. The Marchese raised his head as if waking, and saw confusedly that the windowpanes were beginning to grow white. In the pale light of dawn Adele's face seemed livid; she was supine, motionless, with her sharpened face and dimmed eyes. "Adele!" murmured Alberto, bending over her; she lifted her eyelids with difficulty. "I am here, Adele!" he repeated—one of those senseless phrases that anguish wrings from us. The poor creature's white lips stirred.

"Doctor, does she hear me?" exclaimed Alberto, with an immense emotion in his voice, questioning the physician with anxious eyes; the latter lowered his and did not answer—the strong man understood all the ridiculousness of his hope.

Adele began to tremble again. The physician took the Marchese by the arm, and wished to lead him away. He turned upon him a deep look.

"Do not be afraid!" he said.

"Afraid?" answered the old man, shrugging his shoulders.

A shiver ran through the dying woman's whole body. Alberto took almost mechanically the crucifix that was at the head of the bed, and placed it between her icy hands—the face grew sharp in profile, the muscles of the chin and mouth relaxed—and she remained motionless.

He looked at her, bent over her, raised himself again slowly, slowly, gently left the hands that still clasped his, and took a step backward.

The physician took his right hand.

“Doctor,” Alberto asked with frightful calm, “do you believe one can love a corpse?”

And without waiting for an answer:

“How is it that I love this poor dead woman far more than when she was beautiful as an angel?”

“And what has beauty to do with it?” answered the good physician, a little scandalized.

“Then!...”

CHAPTER L

Alberti let himself be led away from the dead woman's room. All day long he stood looking through the panes at the arbor stripped of leaves, the overturned bench, and the closed window, through whose curtains was seen, as of old, a glimmer—a funereal glimmer this time. From the little church of the graveyard, down there in the valley, melancholy strokes were heard from time to time—he would raise his head and look into the void.

Toward evening the sad procession set out. He followed it bare-headed, impenetrable and gloomy as a phantom. The little flames of the glass globes swayed, and the tassels of the funeral pall swung with the rapid descent.

When he returned from the cemetery the Marchese was alone. The stars sparkled above his head, and the moon was beginning to rise behind the mountains. He stopped at the edge of the road to contemplate a light that still shone down there beside the little church of the cemetery; he looked at the moon that was rising, the stars that sparkled above his head; then he set out slowly toward the villa.

The servants saw him cross the rooms with a firm step, pale and calm, and go toward the death-chamber.

That room was still in the same state. The ends of the candles were finishing their consumption, the windows were open, the flowers were still on the white cloth, the crucifix at the head of the bed, the little bottles on the small table. The wind came in in gusts, and made the bed-curtains flutter.

He advanced slowly, and went to touch one by one those flowers, that cloth, those pieces of furniture, to examine the little bottles; then he filled a large glass with water, brought it avidly to his lips, but set it down without drinking.

The bed was untouched, the coverlet smooth and stretched, the pillow had not a fold. He stood upright before that bed a long while, looking at it with abstracted eyes; he laid his hand with a resisted gesture upon the turning-down of the coverlet, hesitated, with fingers wrinkled and contracted, and all at once, abruptly, resolutely, pulled the coverlet down, and fell heavily at the foot of the bed with his head upon the pillow.

A pistol shot was heard.

THE END.